4+1

After Four Weddings and a Funeral

PARALLEL EDITION

I. The Wardrobe

Original

The wardrobe altered its width in the night. The change was too small for the man asleep three feet away to notice, and large enough to put the right-hand door under pressure. For ninety-four years the timber had expanded and contracted according to the rooms in which it stood. In the present room, the landlord had described the damp as atmospheric. He had declined to say what kind of atmosphere. Water entered through an imperfect window seal; wet towels hung from a chair; a cigarette had been extinguished in yesterday's tea. On the wallpaper, an irregular colony of mould occupied a space roughly the size of the letting agent's card.

Behind the wallpaper the wall had been busy for longer than the tenancy. Its plaster contained sand with remnants of shell and stone, mineral grains that had been carried by water long before there had been a bedroom or a street. A timber stud had darkened around the end of a concealed pipe. The pipe was copper, set against an iron nail with only a thin coating between them. Under recurrent damp, small differences in the metals' tendency to corrode established a slow transfer of material. Part of the nail had become something else. No repair had been made because the wall continued to stand.

Quotation version

Expansion and contraction [1139] perhaps it was too small to notice. [98] The change was conveyed in a mere hand-pressure [1475] it had stood so for eighty years and might stand for eighty more. [688] Expansion and contraction of oak and pine wood [1139] The room is damp. Mildew has got into the canvas. [1491] for the latter required an atmosphere of some kind for its operation [1316] Water sneaked in at the seal [1063] He picked up a towel and hung it over the back of a chair. [1272] damp towels thrown on the backs of chairs [1541] And mould and blight on the walls [1486]

The wallpaper was old and discoloured [1386] may be a grain of sand [1402] Most of the grains are of a clear glassy mineral called quartz. [1027] very craftily sunk and concealed in the timber of the window-frame [807] The connecting pipes are usually of iron but sometimes pipes of copper or brass are used. [739] There was a cut-iron nail, size of a six-penny nail, slightly corroded. [483] by reason of galvanic action between the gun-metal and the iron [7] iron rust [1027] Within, walls continued upright, bricks met neatly, floors were firm [688]

Original

At the edge of the damp patch a film of fungi had colonised paint, paste and cellulose from the paper. Some hyphae entered the joint between paper and plaster. Others spread into places dry enough to stop them. Colonies multiplied where water remained available and contracted when it did not. Fine spores entered the air during a change in the room's pressure, passed the curtain and were captured in the folds of Charles's clean shirt. There was neither a centre directing the process nor a single organism whose interests explained all its parts. The living growth occupied a patch of wall; the patch altered the room's air; the room was occupied by two people who called the wall dirty and had not asked what else was occurring there. A tenant who had lived there before Charles had developed a wheeze which improved after she moved out. The deposit returned to the wall after the landlord repainted it. He described the repainting as remediation. The invoice called it two coats.

A beetle larva was inside a gap behind the skirting. It had entered as an egg in a carpet pile carried up three flights of stairs by someone who had found the carpet beside a skip and thought it a bargain. The larva fed on fibres containing keratin, travelled over accumulations of hair and skin, and retreated from light. It had already consumed portions of a mouse's dried remains that had been inaccessible to the building's previous occupants. The mouse had died after entering a bait station in a neighbouring flat. A small quantity of anticoagulant remained in its tissues, though the larva neither required nor understood this fact. In the same gap, a spider's egg sac had been opened by another small animal. Most of the young never emerged. There was no notable event to mark their absence; the room's supply of small moving bodies continued to be revised by consumption, starvation, reproduction and accidental injury.

Quotation version

damp so that the paper in the attics was peeling from the walls [1462] As the whole surface of the damp paper was covered by these different fungi [288] the joints began to open and to show the white plaster of the wall [1386] Spread them in a dry shade to evaporate excessive moisture. [1413] Still, the colonies kept growing. [496] moisture is a condition favourable to the development of these plants. [288] spores are disseminated by the slightest breath of air. [288] Or the air removed could be made incandescent so no possible germ or its spores could get out. [836] through the folds of the curtain [1398] We had no sense of its purpose. [1397] no centre, no artery, no organic formation. [792] happens outside of all consciousness as rudimentary as it might be. [298] The language is that they’re many, that they’re not one, [1138] The walls of the room were smooth, and hard to the touch. [1449] She remembered the little room with dirty wall-paper [243] The day after the old tenants moved away [1386] I do think my cough has been better since I have been here. [1194] I restore the deposit. [664] It took some argument to dissuade him from repainting all of them black and green. [1101] Two coats of paint [1386]

It is only a little insect in the wood. [561] I made my way down the carpeted stairs to the street, trying to think. [1087] When tucked away in a fold of the skin of its fostering larva [442] the keratin of wool [1523] A dead mouse is placed on the branches of a tuft of thyme. [443] The mouse entered the tunnel [1296] to pursue the rats with poison [855] added an anticoagulant [835] knows nothing of the quantity of provisions needed by her larva [441] It appeared like a gigantic egg, with the small end turned toward the earth. [1400] These insects on arriving at their full size became quite soft, and then suddenly died. [288] The next few days passed without any special event to mark them. [186] In the wasted bodies of those who have suffered starvation [858] Naturally, in case of accidental injury [979]

Original

A draught carried warm air out of the window seal and drew cooler air inward. The movement was uneven. Several organisms entered the room against it; others were carried without resistance. A mite fed in the seam of the mattress on shed skin and fungal fragments. To the mite the seam offered terrain, food and repeated disturbance. It was not a small version of the room Charles inhabited, and nothing about its occupation made the mattress more domestic. When the bedroom was stripped for inspection the next year, the inspector would describe the mattress as adequate and decline to sit on it.

The house had been insulated with government assistance. Contractors had sealed several visible gaps and left an older opening behind the bath. The work reduced one kind of heat loss and intensified a problem with trapped moisture. A recommendation to improve ventilation appeared in a letter sent to the landlord. The landlord forwarded it to the tenants, explaining that the property could only remain affordable if everyone did their part. In the winter he added twelve pounds to the rent to cover increased costs. The ventilation letter was useful evidence of his concern and was kept in a drawer where the damp couldn't reach it.

Charles sometimes put a finger against the wall while searching for the light switch. Its surface felt cool. The sensation told him nothing of the activity beneath. Most mornings he barely noticed the wall. There were several mornings when he looked at it and considered calling the landlord, then looked at his watch instead. Such hesitation had been sufficient to postpone other things in his life. The fungal growth required no account of his temperament to continue.

A line of varnish had lifted near the hinge. The wood beneath was lighter. Three brass screws held the hinge; one had begun to work loose. Behind the door a moth moved across a wool coat. Dust settled on the rail, part of it from the wardrobe. The brass had passed through furnaces and dies; the wool had been washed, spun, dyed and cut. Charles would send the coat for cleaning only when it became unwearable. The processes had different beginnings and would have different ends.

Quotation version

There was a cold damp draught from the window [399] warm air escapes from the room through the window. [440] uneven and with no sure foothold [426] But there was still ... resistance. [1175] There is not resistance, as in the others. [1501] living parasites, small mites [1056] The food is found, at least for the time being. [445] some wilder and more secret animal that had never submitted to man's rule, yet lived almost unglimpsed amongst him [819] The attendant stooped over the bed, to ascertain; and nodded in the affirmative. [377] No, I prefer to stand [1055]

Being maintained at the public expense [211] Behind a ragged curtain a second room was partly visible. [372] It just seemed to suck the heat out of everything. [822] Doors for ventilation were slowly opening and shutting. [1541] The other tenants ought to send me a vote of thanks. [1168] the landlord said he couldn’t afford it. [971] raised the rent [1386] Again she examined the “letter,” folded it and locked it in a drawer. [1417]

He felt along the wall for a light switch and found it. [1084] But my hand on the chair-arm felt it to be cool as before. [323] the true mystery of the wall, marked with the hieroglyphs of cracks and scratches [1222] You can know something and never think about it [752] he might call upon his landlord [1538] Instead, he took his watch from his pocket [95] He looked at his watch. [734] But it was invariably postponed, he never understood—and yet somehow he did understand. [863] But both of these factors must be provided before the fungus can make its characteristic growth. [1364]

The varnish disappeared from the eyes. [1537] It became lighter. [239] One of the screws was loose [945] He pushed open the door and began to shrug off his worn coat. [935] Part of them settled into dust, drifting down the corridor. [374] The wool is dyed after washing and scouring, and before drying. [1523] And better have that coat cleaned [1099] the processes presented a widely different appearance. [337]

Original

At eight forty-three the alarm clock sounded. Its casing vibrated against a bedside table which had been made from a different species of tree, grown in another country, cut to standard dimensions and sold in a flat package. At eight forty-four the clock stopped. Charles had struck it with his hand without achieving consciousness. At nine seventeen the telephone rang.

'Yes,' he said, answering it. 'Yes. I'm in the car.'

'You're in bed,' said Scarlett.

'I'm practically in the car.'

'Angus is getting married in forty-three minutes.'

Charles looked at the clock. It had been pushed backwards. He sat up so violently that the fitted sheet detached from a corner of the mattress.

'Why didn't you wake me?'

'I did. You told me you'd been elected to something.'

He put down the telephone and opened the wardrobe. The swollen door resisted; he pulled harder; the loose screw lifted farther from its hole. A dark suit fell against him. The wool coat dropped from its hook and settled between his feet, disturbing the moth, which moved into the seam of a trouser leg.

Scarlett was downstairs, eating toast without butter. She wore a dress from a charity shop, repaired at the hem with a thread slightly too bright for the fabric. At the back of her neck a small label remained where someone had cut away the name of the previous owner. She had once tried to remove it, discovered that doing so would open the seam, and decided she preferred to keep the unknown woman.

'Your collar's inside out,' she said.

'That's fashion.'

'It's not that recent.'

'Have you ever thought we might be very unhappy?'

'Frequently. Put your trousers on.'

Quotation version

The invisible alarm clock rang again. [1496] The clock ticked loudly. [790] a large flat package [167] our clock stopped [1386] without waking [1472] He struck out with his one hand [1024] Just as she reached it the telephone rang. [878]

“Yes,” was the reply. [791] “Well--yes,” he said. [978] sitting in the car [612]

You’re asleep. You’re talking in your sleep. [1520]

we're practically there [816]

was getting married. [790]

He looked at his clock again. [199] There was a general movement backwards. [1465] He sat up hurriedly. [1268]

Why didn't you wake me up last night? [393]

Of course I did. [1440] You’d never get elected, you know. [427]

He opened the wardrobe [409] The door didn't budge. [436] but I find the screw was too loose. [861] his best dark suit [593] Then he dropped his trousers, forgotten, to the floor. [448]

some dry toast without any butter [377] her dress was worn thread-bare [561] bit off the thread and drew the smaller needle from where it rested in the hem. [239] Because the overcoat has got a label sewn on the inside with your address written in marking ink. [281] previous owner’s name [728] If you go too fast you sometimes have to rip out the whole seam. [1476] She kept it. [791]

Look at the collar. [411]

“You're merely paying for fashion.” [916]

But that's very old-fashioned, isn't it? [916]

Let us all be unhappy together. [1072]

frequently [1443] Put on your clothes. [1419]

Original

They left eight minutes later, their departure accelerating movements already in progress. A glass rattled against the draining board. A draught pushed the bedroom door nearly shut. The loose wardrobe screw rose a fraction within its worn hole. Water continued entering the wall at a point where the landlord had put a towel during his inspection. The towel had been removed before the photographs were taken. By the time Charles and Scarlett reached the road, all evidence of their hurry had been reduced to the movement of loose objects, a running tap and a gas flame left beneath an empty saucepan.

The house did not become quiet at once. Pipes contracted, the cistern refilled, a spider repaired its web. At eleven a passing van shook the loose wardrobe door open. The saucepan heated until its handle began to smell of plastic. The smoke alarm had been disconnected because it went off during cooking. The landlord's notice said tenants were responsible for batteries. It did not mention whether the alarm should be connected.

Charles and Scarlett drove through rain. The wipers lifted water across the glass, leaving streaks at the edges where their rubber had worn. Charles leaned towards the wheel to look through a clearer portion.

'We're going to be late,' said Scarlett.

'Not necessarily. Churches are famously patient.'

'Angus isn't. He rang me from the vestry. He sounded like a man talking himself out of a hostage situation.'

'It's not the worst metaphor for marriage.'

She gave him a look he had earned on several occasions and would earn again. The car passed a lorry carrying rough timber. A retaining strap had cut into the outer edge of one board. Each change in the lorry's speed briefly increased the load against the fibres. In a field beyond the road, a stand of trees moved under the same wind. The lorry continued towards a timber yard to the north. The car turned south towards the church.

They did not meet.

Quotation version

A few minutes later they left [844] after their departure. [1400] The glass in the street lamps rattled lightly. [1221] The door was thrown shut again by the cross-draught [1337] Then it twisted round [1042] It was dripping with water. [480] the towel was removed [338] When they reached the road [508] if you weren’t careful, you’d forget to turn off the stove [680] loose objects fled towards it [131] They were in a desperate hurry, evidently. [843] left the gas-stove in the kitchen alight with a saucepan upon it. [220]

murmurs and movement [840] THE BUILDING OF A SPIDER’S WEB [447] The door swung open. [315] only the wardrobe door had swung open [701] the heavy rattle of a passing truck or cart. [1326] the handle of the saucepan [414] the slight scent of burning [680] disconnected the alarms [356] relations of good and bad landlords with tenants. [194] Who told you to shut off the alarm? [1031]

the rain driving against them [594] The rain spatted gently on the windshield. [176] He leaned over the wheel [861]

We'll be late for our date. [1239]

“Not necessarily,” I said. [640] I shall be patient. [484]

No [506] we entered the vestry. [1402] kept helpless, alone, and ignorant. [209]

If that's marriage, I shall never get married. [990]

That she had won heavily this evening he saw at once. [182] In a few moments a car passed. [250] for I cut off all the side of a strap [641] The speed in the meantime had strangely increased. [1329] the strength of wood varies with the speed at which the fibres are strained. [1139] At the place of their meeting, the road ran under the shadow of the trees. [1144] Toward the west the ground continued level for a thousand yards [863] he was turning towards the car [1401]

It did not meet hers, however. [681]

Original

The lorry carried wet wood from a group of sites identified by compartment number. Its load included trunks from a clear-felled plantation, and several pieces taken from a roadside clearance where a tree had fallen into a telephone line. The plantation had been established on drained ground. The drains were narrow, deep, and irregularly maintained; in wet months they carried dark water through peat into a stream that entered a reservoir. In dry months they emptied the upper soil and left a network of roots, fungi and small invertebrates without the conditions in which they had previously persisted.

The planted trees stood close together. Their canopies narrowed as they competed for light. Some had been suppressed almost from the beginning, leaving thin stems which the machinery cut and crushed into the ground. A bark beetle population had expanded in the stressed trees during an unusually warm season. The adults bored beneath bark, released chemical signals and admitted fungi. Some larvae survived. Others were eaten by predators, starved after the tissue dried, or were killed by parasites that developed inside them. One parasitic wasp had laid its egg in a living larva; the young wasp consumed tissues while the host continued for a time to feed. Both died when the section of bark containing them was stripped and passed under a tyre. Their deaths were not part of the forestry report. They occurred in the ordinary operation of the vehicle.

The contractor who ran the harvest had a damaged shoulder and an employee he couldn't replace. He was required to leave some standing timber for habitat, and he did. Trees judged too expensive to reach were particularly likely to receive this designation. The inspector photographed several pieces of retained deadwood, and the photographs were included in a report accompanying the contractor's renewal application. He had not falsified them. A small cavity inside one retained trunk housed a nesting bird. During extraction, a tyre sank into an old drainage line and the machine rocked. The tree beside it was struck low enough to split an already weakened branch. A nest fell, striking the metal guard. The operator reversed, freed the wheel and carried on. Later, when he saw the broken branch, he informed his supervisor that the habitat tree remained upright. It did.

Quotation version

a load of wood. [1255] On the felled trunks of trees [77] The telephone lines here were down. [323] in well-drained ground [445] forced water from the stream into a small pond or elevated reservoir [706] the old peat-holes with their dark brown water [469] Could we find the answer beneath that dry soil? [1281] They provide a valuable network of soil-holding roots, important in retarding erosion. [1257] under favourable conditions, perfect fungi may be developed. [288]

There are the trees. [589] They look for golden canopies. [1466] In many cases the stem is suppressed. [288] and then the roots and stems and leaves, falling upon the ground and becoming buried [279] This should be done before the beetles emerge from the tree in June. [851] Then the barking sound once more--eager, excited barking. [1023] The larvae were inanimate as if with cold. [483] He slept with them, and ate with them, and starved with them when food was scarce. [327] were soon killed and eaten. [741] This is the Wasp's egg. [447] gets its nourishment from a living host. [613] stripped of their bark and laid across the road [1038] These trees have no place or part now. [67] They function in the non-externalised finer vehicle. [1069]

But the man with drooping shoulders saw nothing. [391] Should he leave it standing where it was? [1214] were wholly involved in standing timber [1270] If he was going to do anything, his problem was the tree. [1268] from which the accompanying photograph was taken [669] Even in the accompanying photographs this difference is discernible. [669] He made absolutely no attempt to conceal this knowledge. [373] A house whose inside is as open and manifest as a bird's nest [1370] bounced the machine on the barn floor to see that the tyres were sound [790] Straightening, she hung them on a low-hanging branch of a nearby tree. [1532] A living nest of them; a prodigious living nest of metal! [977] ran lightning-like on deck and reversed the wheel. [894] For now he saw more than they, and otherwise than men see trees. [630] The sap had risen in the trees, so that a broken branch bled. [921] That started it. [1132]

Original

Below the machines, layers of compacted material held less air than before. Water that once entered the ground near the roots ran across it in shallow sheets. Fine sediment entered the ditch. At the junction with the stream it accumulated around stones, closing some of the spaces in which larvae of aquatic insects had lived. Most of the larvae were small enough to pass unnoticed between a fingertip and a thumbnail. In the summer the stream would be tested for turbidity at a point downstream from where the dark water entered. The result would be entered under WATER QUALITY: ACCEPTABLE. The particular spaces filled beneath the stones would not be reopened by the entry.

The lorry driver had a photograph of his granddaughter attached to the dashboard with tape. He stopped at a lay-by, ate an apple and sent her a message containing a picture of a bird he had noticed in the hedge. She replied with a row of hearts. He had worked on timber transport for thirty years and knew that some loads contained what would be called waste by the time they arrived. His steering wheel was badly worn. He was afraid of losing his licence after the next medical because he had begun to have difficulties with his sight at night. The company had provided an application for early retirement, with guidance on how to make the process positive.

The lorry crossed a culvert. Water passed below it, carrying suspended sediment, a broken leaf, residues washed from the road and a fine quantity of tyre wear. In one pocket of slower current, a predatory nymph seized a smaller animal by the head. The water shifted. The nymph lost its grip. The smaller animal escaped with part of a leg missing, travelled into a channel between stones and was seized there by another predator. In a photograph taken from the bridge nothing of this would have been visible. The landscape would have appeared to have survived the harvest very well.

Quotation version

The thudding sound of a machine below grew louder and more oppressive. [1464] looking out across a large sheet of water in front of them [127] It went in the ditch. [463] Insects buzzed around him, rising up from the dry weed-stalks. [371] the stream with the stones and roots along its bank [126] while the two large ones were far beyond all creatures I have ever seen. [405] Like the streams which the heat of the summer has dried up [414] will the water of streams differ at these times in turbidity and in the relative amount of solids carried in solution? [1027] was quite safe [1009] the blank space was not filled out. [854] The spaces between were filled with mud, stones [527]

He said to the driver:-- [1332] to be attached to the dashboard of his car. [853] “It's an apple,” she said. [1193] he sent a message to her [1513] She did not reply, her heart was too full for words. [1340] the felling and sale of timber [807] He held the steering-wheel well under control. [800] For a moment it was so bad that he was afraid of losing consciousness. [789] before the individuals of the company retired [888] I desire to make an application. [552]

the narrow arch of the culvert [1358] The leaves were washed and transferred to water, but next morning were evidently dead. [337] the quantity of sediment which the passing water carries [989] There was a bullet hole in the gentle, patient animal's head. [178] it seizes by the nose with its powerful jaws [747] He shifted uneasily. [369] The grip's clumsy. [1149] “Experimental animals that escaped during a world-wide war generations ago,” reported the other. [1022] A leg was missing, I saw [546] For a time no effect was visible to the watcher on the bridge. [1459] When the harvest came there was not an animal surviving on the place [895]

II. The First Wedding: Contact

Original

The church door had been installed during a renovation neither old enough to be considered historic nor recent enough for anyone to remember who had approved it. Rain had entered the timber over several days and its lower edge scraped against the stone threshold. The caretaker, June, had intended to plane it down, but the church possessed neither the tools nor the money. The committee had voted to establish whether the defect was structural or seasonal. The vote had been unanimous. No one had been given the job of finding out.

As guests arrived June pulled it open with increasing force. Two people stumbled. A third apologised to the door. Anne, a guest who used a wheelchair, asked for the step-free entrance. June led her around the boiler yard to a gate padlocked for security. Anne had telephoned the previous week and been assured the church was accessible. 'It is,' June said, looking at the gate. She returned with three keys. None fitted. Anne photographed the gate and went to have lunch with her sister instead. June wrote DOOR and ACCESS in her notebook, which also contained HEATING, COLLECTIONS, GUTTERS and ITEMS TO RAISE AGAIN. Most entries were followed by a date and, after the date, a second date.

Behind the locked gate, access to the boiler yard was interrupted by a concrete ramp that sloped sharply towards the rear wall. It had been built when the congregation's oldest member began using a walking frame. Its gradient was too steep for him, but he had died before the defect was reported. The building committee retained the ramp as evidence of reasonable efforts. In winter a strip of algae colonised its surface where gutter water crossed. June swept it with a stiff broom and added grit. The sweepings moved into the drain. The grit changed the surface long enough for the next inspection.

Quotation version

The door of the Church was open. [369] when I reached the door found it was jammed to [278] scraping of wood against stone [557] I thought they were going to pull the whole church down. [1342] pointing out that they possessed neither tools nor machines [873] We demand rigidly defined areas of doubt and uncertainty! [6] Certain real or alleged structural defects should be noted. [1028] The vote was unanimous. [55] no one knew what had actually happened. [736] I thought our job was to find out who did it. [271]

Guests were arriving. [466] some hurrying along, others hesitating in apparent bewilderment. [3] one of them stumbled against the other. [1450] I beg your pardon [671] Anne asked. [561] There was a padlock and a chain upon the gate. [415] I was assured that this always happens. [333] We're going through the gate. [1395] for she had returned with the keys in her hand, [380] none of the keys in the house would turn in the locks [1388] I thought how unpleasant it is to be locked out [1516] Went to lunch [853] She wrote on a torn bit of note-book paper. [1381] after changing the date once or twice [853] and then follows the date [377]

the way was barred to me [415] The yard gate was locked [992] The tall metal church which the gods left here long ago? [1248] the angles of which were too steep to retain snow. [863] That was a bit too steep. [922] This is absurdly awkward; nor is there evidence for steps. [1028] a stream of dirty water was running along the gutters [1540] he is swept out with a broom [399] If it wasn't for the drains [420] How much grit do you think you've got? [569]

Original

The churchyard was managed under a contract advertising sensitive maintenance. A mower made four visits each growing season and left one strip of long grass in an area marked on a plan. The plan called the strip a wildlife corridor. It reached a wall at one end and a parking area at the other. Inside it, a small population of voles had made runways through the stems. A barn owl sometimes crossed the boundary at night and took one of them. The owl's food was not distributed equally between individuals, nor was the owl a guardian of anything. On a damp evening a vole carried a seed and dropped it when a cat entered the grass. The seed lodged at the edge of a broken tile and germinated the following spring. During that spring's first mow the plant and the tile were crushed together. The mower's blade had recently been sharpened to reduce fuel consumption.

The old gravestones altered the movement of water and light. Lichens spread across some surfaces, combining fungal structures with partners able to photosynthesise. Their growth was slow, interrupted by salts, rain, frost, bird droppings and the occasional efforts of descendants to clean a family name. A parishioner had bought a proprietary solution advertised as gentle on stone. It removed the most visible growth and left a pale rectangle where the memorial had weathered unevenly. The cleaned inscription could be read more easily for two summers. On the backs of neighbouring stones, where nobody tried to read anything, lichen remained.

Under one stone, roots had expanded through a seam in the mortar. The pressure lifted a corner by a small amount. Ants used the gap. A queen in a neighbouring colony produced an annual flight of winged offspring, nearly all of whom died before establishing another colony. Some were taken by birds. Others fell into puddles or onto pavement and were carried beneath shoes. A few reached the grass, shed their wings and were eaten there. The survival of the colony did not require the survival of any particular reproductive flight. The numbers were sufficient. Human beings had invented the expression *nature's abundance* for events they rarely stayed to count.

Quotation version

A churchyard. [382] emerged upon a strip of open long-grass [1259] Another flight of stairs, leading to just such another corridor! [667] reaching the wall at the end [638] until they reached the parking lot. [1086] Out into the hidden runway they had crept. [1242] small furred creatures were the two short-tailed voles--field-vole and bank-vole [661] after the white barn owl had passed round the fir copse. [708] Then the owls came out, and night-flying things. [507] Outside the little cabin an owl hooted. [1076] Have you ever seen a cat trying to open a package? [290] like a seed that has germinated [788] ground and crushed under the rolling wheels. [1465] it was sharp and crisp at the edges. [1232] sharpened down one side of the blade. [197]

The light passed on. [120] the stone which the lichen has embossed and richly coloured [661] the cellular structure which surrounds [288] with the slow modification of their descendants [334] the growth was slow and natural. [1356] dust the stone with assiduous care [1391] The gentle art of advertisement. [728] the fumes from the cascade stills left their mark on stone buildings. [1109] The growth had been removed [99] came and gave orders that the inscription be restored. [600] Many of the lesser stones were spotted with dark dots of lichen, not unlike a toad. [709]

Everyone knows how a sycamore root will buckle a sidewalk [389] Pressure on both sides. [664] The ants gain access [91] borne upon the wings of all the butterflies that have died upon the Worlds [421] produce a large number of offspring [1219] now after a bird has found and devoured a large supply of food [334] The pavement was blackened and shattered to rubble. [1245] muddy shoes, worn at heel, splashing through the puddles [302] One arm reached out for grass, and clutched bare space instead. [960] Your colony wouldn't want our seeds. [148] while other members of the colony are purely reproductive animals. [1260] sufficient to sustain a population [747] what men call [124] abundance of life [997]

Original

The church ordered a printed banner announcing a community day devoted to biodiversity. It was made of a composite plastic fabric that could withstand wind and rain. The company recommended replacing it every two years to maintain legibility. June tied it to the fence with cable ties; one drew tight against a young branch. A visitor asked whether the event would involve planting trees. June said she hoped so. The funding had been approved for activities rather than maintenance, and there was no money to water anything planted. The visitor said that sounded about right.

When Anne returned from lunch with her sister, the wedding reception had already begun elsewhere. She sent the photograph of the locked gate to the church office. A volunteer replied that all visitors were valued equally and asked whether she would like to be added to the mailing list. Anne said she would prefer a way into the building. The volunteer passed the message to June, who was lifting a bucket beneath the leaking boiler. The bucket was almost full. June put the telephone down, emptied it, and wrote a further entry beneath ACCESS. At the next meeting someone would ask whether there had been any complaints. June would say yes. The secretary would ask whether the complaint was a new one.

Beneath the boiler yard, a broken drain carried warm water into colder soil. Earthworms occupied passages around roots and pieces of mortar. Their tunnels altered how water and air moved. One was cut during an emergency repair to the pipe. The two pieces contracted separately. The front portion moved for several minutes. The plumber found the sight unpleasant and asked his apprentice to fetch a bag for the rubbish. The apprentice returned with one marked BIODEGRADABLE. It was not the sort of material for which the label had been designed.

Charles arrived during the reading. Scarlett went ahead of him, holding her shoes, which were wet through. He tried to close the door quietly. It wedged against the threshold. Through the gap he could hear a woman describing love as patient.

He pulled harder. The door came free and struck its frame with a noise sufficient to interrupt a minor agricultural accident. Every head turned. The reader, who had been describing love as kind, hesitated as if about to revise the statement.

'Sorry,' Charles said.

Quotation version

like banners in a church [1540] Here I was given a vociferous banner announcing: [1232] After all, mere clouds, which may or may not hold wind or rain. [285] This is replaced every twenty-four hours. [950] He hung on tight, clutching at the sagging fence. [375] It was tied to a tree or a fence [981] drew tight the second. [976] And how do you think I felt when a tree answered me back? [1289] It hoped so too. [1318] The plants in the water were as leafless as the plants on land. [439] “I ... all right,” I said. [974]

the reception [8] had already begun [593] Then he went out and locked the gates of the enclosure. [1463] We'll ask for volunteers. [1505] It was a list of mailing information [1012] called to me to let her in [378] In this manner, they passed the buckets to fill the scuttle-butt. [971] Thus the message was passed from person to person [144] a leak in the boiler [1018] A full bath or a full bucket seemed empty [972] Our telephone has just gone out of order. [777] and wrote the entry rapidly [790] While emptying the buckets at the back of the house [593] “I think such a meeting would be possible,” the Secretary said. [644] She said yes, [478] the Secretary asked. [644] And what do you think his complaint is?' I asked. [807]

the boiler and the plumbing. [746] underground passages [203] And the passageways, although brilliantly lighted, were mere narrow tunnels. [1199] after taking a long pull at his pipe [563] Separately, of course. [480] She didn't move for several minutes. [453] He determined to fetch one from the buffet cupboard downstairs. [1182] What's all this rubbish? [1007] instead of sending one of his apprentices. [991] This picture was the design I had failed to make out [1480] designated by some label or mark. [192]

Charles came into the room. [466] She came down the walk, and took him by the hands. [1075] He proceeded quietly to close the door again. [1181] had blocked up the threshold. [1256] She saw that he did not value her love and care, but she was patient. [40]

Our leader pulled up. [1104] Suddenly he stopped speaking as a knock sounded on the door. [454] Then came the noise of a closing door [509] Every head had lifted, every eye had turned away from the strangers. [580] Oh no! not the kind of love, that is, that you read about. [663]

Sorry [189]

Original

The apology travelled across the congregation. The door, resecured in its frame, was already beginning to retain heat on one side and lose it on the other.

Angus and Laura were young enough to be optimistic about their own competence. They had organised the wedding themselves, with financial help from Laura's mother and intermittent obstruction from Angus's father, who regarded payments for musicians as unnecessary because the church already owned an organ. The venue had charged them for removing its own furniture. Laura's mother had quietly paid the difference, then tried not to mention it at dinner, failed, and asked her daughter whether marriage was really meant to begin with an overdraft. Angus's shoe pinched him. Laura wondered whether the flowers smelled of petrol. Her brother had reversed the hired van into the delivery entrance and refused to discuss the dent until after the photographs.

It was a perfectly good wedding. On the evaluation form sent afterwards, Laura would give it four stars.

Charles found a seat beside Gareth and Matthew. Gareth had supplied an enormous pink handkerchief to anyone visibly upset by the ceremony and had offended three relatives while doing so. His own shirt was slightly too tight across the stomach. When he moved, the cotton pulled against the buttons with a dry sound.

'You're late,' he whispered.

'We were held up.'

'By consciousness?'

Matthew placed a hand on Gareth's knee to prevent the next remark. Gareth made it anyway, too quietly to distinguish. Charles smiled. Across the aisle, a woman with short dark hair seemed to be looking at him. She was, in fact, trying to see whether the man behind him was the former husband of a friend. Charles turned to look and met her eyes on the way back.

She smiled too.

Quotation version

Even as such, some apology for it is necessary. [1424] But now the Door is jolly well shut for keeps! [821]

The young, always they believe they are the only ones who were ever young! [1358] the cost of the wedding, [552] The wedding was very much like other weddings [41] Mother! mother! help your daughter. [949] the Organ’s melody swelled through the Church [852] it had been overlooked by those who removed the furniture. [1386] her mother asked her [1443] not to mention, at tea or dinner [1183] She says she’ll have to ask for an overdraft as it is. [1517] It was apparent to everyone where the shoe pinched. [862] She smelled nice. [823] the smell of flowers mingled [913] And she had refused, and still refused! [1540]

They were perfectly good. [1464] the four points of the star [977]

It had been lying on the seat beside him, but it was gone now. [521] being offended [166] He carried a scented pink handkerchief [1380] not too tight to disturb the stomach much [816] in a workingman’s cheap cotton shirt (one button was missing from the throat) [873]

“I'm so sorry I am late,” she whispered. [1158]

I held on to it. [672]

Consciousness itself--after all what is it? [977]

laid one hand on his knee. [1270] too quietly for me to hear, [1015] with a polite smile. [635] He ran a hand back over his short hair and looked at her. [1152] He was a married man, but a connection of her own, immaculate! [508] Her eyes came back from that reach and met his own a moment. [699]

smiled too. [1520]

Original

Outside, wind took hold of the ribbons tied to the gate. Some were secured with double knots, others with single loops pulled tight by people who had recently been assured they could manage without instructions. A blue length slid from its fastening and travelled down the path, wetting, folding and unfolding. It lodged beneath the lip of a drain cover. Passing shoes drove water into it. A leaf caught against its fraying edge. By the end of the ceremony the ribbon had redirected a thin flow of water onto the ground beside the step-free entrance. The water would find a different route before anyone recorded the problem. There was no ceremony for that.

The ribbon held against the drain cover throughout the afternoon. The water above it rose to the depth of a thumbnail, then spilled around a broken corner. Fat from a kitchen upstream had hardened against a seam in the pipe. It had accumulated over several months, receiving small amounts from places whose occupants each considered themselves careful about what went down the sink. Hair, lint and scraps of a wet wipe had adhered to it. The wipe had been sold as flushable. It could indeed be flushed. The claim concerned the beginning of its journey.

A drain fly had laid eggs in the film on the pipe wall. Larvae moved through a mixture of bacteria, organic particles and moisture. Their development was interrupted when a household poured boiling water down a basin. Some died; others were sheltered by the thickest part of the deposit. A subsequent application of drain cleaner altered the chemistry of the film, and the organisms that survived recolonised it from its edges. The deposits narrowed the passage just enough for water to accumulate during heavy rain. The household bought a larger bottle and kept it beneath the sink, beside products whose labels warned against combining them. Nothing dramatic happened there for weeks. This was taken as proof that the pipe had been cured.

Quotation version

The wind lifted her hat, and fluttered the ribbons under her chin. [239] It was covered with brown paper, and secured with string, and the knots were troublesome. [913] is pulled tightly and left in a loop [96] it was sliding swiftly downward through the night-blue [638] The drain boards are sometimes covered with perforated rubber mats. [739] The water was up to his ankles. [1497] A leaf turns on its edge. [1519] The ceremony was over and the crowd was beginning to pour out. [1446] But how can the steersman follow the route in the middle of the waters? [1402] They have no ceremonies whatever. [706]

The drain-pipe was dripping [853] The water rose [561] even in water so shallow [641] the clean-out is so placed as to give access to the inside of the pipe. [739] Assuming that this amount had accumulated in six months [335] be careful about the small things [252] showers of dust and rolls of lint had come tumbling down upon her head. [1439] Wipe clean. [1038] His face was flushed. [29] But where was that beginning? [582]

One fly deposits hundreds of eggs [334] The later part of the decay, however, is largely carried on by bacterial life. [279] One had a brown pot, into which the boiling stuff was poured. [480] The strong ones lived—the others died. [1520] till the thickest of the forest sheltered me [601] the animals survived the otherwise fatal doses they had received of the toxin [485] a larger application is necessary to produce the same effect [716] The rain-water collects there [664] The passage for the water is thus gradually narrowed [716] He told him of the larger bottle of solution [1286] For a split second, nothing happened. [939] Proof having been thus obtained, they resorted to the accustomed remedy. [1113]

Original

At the outfall, intermittently diluted household water entered a shallow channel with stone sides. A thin population of algae occupied its illuminated surface. In darker corners there were bacteria and small invertebrates, not all drawing on the same resources. A rat drank where the channel widened. Later it brought a fragment of bread to a hole in a retaining wall. It was bitten on the flank by another rat and returned on a different night. The wound became infected. The first rat continued to feed, but travelled shorter distances; one evening it emerged slowly enough for a terrier to catch it. The dog belonged to a retired accountant who believed strongly in not interfering with wildlife, with exceptions for vermin, of which he had drawn up a private definition.

Beneath the road a greater length of the drainage system had been lined with a plastic sleeve. The sleeve was manufactured from material refined and processed at facilities beyond the county, installed to extend the life of a cracked pipe without excavating the street. Its inner surface was smooth at first. Fine sediment collected around an imperfect join. In a small pocket of slower water, organisms assembled a thin film, capturing particles passing from above. A larva with hooks on its posterior end held against the current. The hooks were sufficient for ordinary flow. During a sudden storm the volume increased, shearing away the film and carrying the larva through the culvert. It struck a metal screen at the next chamber and became part of the accumulation that made the screen necessary. The screen performed well until it obstructed the flow.

By evening the blue ribbon had dried at its exposed edge and remained wet beneath the grate. A boy on his way home pushed it with a stick. He was trying to get it into the pipe and failed. At the reception June went to help locate a lost guest who had mistaken the toilets for the exit and was now attempting to explain himself to a fire door.

In the reception room Charles was introduced to the woman from the church. Her name was Carrie. She had travelled from America, but not specially for Angus and Laura; she had been staying with friends, she explained, and invitations had accumulated around the trip. Charles found this remarkable. Invitations, in his experience, arrived like parking fines.

'And what do you do?' she asked.

Quotation version

The water at the sides and end was shallow [863] a narrow channel of water [256] illuminating the surface of the water [788] the simplest forms of Algae [1196] could be in any way injurious to animals living in darkness [334] The natural resources are not the same. [721] A rat is a rat. [622] I think it must come under the head of black bread. [1469] A piece of bread was brought [414] Well--a rat is a nasty thing! [794] Being wounded with wounds. [88] The time for the rat-catching arrived at last, and the hunt began. [594] paused, looked round, and returned to feeding. [710] for he had seen his terriers catch them [1324] many a farmer this night believed that his dog was choking. [422] and the dog belonged to him. [1194]

lined both sides of the road [899] a system of elementary drainage [664] in which the old man with the pipe had joined them [382] sources of raw materials and markets for their manufactured products. [1151] Notice its smooth unobtrusive shape. [1331] only the finest sediment was deposited around me. [1370] by forming a protective film around the particles of the suspensoids [1364] particles of dirt adhere to it [535] the larva goes to the end [443] Then I wonder—hooks? [400] with a hook of sufficient strength [950] To my surprise the little wisp of vapor increased in volume as it ascended. [1140] a screen of metal [701] under the meshes of a wire gauze. [444] I don't know how it got past our screens. [786]

on the surface [632] It was perfectly dry. [311] still wet from the river. [706] pushed it with a stick [747] but he pushed it away with a stick [1172] His pipe was out, but he could not take his hands from the wheel to refill it. [470] The guest's exit was succeeded by a momentary silence. [216]

the manner of her reception depended upon the period at which she was introduced. [108] What's her name? [305] She’s not too ill to travel: she only might have become so if she had stayed. [697] She went to stay with girl friends. [792] Now, it is very remarkable [1464] it had been a grave mistake to accept their invitation [104]

“How is that?” she asked. [115]

Original

'At the moment I'm standing here.'

'Is it paid work?'

'No. But I'm ambitious.'

They spoke for eleven minutes. A waiter carried glasses between the bar and kitchen; a fly struck the window; a damp cloth spread a stain across a table. Carrie described an abandoned flat in Chicago and a London editor asking her to revise a book of photographs. Charles described his job and apologised for making it sound like one. He liked not knowing what she liked about him.

Across the room Fiona watched Charles with the exhaustion of a person whose prediction had proved correct and had not made her happy. She had loved him for years, in ways that rarely inconvenienced him and continually inconvenienced her. She did not believe this gave her a claim, though she sometimes resented the moral advantage of being able to say so. Tom came up behind her carrying sausages.

'Are you having a good time?'

'I'm observing a very good time being had elsewhere.'

'Would a sausage help?'

'Would it be a replacement for something?'

'It's meat. That's already an ambitious claim.'

She took one. Later she would remember his expression more clearly than the flavour. At that moment she had no reason to imagine him as the man who might eventually help carry her furniture out of a bad flat.

Quotation version

Stand here at my left hand. [1066]

He was doing the work for which he was paid. [1386]

“No, no!” she repeated. [698] I was just a little too ambitious, that's all. [886]

“Eleven minutes,” the signal sounded. [263] The flies buzzed round the table and crawled over the stained cloth. [1491] A waiter went to and fro, bringing plates and glasses. [957] A fly flew up suddenly and struck the window pane [399] I looked down and saw the wet stain spreading [958] an empty flat [399] he spoke of his work [514] conscious of inanity. [162] He liked her; she was certain of it. [365]

She was at least partly right in her predictions [1420] And it was terrible to think that he loved her, and she must continually distress him. [955] She did not believe her own words, yet the mere saying of them gave her renewed hope. [204] the advantage in moral dignity [1213] he came up behind her [1474]

Are you having a good time? [788]

I often think of that, now that I'm ashore for good and all. [312]

Wouldn’t I, sausage-maker? [401]

We'll see what we can do about a replacement then. [1352]

It’s been meat and drink [1329] Nor too ambitious, friend. [1328]

She took her freedom. [909] And then he remembered. [524] She remembered his speaking expression [1147] She could not imagine what this man wanted of her. [509] and carried furniture with them. [1323]

Original

The floor beneath them had been laid in sections. Wear and changing humidity had raised an edge near the dance area, forming a shallow ridge. The hired catering trolley crossed it every seven minutes. One wheel had a flat spot from standing under an excessive load; its bearing carried grit from a delivery yard. The resulting squeal arrived at intervals too regular to be accidental and too faint to justify an official complaint. A man in the kitchen called it the little pig. His manager called it a maintenance item and had removed it from the list when the company changed owners. The wheel was still capable of turning, which settled the argument for several months.

Carrie danced with Charles. She was more decisive on her feet; he followed her through a gap barely wide enough for one. Gareth danced with Laura's aunt until Matthew intervened. When someone pulled a plug from the wall, the music stopped. People continued moving in the sudden silence, appalled by the size of their gestures.

'If we keep doing it,' Gareth announced, 'they'll have to put the music back.'

No one could hear him across the room. He continued dancing with great seriousness. Someone laughed, then several people did, and the man at the socket restored the power.

At the bar, Carrie mentioned that she was leaving in the morning. Charles failed to conceal his disappointment with sufficient speed to preserve the illusion of sophistication.

'You could come and have a drink,' she said.

'I'm having a drink.'

'A different one, somewhere else.'

The invitation reached him intact. He agreed.

Quotation version

the walls being unplastered and the floor not laid. [1274] The words of the Dance-- [1535] oak floors, warped with age. [810] It'll be registering every trolley car that goes by next. [548] the wheels groaning under their heavy loads. [239] carrying grit--plain grit [1208] Sis let off a couple of silly squeals too. [822] faint but regular [977] Then the little Pig said, "Hah!" [187] to be removed from a list. [740] He took hold of the wheel and turned it. [370] Several months passed in this manner. [1255]

She danced up and down. [812] The path itself was barely wide enough for footing. [871] The gap was just big enough to enable him to squeeze through it. [719] intervened [1476] The music stopped. [623] And as though at a signal a sudden silence fell. [767] There was a hushed, appalled silence [431]

Shall turn our loosening musics back to love. [1368]

Inside, they couldn't hear him. [1423] He continued mercilessly. [599] Dancing continued in this manner with little intermission [1177] The man came back and said: [1334] turning on the electric switch [1419]

leaving in the morning [461] There seemed to be a definite disappointment in his cruel eyes. [1148] with a vain attempt to conceal his disappointment [692]

"Come over and have a few drinks," he said. [1303]

Have little drink? [1392]

Where else should it be? [1365]

He had not caught the invitation, that was all. [131] "Then we are agreed," he said. [1314]

Original

They left before midnight, when the room was warm enough for condensation to form behind the curtains. In the kitchen, grease cooled in a shallow tray. The trolley had stopped; the damaged wheel settled into contact with the floor. Its flat spot would deepen by morning. Laura's brother negotiated a cash payment to the van company and then told Laura that everything had gone beautifully. She believed him because she was happy, and because the ability to accept a statement without looking into it would be useful during the first year of their marriage.

Outside the gate, the blue ribbon remained caught under the drain. Water pushed against the leaves gathered there; a thin rivulet found a second route around the metal cover. In the morning June would notice a shallow pool and write DRAIN in her notebook. She would draw a heavy line beneath it, then return to the business of the church door. The ribbon would remain in place for many weeks.

Charles and Carrie went to a hotel. The headboard had a factory-applied finish and the sheets contained polyester mixed with cotton. They undressed with an impatience that made further introductions unnecessary. Afterwards Carrie spoke about her mother's Sunday calls to ask whether she was happy, a question she disliked because any answer could create work. Charles said he had worked in the same office six years without ever wanting to be there. He was becoming good at it, which made the mistake harder to correct.

'What would you do instead?' Carrie asked.

'I don't know. I was hoping to arrive at that part later.'

He said it lightly, but she recognised something costly underneath. She had used the same postponement herself, in other rooms, with other people.

At four they woke to rain. Carrie was leaving before ten. Each had something to say about what came next, but neither wanted to be responsible for the next sentence.

Quotation version

We and some others left at midnight. [83] the room had become definitely, uncomfortably warm. [1211] with grease worked deeply into the pores of the skin [1026] The wheel spun, stopped. [436] A single spot of water on a smooth, flat stone! [434] returned and told her the news. [532] though they were thought to have included a large cash payment. [462] He had to see her--to convince himself that she had not forgotten the happy years together. [733] During the first year of their marriage [1256]

Outside the east gate. [1240] with its faded blue ribbon. [601] Gradually the leaves thinned around me [405] thin line raced down the metal [1175] The action was now concentrated at the far end of the pool. [242] Then she lost sight of him as he advanced to the door. [324] Heavy line--For border lines. [566] Now to return to business. [1164] it takes the place of a medal or the red ribbon. [709]

returned to the hotel. [510] Then he began to drop the rest in, sheet by sheet. [1051] clothes or fabrics containing cotton [1357] Their fingers met and meshed at his belt; [349] when she answered her mother's questions about her work. [631] Would she really be happy? asked the mother [1275] It 's pretty hard work to answer general questions in a particular way. [250] Once he had worked there, technically he still did. [1422] If anything worked to correct his mistakes this would. [756]

So you'd hire me to kill her instead? [1348] asked Carrie. [409]

I do not know. [1142] while hoping at bottom that this last second would never arrive. [1184]

“You might have this analyzed,” he told her lightly. [980] She was the same all over. [1086] and with it the same causes for postponement [888]

The four-hour evening rain had begun. [153] I never think of leaving till ten. [314] They needed to say something, and that was the only thing they could say! [830] His next sentence would be for life. [1417]

Original

When the housekeeper entered at noon, she found a glass beneath the bed and another on the windowsill. She had six rooms to prepare before three and had been told that her hours would be reduced if she exceeded the allotted time. The sheets retained moisture where two bodies had been; the window rattled when buses passed. She stripped the bed, picked up the glasses and found a receipt for two breakfasts neither guest had eaten. The hotel would charge them anyway. The two people who had spent the night there were already moving in different directions, both briefly convinced that the other had understood more than had been said.

The hotel's laundry contractor collected two hundred and forty sheets that morning and did not know which two had been occupied by Charles and Carrie. Sheets arrived with other hotel textiles, separated first by expected whiteness and then by stains sufficiently conspicuous to require treatment. A machine admitted hot water and detergent in measured quantities. The detergent removed oils and proteins. It also carried fragrances that remained in the fabric after rinsing, indicating cleanliness to guests who could not inspect the fibres. The rotation of the drum pulled at weak seams. Several polyester filaments detached and left with the water. The filtration plant retained some of the larger fragments and passed smaller particles into a system already carrying fragments from domestic clothing, vehicle wear and paint.

The treatment works did not simply remove dirty things from clean water. It depended on enormous populations of microorganisms, supplied with oxygen and food under controlled conditions, breaking down compounds accessible to them. Other compounds passed through or entered sludge. A supervisor examined the daily numbers, saw that the plant was operating within limits and went to fetch coffee. The limits were meaningful, measured and partial. Downstream, a low flow concentrated some of what remained. A small fish moved its gills rapidly in water warmed by an unusually dry week. Its tissue already contained residues of substances that had never been used in the water itself. The plant had not been built to answer the question of what it felt like to remain alive as several different chemical tolerances were approached at once.

Quotation version

and the housekeeper entered the room. [274] They found him, not in his bed, but in his room. [808] The hour was a quarter-past six. [406] The working hours may be reduced [1006] Soldiers saw his sheet from the window. [1116] Where could the body moisture go? [929] He heard motor-buses roar by his other window [420] Why had she gone starving to bed? [1408] She had not eaten breakfast with the others [166] And they would do that anyway. [464] Then they were both silent, lost in their thoughts, looking at the night. [397] and the people scattered in different directions. [40] I felt convinced from that parting look that she had understood me [659]

Thinking she might have turned two sheets by mistake, she turned back one. [1081] a laundry, a small hotel [741] Why, Undie, YOU'RE as white as a sheet now! [1476] the sheets were fair and white [23] “This clothes-washing machine you talk about,” she admitted. [359] the washer pounding. [850] It was myself in oils [1259] he was carried away by this cloud of fragrance [244] cleanliness is a fine thing. [14] The drums were stilled. [1406] the automatic rotation of the drums or rollers [845] The water rolled off without wetting the material. [428] This charring extended to some of the fragments of clothing. [897] that sand-filtration, when carefully carried out [485]

How well the word clean describes him who is gone. [637] had the form of enormous fungi [906] are a constant supply of certain matters, animal food, and of oxygen [858] Finally, the sludge may be drawn off through the same outlet to the sludge-disposal area. [425] The Bad News Came After the Coffee [1099] and a running to fetch water for coffee. [854] No limit at all. [1241] You go downstream. [1268] The current carried them downstream. [883] It's a week since I caught these very fish. [243] The fish lives altogether in the water and breathes by gills [1393] Upon the water were floating patches of a substance that was not identified. [483] Plant kept at rather too low a temperature. [338] A direct chemical approach seems out of the question. [724]

Original

At the laundry, a worker called Beatrice lifted sheets from a cart with an injured wrist. She knew how to turn the fabric so that its weight fell closer to her body. Management had supplied a manual-handling video showing three smiling employees lifting a cardboard box. Beatrice's shift began before the first bus, and she was paying a neighbour to watch her son until school opened. The hotel had sent a note asking why several towels came back with faint stains. Beatrice circled the appropriate sentence on a standard reply: normal wear was not a hygiene failure. Her supervisor replaced the reply with an apology and a credit note, then told Beatrice that the customer had to be treated as the expert on what it felt like to have clean towels.

A cotton fibre detached from the edge of a pillowcase. It was plant cellulose, processed, bleached and woven, and had already endured many cycles of water, heat and abrasion. It joined the sludge from the treatment works, where some organic components were broken down and others remained mixed with mineral particles, plastic fragments and residues that resisted easy separation. The sludge was transported under a certificate describing it as a recoverable resource. At the receiving site it was spread on land during a narrow permitted window. A rainfall event moved some of the finest particles into a ditch. A beetle entered the moist surface to lay eggs. Its larvae fed there. Two survived to adulthood; another was invaded by a parasite. The sequence took place on a field that would later be described in a hotel's sustainability report as part of its commitment to circularity. The hotel had contracted out the laundry and had never seen the field.

One of the sheets was discarded before the next wash because a tear opened near the corner. The contractor sold damaged textiles by weight. A buyer sorted them into grades, and a portion was shredded for industrial wiping cloths. Some fibres became airborne during shredding and entered the filters of the machine. A maintenance worker later removed a thick felt of lint, compacted it in a bag and left it beneath a sign asking staff to recycle responsibly. The felt was damp by the end of the week. A black patch spread on the wall behind the bag.

Quotation version

Lifting an edge of the sheet he pulled it away [110] Her dyed blonde hair had fallen disheveled to her shoulders. [320] fabric clung to her body [56] Lifting the box with his right hand [1171] She watched her son as he ate. [594] I inquired through the towel. [1453] sent a note from the hotel [922] She did not immediately reply, but wiped her fingers on her handkerchief. [1538] “Just cleaning,” she replied, stopping and winding a dusting towel about her hand. [409] with a note of apology. [1466] What are clean towels for? [684]

It was a thread of cotton. [1007] =Ligno-celluloses.=--In the young plant cell [1364] spun and wove, bleached her linen [1377] From the liming sump the sludge passes into the sludge tank J [425] in the form of black sludge [425] mineral particles, which previously had been resting in an organic matrix [280] This is suitable for all cases where the sludge can be discharged to the sludge bed by gravitation. [425] The window on the landing-place, which was a sash-window, was open. [664] It had rained from the early morning and the day came to its end. [1354] Some lay eggs and some lay none. [622] on which nymphs and larvae are fed. [920] when the nest is invaded by the parasites [446] The hotel was one of the kind described as “renovated.” [622] the optimistic reports, the perpetual sequence of triumph and disaster and silence. [1459] They never found the hotel. [1007]

Why not just tear off the corner of one of the sheets? [783] Are you sure it wasn't mechanical damage? [515] were shreds of clothing and tangles of hair. [110] in which case the buyer made the price [1335] The clothing was in shreds [897] “Disintegrating machine!” he choked. [144] it would tear out the fibres in shreds [902] letter-bag on shoulder and staff in hand [282] a piece of lint of thick texture [1438] The part where most tide is felt was then past. [745] a black patch [557]

Original

The hotel charged Charles and Carrie for breakfast, though neither had eaten. When Charles complained later, a receptionist said the charge was part of the package. It could not be refunded because the package had been consumed, which was a peculiar way of describing the two untouched breakfasts. Charles nearly made a joke about it. He was thinking of Carrie, however, and allowed the breakfast charge to stand. The financial records were tidier than the beds had been.

By then the empty saucepan in Charles's kitchen had ruined its handle. A neighbour smelled it and called the fire brigade. The gas was turned off; the disconnected smoke alarm was noted. The landlord later demanded payment for an emergency visit, replacement battery and cleaning after a fire that had not quite happened. Scarlett disputed the cleaning charge. The landlord replied that it was standard. The saucepan went into a mixed-metal container. At a sorting depot, its melted handle had to be detached by hand before the metal could be processed further. The worker did this between two much less troublesome pans.

The following Tuesday a contractor cleared the screen farther down the drain. He tipped the wet mass into a bucket. It contained leaves, silt, packaging, the remains of three small animals and a strip of pale fabric that might once have been part of a shirt. He pulled on a glove and removed an object resembling a human finger. It was a latex novelty item from a hen party and retained an offensively cheerful fingernail. His colleague photographed him holding it. The photograph circulated in four group chats and was eventually seen by the person who had dropped it, who declared that it must have travelled miles. It had travelled two hundred and thirty metres. For most of that distance it had been underground.

The contractor put the remains into a black sack and marked the blockage as cleared. The line on the digital map changed from amber to green. During the next rainfall, water ran more rapidly through the newly open channel. At a downstream bend, the increased flow undermined a patch of sediment occupied by juvenile worms. Some were carried into the deeper drain and died there. Others lodged behind a root and continued feeding. A small fish took three in a single movement of its head.

Quotation version

He did not eat any more breakfast that morning. [1386] Except breakfast next morning, which would be covered by her hotel room fee. [1215] He was in charge of inquiry and packages at the door. [411] He opened the package after breakfast. [1176] her breakfast cold and untouched at her side [1513] should have made a joke of it [276] he was thinking of her [593] For it was a small room and there were only two beds in it. [1137]

the handle of the saucepan [414] was burnt [1329] Run on to the town and call up the fire-brigade. [1143] I turned off the gas [1412] no fire at all [971] I still disputed. [1460] It was the landlord this time. . . . [923] Then he replaced the saucepan lid. [792] Perhaps melted back would be a better way of putting it. [882] The workers in the salt-pans [487]

It crept through and following the other side of the wall back to the drain [110] The sea was wet as wet could be-- [536] It was humanoid in shape, flesh-colored but without animal details. [907] He drew forth a small bundle of fabric [205] Let none remove it from your finger as I removed the other. [1513] A lot of old hen parties. [411] gave my colleague something to hold on by [697] We may have traveled two or three miles in all [405] Two hundred feet, one hundred, fifty, thirty.... [291] He must have been hours in that underground place. [1025]

took out what money he found there and put it into some sacks. [1172] The signal changed to green [755] Grain supplies through the narrow waters of the channel. [728] The water ran in the new channel. [174] It is not probable that they can have been undermined by worms [335] The dead were carried out [1256] the sediment will be carried into and may clog the drain. [1038] twelve hours after feeding the roots [1413] A large fish swallows the bait and the stick with it. [567]

III. The Interval: Grading

Original

At the timber yard north of the motorway, the boards were unloaded beneath an open roof. The paperwork called them by length, width, thickness, grade, moisture content and species. No invoice mentioned the roots, the soil from which water had been taken, or the fungi whose interactions with the living trees had altered the chemistry of their tissues. These were not omissions of malice. They were details for which there were no boxes and, in the main, no customers. The boards retained rings of unequal width, mineral stains and variations in density. The grading system described what could be sold, not what was present.

A woman called Leena selected boards for the kiln. She had worked there thirteen years and could often tell, from lifting one end, which would split in drying. Her judgement mixed experience with information that had never reached the computerised grading station. The supervisor praised her intuition whenever it avoided waste and called it guesswork whenever she asked to slow the line. He had recently introduced a screen showing the number of units processed per hour. Leena sometimes looked at the screen and sometimes at the wood. The screen was never wrong about the thing it was counting.

One board had a pale band and a knot interrupting the grain. Leena chalked its end and sent it into the kiln. Warm air moved through the stack. Moisture left the outside faster than the centre. As the outer layers dried against the swollen interior, the fibres came under tension. A crack started by the knot and travelled in a rapid series of tiny failures. Leena heard the dry click beside the fans and knew the batch was being pushed too hard. She wrote a note. The kiln manager had a new schedule and said the note could be considered during next month's review. Leena asked whether that meant the schedule would remain until next month. He said the review process was designed to be responsive.

Quotation version

The roof was open. [906] It was being unloaded in the yard. [1538] In general thickness, they all bore a seemly correspondence to their length. [971] Water is taken up by the roots of the tree from the soil. [851] But he bore no malice. [1080] There were no customers at the tables. [623] They warp less because the annual rings cross the board more evenly. [1038] It may be obtained in two grades, the standard and extra heavy. [739]

the woman selected two sticks from the heaps. [592] It's all one s'long as she keeps a dry bilge. [576] for thirteen years [302] drying proceeds rapidly and irregularly, so that material seasoned at that time is more likely to split and check. [1139] She had never mixed with the girls as one of themselves. [790] The line had slowed almost to a halt. [366] my "intuition," as others called it [124] a certain number of units [1466] charts which register the volume [425] per hour [1400] How strange it was to look into the wood [915] He was wrong on one count at least. [49] It has never been wrong--it can't be wrong. [979]

surrounded by the rough brown boards full of knots [1370] In the vicinity of large knots the grain is likely to be cross. [1139] the loads going in at one end of the kiln [1038] It seemed to move by itself through the air. [578] It was very warm, and left no moisture. [706] This outer portion must either check open or the fibres become strained in tension. [1139] a crack in the knotted rock [1463] A tiny crack appeared there [606] I heard a click, and a little glow lamp came into being. [1461] dry, metallic click was heard. [957] while she wrote a note [12] Nothing new to note! [1400] Next month, perhaps. [462] What's the daily schedule here?" he asked. [325] No review at all? [393]

Original

The kiln operator worked from a chart that specified how quickly each species and thickness could be dried before the expected losses became unacceptable. The chart had been adjusted after a run of claims from a furniture manufacturer. The buyer's price allowed for a certain proportion of boards to crack. A small percentage was an engineering tolerance. Each percentage contained boards which had been living tissues not long before.

A residue of bark on one board contained a beetle chamber. During storage its occupant had survived two periods of cold. The first period had reduced movement but not ended it. The second had delayed emergence. The kiln heated the small space faster than the insect could move into cooler wood. It died while its tissues were still capable of releasing energy through ordinary metabolic reactions. Elsewhere in the stack, spores able to tolerate the conditions persisted. Heat removed many living organisms without purifying the wood of its previous relations, just as the visible inspection removed some defects without eliminating the processes that would make others.

Fine particles moved into the collector. The extraction system was designed to keep airborne concentrations in the workshop below a specified limit, and most of the time it did. During a filter change, a cloud escaped through a poorly secured panel. The men responsible had been told to wear respirators. One mask had a torn strap and the other was in a cupboard shared with solvent containers. A maintenance worker called Dan pulled his shirt over his nose to finish the job. Wood dust entered his lungs in quantities too small for him to feel immediately. Some particles were cleared by ordinary bodily mechanisms; others reached places where clearance was slower. Nothing that happened to him that afternoon entitled the company's incident recorder to open a case. He sneezed twice and was sent to repair the loading gate.

Dan later attended the company's health-and-safety day. A representative from head office encouraged everyone to report near misses and gave out mugs reading SAFETY IS EVERYONE'S BUSINESS. Dan thought about reporting the torn strap. He had reported a broken extractor hose the previous month, which had led to his shift supervisor being disciplined for failing to document an inspection. He took a mug. At home he used it to hold screws. His daughter drew a face on its side with permanent marker. The face faded in the dishwasher and for a while it appeared to be losing an argument.

Quotation version

Improvements in kiln-drying are along the line of moist air operation. [1038] He picked up the chart from the foot of the bed. [1165] there are more manufacturers of furniture [678] In order to prevent cracks at the ends of boards [1139] The engineer fumbled over the knobs. [1002] They contain also the earth of bones. [858] what appeared to be living tissues [1037]

It was like kittens round a beetle. [1461] this beetle passes the winter beneath loose bark. [985] The application of cold storage for preservation purposes is [485] there were alternating periods of lift and free fall [829] It was the work of a second. [842] Its wood is also sometimes attacked by small boring insects. [851] Perhaps it had not just died. [919] the metabolic processes of the tissues [1364] Such spores when subsequently placed under favourable conditions will germinate and start bacterial activity anew. [279] does not tell its past, but contains it like the lines of a hand [219] Remove spots as soon as visible [962]

He blasted them into particles. [372] insist upon their workshops being well ventilated [485] which was a high concentration but still within the tolerance limit. [838] It was a very small cloud of very fine dust. [431] But the only men we ever saw were the doctors. [611] In the assembly hall his mask was whipped off. [1310] He pulled off his shirt, himself. [400] After a while, the job was finished. [1093] He should be dust. [738] A grain of dust is too small for him to notice [280] breathing their lungs full of the fine dust [1274] The dusty particles on the surface are thus removed and replaced by others. [441] Well, nothing at all happened that afternoon. [101] No incident had occurred on the way--worth recording. [1144] Her tenant threw back his head and sneezed. [233] he sneezed twice [993]

he went to attend a meeting of the aforesaid committee. [593] We're supposed to report anything strange or unusual, anybody doesn't act normal. [369] I ought to report [728] its torn fastening [762] His last full inspection had been almost a year ago. [270] the way he grasped the mug [281] the necessary screws and nails [1386] It is the face of a little child! [1016] His face was thin and the sunburn faded, as though he had been ill. [284]

Original

The low-grade residue entered a chip plant. Different scraps were reduced, screened and mixed. No single board survived as a board. The process made it possible to manufacture panels with predictable dimensions from material whose origins were too varied to be marketed individually. A resin bound the particles under pressure and heat. Its supplier had revised the safety information twice in response to changing regulations, and the procurement system showed the revision as COMPLIANT. Some compounds were emitted from freshly made boards, then at lower rates as the product aged. Emissions depended on the resin, temperature, air movement, surface treatment and other variables that were not identical in every room where the boards would be used. A brochure displayed the panel in a bright family kitchen, beside an uncut loaf of bread. No one in the photograph was eating.

At the edge of the factory a container received the fine dust that could not be incorporated economically. It was taken away by a waste contractor who described the material as secondary feedstock. On one journey, rain reached a badly closed load and carried a dark slurry down the side of the vehicle. At a service station some of it accumulated in the gutter. A cleaner washed it into a drain because it was not his job to store substances carried by other firms. He was not wrong about his job. A small crust remained when the water evaporated, cracked under tyres and travelled in particles along the road.

The factory won an award for reducing the amount of virgin timber required per finished panel. The panel count increased in the next year, absorbing the reduction. At the awards photograph the managing director held a wooden plaque manufactured from wood-fibre composite. He had asked whether solid wood would have looked more premium. The supplier said they could provide solid wood for an extra charge but thought it would send the wrong message.

Quotation version

When you think of them all it does seem a waste of wood. [728] Carefully he crushed them to powder. [790] Often several boards are damaged [1139] endlessly varied in material and style [1464] by the pressure of particles of any kind [337] has already received the stamp of popular approval. [540] It was a compliant machine. [933] And still the pale phosphorescense glowed in that detestably ancient woodwork. [895] The air is heavy with the smell of pine and resin. [1381] She took it out of the kitchen, where there is bread enough. [14] bring an uncut loaf of new, white bread. [921] The others began to eat; she ate nothing. [466]

Fine dust drifted down from the roof above. [602] It must not be too fine or contain too great a proportion of dust [425] the materials themselves had been taken away. [593] The gusts of rain had drenched the front of the vehicle [664] This, with the same care, he deposited in the gutter. [873] He was the cleaner. [792] it'll all be down the drain, finished, washed up. [1033] all he was paid for was the time he actually worked [1386] the water evaporated [169]

Enormous fortunes have been made by timber thieves, now respectable members of the community. [1038] Because they have already produced too much. [1386] increases year by year [706] She held a cup, apparently made of wood. [1537] for wooden plates, plaques, baskets [566] His stout back was solid as wood [923] There’s nothing distinctive about it that I could mention--just an ordinary pine-wood [134] solid bulks of wood [946]

Original

In the plantation, the section of wood which would never reach a cabinetmaker had already undergone changes for which the timber yard possessed no classification. Beneath a loose scale of bark an insect had excavated a chamber and laid eggs. The larvae grew while a network of fungal filaments spread through adjacent tissue, benefiting from openings insects had made but not confining itself to them. Some larvae consumed material altered by that growth. Others were themselves entered by mites or smaller parasites which travelled with the parent insects. The bark appeared sound from the road. The log's external diameter was measured and entered into a computer. A considerable part of what lived between the measurement points was not relevant to the diameter.

One of the insects had spent most of its life within a few centimetres of its point of hatching. As a larva it fed through wood softened by fungal action. Its gut community included microorganisms capable of helping break down a diet that would have been useless to many other animals. When the temperature changed, development slowed. It survived a freeze in a protected cavity. Before it could complete the transition to an adult, the trunk was processed. The blade opened its chamber. Most of the larva remained in the wood as tissue; a small portion became dust in the extraction system. The dust collector was marketed as reclaiming value from every fibre. It did not specify whether the fibres were still occupied.

Nearby, another log lay in wet storage beneath a tarpaulin. A beetle had emerged from an exit hole, leaving a round opening in the grain. It reached a second log and laid eggs; a spider took it before it could reach a third. The spider was carrying eggs of its own. Several were parasitised by a minute wasp whose young developed within the spider's egg sacs, consuming contents that would otherwise have become spiders. When the first spiderlings emerged from a different sac, they dispersed on silk carried by moving air. Many landed where prey was scarce. One was eaten by another spider before its first successful feeding. None of this was an especially violent period by the standards of those populations. It was a successful reproductive season for the wasp.

Quotation version

a change of scene was to be supposed though none was visible [1213] soon deposit their eggs on the bark of trees [851] Here the filament passes through the insect from end to end and emerges underneath. [441] a spread network of infinitely delicate filaments [132] There is a material growth; we admit it. [664] There are other insect parasites [91] living parasites, small mites [1056] the sound of hoofs upon the road. [727] They were measuring angles and diameters. [1400] the logs are "scaled," that is measured in order to compute the number of board feet in them [1038] There had been no time to judge distances accurately. [666]

To emerge from underground after the perfect insect is hatched [442] I examine through the magnifying-glass a pinion of a larva ripe for transformation. [445] What do animals eat? [35] Early growth is extremely slow. [1257] Then he stood frozen in the door-frame for a moment. [1218] The trunk contained the wheels and springs, and in the head was fixed the electric battery. [90] Turn on the blades. [1529] Mildewed honey, dust and rubbish, a shrivelled larva, or a larva in good condition? [441] as may the larvae of those species which feed on wood. [1416] a small patch of similar dust [1335] But your real collector values a thing for its rarity. [1472] for all that were of good Fibre [641]

with the log cabins of the tenants or owners close by [649] And is the only exit that small round hole in the distance? [991] The beetle emerges [1170] the wasp reached its burrow and took down the spider [91] Next morning I find the Spider carrying her bag of eggs slung behind her. [447] several large spiders ran out of it into the grass. [701] Probably all of our spiders agree in using the silk for this purpose. [1219] Work was scarce. [500] I have made the acquaintance of a spider who ate her own mother. [439] They were violent. [873] I found nothing unusual: [639] Is it a wasp? [997]

Original

The yard installed three insect hotels on a fence after receiving criticism over habitat loss. The hotels were arranged in a row beside an information board with coloured illustrations of the visitors they were intended to attract. Some cavities were too large for the species pictured; several were drilled with rough interiors which caught on delicate wings. Solitary bees used a few suitable tubes. A species of small wasp used others. A parasitoid found the sealed chambers and inserted eggs through vulnerable points. Several bee larvae were consumed before adulthood. When the staff opened one tube during an inspection, they found an apparently complete row of cells with dead larvae inside. A supervisor concluded that the hotel needed cleaning and asked the maintenance worker to sterilise it. The new nesting season began with clean tubes, fewer surviving bees and no change in the layout of the information board.

An employee named Martin had volunteered to build the hotels from offcuts. He found their condition upsetting, although he was responsible for operating a debarking machine which removed hundreds of small organisms each shift. He did not consider himself inconsistent. The work at the machine was paid, loud and necessary; the insects in the nesting tubes had been promised help. He replaced several split blocks and added a little roof. In June a school group visited. Martin explained that many insects were under threat and deserved protection. A girl asked whether the wasps counted. He told her they did, although they were not the ones illustrated. The girl looked disappointed and asked whether he could take them out.

At the end of a rainy month the wet storage area was drained. Pooled water disappeared through a grate. A mat of fungal growth at the base of one stack began to dry. Tiny organisms inside it became less active or died. A collection of springtails withdrew into the deeper, wetter spaces, where their numbers increased briefly. Food there became scarce. Development stalled in some individuals. Others were eaten by predatory mites already occupying those spaces. A new stack was placed over the same ground. The yard's quarterly report described an improvement in hygiene. The following quarter the pest contractor recommended treatment because insects had begun emerging from the older wood in large numbers. Hygiene was to be improved again.

Quotation version

An insect called the shad-fly also appears at the same time, covering the houses and fences. [1371] Nearby was an information display under a “lean-to shelter.” [870] COLOURED ILLUSTRATIONS [272] Because we may possibly grow wings they cut off their legs. [251] in which several holes are drilled [902] “Where there are bees there must be honey,” he said. [715] A species of Mason-wasp [443] Eggs of animal parasites may be washed in from the surface. [1307] What will the Bee do? [441] the test-tube is filled with larvae [442] they contain dead larvae [441] “Have you ever cleaned with a Vacuum?” she ask to know. [684] They have no change of seasons [906] There's been no change, no new information, I suppose? [722]

had volunteered to help [594] When the machines stopped, he came up to find the reason. [1385] he found them rather upsetting [275] It was a simple machine to operate [780] So there's nothing inconsistent-- [413] a job’s a job, even if it pays by the hour [1057] They split off a few blocks later [1279] I've been to school! [586] Hence, as before explained, the scarcity of insects. [1415] “Yes,” said the girl. [1233] it became an interesting question to know whether this Wasp [446] Yes, he told us that. [1457] Instead, he shoved them out of sight, and grinned at the girl. [142]

The winter was long and black and rainy. [1479] If land be wet, or badly drained [716] The water disappeared. [863] Directly this extraordinary growth encountered water it straightway became gigantic and of unparalleled fecundity. [1465] Such a tiny organism can have only the most rudimentary of memories, but it remembered. [1236] During these rambles by land and water we increased our collections considerably. [77] Their number went on increasing. [1541] Food was becoming scarce. [487] Simple arrest of development is one. [1313] Hardier peoples were already hovering over the prey. [1114] At bottom, it's the same thing. [556] Hygiene that was what they call now. [728] When the pest does not yield to this treatment, a spray is recommended. [1489] A large number of insects of many kinds [337] Her clothes were improved now, even fine. [409]

Original

When a buyer complained about the condition of a batch, the yard offered a discount. The contract allowed a percentage of biological damage, stated as a limit on the size and frequency of visible holes. The buyer accepted the revised price and sold the pieces as reclaimed rustic timber. A restaurant used them for shelves above tables serving food grown in heated warehouses. The menus announced a commitment to the living world. Two screws were driven through an area containing a dried egg chamber. The casing cracked and fell in pieces behind the shelving. Several other chambers remained closed. During the first warm autumn, small beetles appeared along the restaurant's walls. They were treated as a breach of food safety, which in that setting they were. The inspector gave the restaurant twenty-eight days to take action. It needed ten.

The board emerged suitable for narrow pieces, not the panel specified. Leena marked it again. A saw divided it. One piece went to a cabinetmaker, two to architectural trim, the rest to a chip hopper. The cut ends exposed bands of grain the grading system had never recorded.

The cabinetmaker, Abdul, had an order for four shelves. The customer wanted something 'honest-looking': exposed grain, no visible fixings, and a colour appearing not to be a colour. The customer supplied reference photographs taken in a room with artificial lighting and a floor finish nobody could identify. Abdul prepared three samples and explained the relationship between stain and absorption. The customer listened patiently before saying he preferred wood that looked more natural. He selected the sample that had received the most treatment. Abdul had learned not to correct the adjectives of people paying in full.

A shelf from the marked board entered a flat above a pharmacy. It held gardening books and keys in a ceramic bowl. Brackets transferred the load to a brick wall. The pale band remained visible beneath the finish.

Quotation version

That's about the natural discount for a woman. [622] These holes should be bored to a uniform depth. [566] near the limit of visibility. [476] they had been obliged to accept the timbering tariff [1541] in which case the buyer made the price [1335] They sat at a little table in the restaurant. [1519] shops and storage warehouses of local food supplies. [321] A coexistent world. [1431] Their world is one of menus [1043] At the aperture of the egg-chamber [445] I think the case can be cracked right now. [605] Then the tomb closed. [395] The beetles appear from June to August. [851] The holes were probably made at first by small beetles of various families [1120] the food trays were set before them and they ate their sufficiency. [22] I waited twenty-four hours and then alerted you. [751] it needs ten [435]

The panel may be made of one board or of matched boards [1038] Is it marked? [372] The object struck was harder than the saw. [989] The next morning both chips and beaker were gone without trace [895] chipping a piece off its edge. [1513] not only devouring the grain upon the straw that had never been cut [706]

The four remaining orders, though large, can be easily characterized. [288] The wood is fine-grained, hard, and a rich reddish brown color. [669] authentic, expertized, genuine tree-grown wood. [1112] “We have everything on this floor photographed,” he said. [1094] The sitting-room depended entirely upon artificial light. [1419] See that stain up there? [1356] Did I not listen to you in the wood before we started [659] his new samples had been satisfactorily selected [409] If the sum demanded were beyond their resources, they could not pay it. [1206]

Over the door there was a board nailed flat against the wall. [664] “And have you got all the garden keys?” [701] All they needed was the brick of discovery; then they could build their wall. [1021] The pale band had broadened into a clear vast space of light [915]

Original

Other boards yielded thin decorative sheets, sliced and prepared by a separate supplier before being bonded to manufactured panels. Their destinations appeared as numbers in an order book, with different tolerances, dimensions and finish codes. One batch failed an inspection for visible streaks; the rejected sheets went to another buyer, for whom those streaks would be sold as character. The material had no difficulty accommodating the disagreement. It had never been uniform. Uniformity was a standard applied from outside and revised when it became expensive.

In the yard, a machine threw sawdust into a collection system. Heavy particles settled; lighter ones travelled farther before reaching a filter. The largest fraction went into engineered board. Another was burnt as fuel by a local business displaying a sign that read RENEWABLE HEAT. The sign had been paid for with a grant whose reporting requirements concerned quantities of fuel rather than the smoke carried downwind. On certain mornings that smoke entered the bedrooms of a terrace near the bypass, where residents were encouraged to keep their windows open to prevent condensation. The benefits and costs were distributed unevenly, without anyone having arranged a meeting to agree the distribution.

At lunch Leena's daughter asked by text whether she would pay for driving lessons. The message ended with a heart. Leena considered the cost and remembered an accident she had never told her daughter about. She wrote YES IF YOU PASS THE THEORY FIRST, deleted the condition and sent YES. She regretted it for two minutes and then enjoyed the decision.

Behind the warehouse, water collected in an oil-marked depression. A discarded screw lay at the bottom, darkening where a break in its coating admitted water. The supervisor had asked that scrap be removed before an inspection; the cleaner had been sent to a different site; the inspector had examined the fire doors and left. A snail crossed the wet edge of the concrete. The screw remained. Neither the screw nor the snail had any means of knowing that the yard had received a satisfactory report. Their subsequent encounters with the water were unaffected by the report's conclusion.

Quotation version

the sheets of thin paper in the other [923] was sliced up very thin [1206] I originally intended to “correct” some of the numbers in the book. [1400] The shopkeeper looked into his order-book. [594] different dimensions [1018] These scraps of paper fail me. [376] but with a few white streaks still visible [337] Besides this, there were material difficulties to deal with. [1475] Too bad that you wear the enemy uniform. [776] If the standard changes, how can there be improvement, which implies a standard? [251]

with heaps of sawdust by the sawing-machine and its engine. [1465] Hence, the settling of such particles, if in mechanical suspension, would be measurable, although very slow. [1364] And the engineer went on his way. [587] they say that with such fuel the house would be burnt down. [487] I take it they wanted you to sign this report, too? [1092] He had a certain quantity of fuel to do it with [339] We have some ventilation here, and you may smoke if you wish. [961] keep your windows open [99] They were no more inclined than entitled to demand his money. [43]

“”””What is to pay?” said I.--”Did you drink any thing, sir?”--”Certainly. [192] The message stopped abruptly. [31] I had never told him about the incident. [262] “That's just theory,” she said. [1287] She realized it as perhaps a mistake. [1483] I almost regretted my decision. [181]

It was oil and water [873] A pool of water lay on the bottom. [1504] The inspection window seemed to be designed for the very purpose [490] Much obliged, sir,” said the Inspector, and left the room. [1412] It was a snail. [1521] All the flowers hung heavy with wet, snails marched on the paths [718] The screw is stopped. [1402] no report having been received from him. [1180] We reported the discovery of water and held up the fish. [130]

IV. The Second Wedding: Resistance

Original

By the second wedding June had concluded that the church door's defect was permanent and the committee's money was not. A carpenter trimmed its lower edge for cash and declined to issue a receipt. The fresh wood showed above the threshold. The door opened freely during rehearsal and stayed shut when required. The committee placed an item called DOOR—RESOLVED in the minutes. June kept the original entry open. The trimming had made the gap beneath the door large enough for rain to enter under a particular wind.

The second wedding took place in a different church with a different problem. Its organ had been renovated when grants were available. The contractor had replaced parts, cleaned the mechanism and supplied a folder of instructions that the church treasurer had stored with the insurance policies. One valve occasionally failed to return. The defect depended on temperature, humidity and recent use, none of which the insurance policies addressed. It did not occur during the organist's rehearsal.

At Bernard and Lydia's wedding the valve stayed open after a low note had been released. Air continued through the pipe. Eleanor, the organist, shifted the harmony until the sustained pitch became almost useful. She taught three days a week, had recently received medical news she wasn't yet sharing, and had been asked to play for half her usual fee because the couple were friends of the treasurer. The congregation found the entrance unusually solemn. Bernard looked back several times, convinced the organ was expressing a view of his prospects.

The organ occupied a loft where the air moved less readily than it did among the congregation. Dust lay across the wooden cases and along the upper edges of pipes. A mouse had entered through a gap beside a cable and made a nest in material removed from an old hymnbook. The book had been left in storage because its pages carried a previous rector's annotations and could not be thrown away without consulting the family. The mouse shredded the annotations along with the rest. Its nest survived until a contractor opened the loft and removed it with a brush. The mouse had died before that, in a trap placed by a different contractor whose invoice described preventative pest management. Its fleas dispersed when its body cooled. Several found nothing they could use and died on the boards.

Quotation version

The church next door had been sold. [239] acknowledge therein the receipt of the cash [414] Was it there as in the fresh woods? [14] The door opened and shut--there was no lock. [595] that entry in the minutes, [564] Her Date Book had to be kept on the Double Entry System. [9] the rain was still falling and drove in through the partly open door [1386] The rain entered diagonally [673]

Inside the church, the wedding was going on. [788] A few needful repairs were soon made [1415] The contract for its repair and replacement has already been let. [1384] it was replaced by a new part [720] the valves will fail to work properly [739] None the less, you are right in declaring them defective. [687] was the use of an insurance policy? [662] “Yes,” said the organist. [593]

If the valve is open [1377] or the valve which released the air from it. [1526] It was in the air. [828] the organist loitered over the keys [623] an organist, a teacher of the theory and harmony of music [154] She had paid half [1064] The news of this event was received by her some weeks later [1472] she came down for half her usual fee. [114] The phrase arrests by its musical cadences, by its solemn, mournful music. [277] He fancied that he heard music [863] He looked back, not once but several times. [1452]

the air became still and warm. [863] the organ loft [1443] The dust lay thick. [923] the mouse [201] The mouse entered the tunnel [1296] made a comfortable nest there. [201] Presently she returned the book to the shelf [1531] They bundled their books away [728] Rare books perish [657] The door of the loft was open. [792] I removed a great part of this nest [658] a trap was set [1242] I caught in a trap a singular little mouse [333] As the vital heat declined the fleas deserted their host [707] Of course they found nothing. [1471]

Original

A small patch of fungal growth had developed on the timber behind the loft's leaking flashing. Repair work had been authorised the previous year and postponed when costs rose. A temporary sheet covered the flashing, fastening the water's route to the wall rather than the roof. When the organ was played, the air pressure inside some pipes changed rapidly, but the moisture in the surrounding timber did not respond on the same schedule. The defective valve was a combination of wear, adjustment and environmental conditions. If the organist had lived in the loft, she might have anticipated the pitch by the state of the morning air. She preferred to live in a house with a kitchen.

For several seconds the stuck note provided the music with a centre nobody had intended. People grew attentive without knowing why. The tone was not expressive in the way Bernard feared. It was the consequence of air escaping along a permitted route that had failed to close. Yet the audience heard solemnity, impending disaster, a joke, a warning and, in one elderly guest's account, an encouraging resemblance to the voice of her dead husband. No account changed the pressure at the valve. The guest went home feeling comforted. Eleanor stayed late, unable to persuade a spring to return properly. There was no reason for either response to correct the other.

The church had acquired a digital system that measured heating efficiency. A small sensor beside the organ showed a temperature slightly higher than that near the entrance. The administrator discovered this discrepancy and proposed turning the heat down, as the organ loft was clearly warm enough. Eleanor asked how the loft was relevant to people sitting in the cold aisle. He said the sensor was part of an integrated system, and they should trust the data. She said she would if they put the data in a coat and made it sit through a service.

During the reception, while Eleanor was turning off the organ's supply, the mouse's vacated nesting site was entered by a spider. It found two dead insects and a living one. It fed, then waited in a crevice for movement. Months later the rotten flashing would be replaced and the spider's web cleared away. The loft would become dry enough to discourage the particular growth found on its timber, but the cavity around the cable would remain. A different mouse would enter. The repair certificate would list the work as completed in full.

Quotation version

The different forms of decay in wood are accompanied by fungi [288] It had to be postponed to the following year. [245] the walls so constructed that they drew and retained moisture [1386] In the distance pipes an organ . . . [621] where it is desirable to know not only the average moisture content but also its distribution through the timber [1139] When this valve becomes worn and begins to leak [739] There was something mysterious in the air that morning. [201] The kitchen had perhaps originally been the house [711]

The note was a firm clear one [492] They listened, finding it difficult to make the effort of understanding. [791] His tone was helpless. [165] The air that made life possible was escaping. [1407] It was sending her its warning of some impending disaster. [1061] and heard the notes of solemn music [1134] the elderly female [297] that her husband was dead [664] The valve became unfastened. [863] I always feel happy when we have a guest. [1265] stayed late that night [1386] For a time there was no response. [764]

efficiency [252] with a slightly higher mean temperature [1102] who were climbing the stairway into the organ-loft. [1172] they had it warm enough. [854] is it not cold? [1461] Data poured into his sensors. [264] I interpreted it, integrated it [783] and I must trust to my subsequent investigations to put the reader in possession of data for forming a judgment on these points. [859] I don’t count. [84] she could hardly sit through the service [561]

There was a little nest where she had lain, and spiders’ webs hung overhead. [593] spider has her nest between his leaves [439] A living insect is a more efficient object than a dead one [337] He stood and waited for her to make the next move. [1238] Web walked quickly away in the sand. [1235] He even saw the lighted dryness of the loft behind [792] Yeah, you’ll get a mouse behin’ there. [885] A half hour’s work was sufficient to repair the damage [204]

Original

Bernard was frightened enough to take solemnity personally. Lydia nearly laughed. She loved his ability to make a catastrophe out of arranging chairs, though it had been a more useful quality when they were still enjoying it as courtship. Her family had argued over the seating plan for six weeks. One aunt would not sit near a brother because he had called her late husband a profiteer; another would not sit near the windows because she had once developed a cold at a christening. Nobody minded sitting near the fire exit, provided they were not described as expendable.

After the vows Eleanor returned to a triumphant passage. The defective valve finally closed, silencing the low note so abruptly that Bernard turned. The congregation left. Eleanor tested the mechanism and wrote a note for the repairer. The fault would return next Sunday during communion.

At the reception Gareth collected insults from guests, polished them and offered them back. Matthew disliked the practice when it worked and loved him most acutely when it failed. Gareth had asked Bernard's uncle, an expert in agricultural subsidies, whether there was a dishonest side to his work. The uncle answered for twenty minutes, naming six committees and a particularly reliable spreadsheet. Gareth missed the first course.

'You do this to yourself,' Matthew said.

'I thought he might be corrupt. He was merely detailed.'

'Perhaps you should have asked a better question.'

'I asked whether he was interesting. He said yes.'

Matthew took the roll from Gareth's side plate, tore it and returned the larger half. They had lived together seven years. He knew which foods Gareth would leave, how long he would deny being ill, the particular silence that meant an apology was due. Gareth knew the turns in Matthew's moods, though he sometimes used the knowledge to win arguments. A distant cousin called them old friends. Matthew didn't correct her; Gareth did, loudly and with an illustration involving their bedroom. Afterwards the cousin congratulated herself on being open-minded. She was relieved not to have been asked anything.

Quotation version

he was frightened, too. [790] She almost laughed [477] He pushed a chair to the table and built up the seat with cushions [1097] the careful arrangement of the chairs [391] She wanted to enjoy courtship. [792] Sometimes she argued with the children about their plans, and ridiculed them. [1386] His aunt was sitting near the bed. [246] There was no fire. [63] that no one is expendable. [1063]

a burst of triumphant music [1539] He had turned abruptly. [1195] The valves closed on it. [831] But he was still left alone in it when the congregation had assembled. [427] It was tested over and over-- [51] The next day was Sunday. [718]

He offered these seats to his guests, who accepted them in silence. [164] And it never failed him to the last. [725] uncle [273] Because some are dishonest, are all dishonest?" he appealed. [1453] For each of the six offices, three candidates had been chosen by a committee. [853] Missed everything, of course. [283]

“You nearly got yourself cut down,” he said. [179]

I was not corrupting him! [398] But this was merely a minor detail. [873]

“You have asked me a difficult question,” she said. [647]

“Did I miss something interesting?” he asked. [1096] “Well,” he said. [1435]

With which he tore open the covering of one of the rolls. [1355] who had lived with him [1376] A long silence was finally broken by the sick man. [1426] he knew, to a subtlety, the foods [462] The apology is due [1513] he knew. [1295] who knew him intimately in all his moods [843] and this knowledge gave an energy to his arguments [1177] We called each other familiarly by the name of cousin. [1255] he corrected her. [1520] She in turn opened her mind to him. [1454] She was relieved [235]

Original

Charles was congratulated on arriving without a girlfriend. A relative introduced him to Harriet, a property lawyer prepared to talk about something else for three minutes. Charles held her empty glass, not knowing whether he'd offered to fetch another.

Carrie appeared. Charles stopped listening to Harriet, still holding her glass. Carrie saw his expression and came over, smiling warmly enough to make his prospects seem reasonable until she spoke.

'You survived another one,' she said.

'People are getting efficient. I barely had time to arrive late.'

'I wanted to introduce you to somebody.'

The somebody was Hamish. He was taller than Charles, older than Carrie, and possessed a calm that came in part from having inherited enough money not to mistake delay for danger. He used his handsome hands economically. Carrie had met him in Edinburgh. He was going to marry her, she said. Charles wondered whether this sounded less alarming to the person who had asked.

Then Hamish put out a hand.

'Wonderful to meet you. Carrie says you're terribly funny.'

'Only when frightened,' Charles replied.

'Then I hope I've given you an opportunity.'

Hamish laughed. Charles found it difficult to dislike him and resented the effort this imposed. In later years he would recall the man's good manners more vividly than his face.

At the opposite end of the room the catering trolley had returned. Its damaged wheel had worsened. The tyre's flat region extended with each period of loading; grit entered the bearing. Pavel, the waiter, pushed it at an angle to reduce the squeal. His agency had told him to arrive forty minutes early without pay, a request described as showing initiative. Pavel calculated that, if he showed enough initiative, he could eventually be unpaid for half a day. The kitchen entrance required a sharp turn and the room was narrow.

Quotation version

had congratulated him [1474] introduced him [41] who had already begun to talk about something else. [1183] He held the empty glass to the light, then set it down, regretfully. [494]

Carrie appeared there. [409] He stopped after a moment and listened. [1362] Carrie smiled [458] looking down, smiling warmly. [520]

I have survived safe and sound. [247]

People could be real efficient. [928] Better to be a little late than a little early. [1269]

And then: “I want to introduce you to—” [922]

Perhaps there was somebody there. [1522] He was oblivious of the danger of the terrible power of the older man [1405] He was taller than I. [1460] It was a case of inherited money. [1478] The handsome man put his hands in his pockets. [82] I met him there [799] that man's going to marry her [1468] what is it? [803] it sounded so very alarming [1194]

He put out his hand [1460]

We are wonderful. [748] “Oh, you're such a very funny man,” she declared. [771]

“No,” she said, frightened. [790]

“I haven't given up hope!” he said. [883]

Then he laughed. [1108] for he found even the slight physical effort difficult. [114] The face did appear familiar, but he could not recall the occasion. [761]

At last they came to the last room at the end of the corridor. [652] It was my wheel. [640] He seemed to think my bearing had been of set purpose [392] I didn't know he'd turn yellow and squeal. [437] He told me to send you up the minute you arrived. [1039] They had been waiting forty minutes [1271] He was absent for half an hour perhaps. [1130] Their daywork, paid or unpaid [564] I turned and rushed out of the room and down the hall to the stairway. [1367]

Original

When Bernard's father rose to make a speech, Pavel attempted to pass behind him. The wheel caught the raised edge of a carpet tile. The trolley's forward motion stopped while the glasses on its top tray continued sliding. For an instant, the entire arrangement depended upon the friction between glass, damp linen and polished metal. Pavel tightened his grip and pulled back. Almost all the glasses stayed where they were.

One continued travelling. It reached the edge, tilted, fell and broke on the floor.

Bernard's father paused.

'Well,' he said, 'that's one way of ending the marriage before I've finished the speech.'

Laughter released the guests from their obligation to be quiet. Pavel crouched to gather the glass. Five people warned him about sharp fragments, all in the careful tone used to address an unfamiliar animal. The manager asked whether he had cut himself but went away before hearing the answer. Pavel had not. He had a second job at a warehouse and couldn't afford a bandaged hand. The manager later made him sign a statement confirming that the incident had not involved defective equipment. He signed it beneath a printed sentence explaining that all statements were voluntary.

The wheel was replaced on Monday. The old fitting had to be heated before it released the axle. The mechanic set the damaged wheel aside with the other rejected parts, recording its removal under ROUTINE MAINTENANCE because the form had no box for AVOIDED FOR MONTHS. The replacement was slightly smaller. The trolley now stood at an angle and drew left when pushed. Pavel complained. The manager said the matter had been addressed, which was true of the wheel he had complained about, though not of the new problem.

Charles avoided Carrie for an hour, then found himself behind a pillar with her. She was not apologetic about Hamish. He understood there was nothing to apologise for and resented the inconvenience of understanding it.

'You could have told me,' he said.

'I didn't know when I last saw you.'

Quotation version

Then he rose to make a speech. [788] he rose to make a speech. [788] She raised herself on her hands and crawled along the carpet [37] then it stopped and slid easily to the left [202] The trolley with its frequent stops [1014] as though it were one sliding motion. [970] were not glass but a transparent metal of some sort. [585] I admit that linen is damp. [1321] His grip on my shoulder tightened. [899] Haven't worn glasses since I was ten. [138]

He has traveled. [412] It fell on the floor. [702]

Father paused. [873]

“Well, that's it,” he said. [973]

The guests sat in astonished silence. [953] At this the guests gave way to their applauding laughter. [905] He came back with the glass full. [494] A sixth sense warned him, or perhaps it was some slight sound. [606] the tone seemed to carry a sharp warning. [1387] “Was he by himself?” asked the manager. [726] he had not. [1198] His hand was still all bandaged. [917] He couldn't afford to lose any money. [1543] He needed the job. [746] Various managers of departments stopped him, he had to solve difficulties and confirm orders. [1540] It would have to be voluntary. [1201]

Only one wheel on it, right front. [1083] the rude wheels fitting but badly on the axle [706] several other wrecks lay nearby, stripped of their tyres and chromium trim [59] He wrenched the wheel aside. [555] Very much smaller—? [697] We turned off the main road, at right angles, and drew up. [807] They complained. [876] It seemed as if there was no solution to his problem. [1303] That's another way of looking at the matter,” assented the general manager. [589] It is not a new problem [1193]

behind a pillar [593] My dear man, you’re so apologetic about never being apologetic! [855] He had ceased to apologise for, or seek to justify his action. [921]

“I told you; I told you,” he mumbled. [283]

You see—since I saw you last—— [1484]

Original

'You knew you were in love with someone.'

'I knew I liked someone. There's a period between those things.'

'How long?'

'I don't know. You seem to have been enjoying it for years.'

He wanted to take offence, but had no evidence against her. She looked tired for the first time since arriving.

'I thought I'd feel different when he asked,' she said. 'I do, just not consistently.'

'You don't have to marry him.'

'I know.'

'And I'm not saying that because—'

'I know that part too.'

They stopped speaking. Music reached them through the plaster. Carrie returned to the room; Charles waited before following.

Fiona had seen enough of Charles and Carrie to understand that the news was bad for Charles and unreasonably good for his self-regard. She went outside before she could make matters worse by telling the truth. Tom was on the terrace eating a piece of cake he had secured before the speeches.

'You look unhappy,' he said.

'I'm being punished for something I haven't done.'

'Is that a family tradition?'

'In this family it's the catering.'

He gave her half the cake. For several minutes they discussed the building's astonishing extension. Fiona found relief in disliking something that couldn't hear her. Tom thought he had said something helpful and wisely made no further attempt.

Quotation version

There is someone you love? [174] He loved someone else from the beginning—before I knew him. [546]

I knew how he felt. [53] He alternated between periods of screaming and reading. [694]

For how long? [1041]

I don't know. [1509] You seem to have enjoyed yourself. [728]

She had not been swayed by all the evidence against him. [412] She seemed to relax for the first time since last night. [1528]

“I'd rather thought that myself,” he admitted. [1363] He had thought he would feel very different [320] I cannot seem to think clearly or consistently. [1180]

You don’t want to marry him! [1517]

“I know I am,” he said. [969]

I'm saying it because it's true. [1008]

That part I know very well. [1456]

His voice stopped and the silence spoke. [175] Neither was it music-hall sentiment. [712] The room in which he sat waiting was a hallway. [1398]

Indeed, she could see that the news had really done her good. [271] Then she went outside again and looked. [957] to explain, made matters worse. [793] taken a piece of cake [41] he was forced to eat cake. [1183]

There was an unhappy expression on his face. [1129]

I must not only punish, but punish with impunity. [1106]

a sort of tradition in the family. [1333]

You're to consider yourself one of the family. [625]

He gave her half, and they began to eat. [198] it was not the discovery of the building that had so astonished me [638] They were her token to the face, even though it couldn't hear. [820] Tom made no attempt [249]

Original

Eleanor tested the organ the following afternoon. The note returned. The repairer couldn't come until the end of the month. Eleanor practised a piece in which the note could be tolerated.

Quotation version

play the organ [1067] you will return my notes [45] And trying to make it last for six months was no solution. [1430] she was practising [1198]

V. Several Unrelated Matters

Original

Beneath the pavement outside the first church, the ribbon remained woven into leaves and silt. June removed the leaves with a piece of wire, missed the ribbon and went to unlock the building for another funeral.

The deceased was eighty-eight and had requested a recording that the church equipment could no longer play. June found a compact disc player, placed it on a hymnal stand and connected it with an extension lead running across the aisle. A relative produced a different recording on a telephone. The service began late while six mourners negotiated the use of a cable. A version of the desired piece eventually played, followed by a recorded voice asking the listener to subscribe. Nobody mentioned the interruption until afterwards, when everyone agreed it was a disgrace. The dead woman had enjoyed unwanted interruptions when she was alive. Her grandson could not decide whether this made it better.

Leena received a photograph of her daughter beside the driving instructor's car. The girl looked proud; the instructor looked cold. The radio announced an accident on the bypass. Leena switched it off.

Abdul was asked to replace a shelf that had fallen when a bracket tore through plaster. He inspected the wall and explained that the timber wasn't at fault. The customer ordered better timber anyway. Abdul supplied it and charged for it. The material was indeed better.

The old trolley wheel travelled through a succession of increasingly confident descriptions. At the hotel it had been faulty equipment. On the mechanic's workbench it was a replacement part. In the scrap container it became mixed material; at the processing site, waste rubber; in the recovery estimate, a percentage of diverted landfill. The physical portion that survived each name change did not need to remain recognisable as a wheel. The axle was taken off, the rim crushed and the remaining composite divided into particles of different sizes. Some were recovered for use in surfaces designed to absorb impact. Others were lost in fines too contaminated to meet the buyer's specification.

Quotation version

They were outside in the shadow of the church. [254] The pavement, too, was strewn with leaves [1398] No funeral was held over the strangely released bones [898]

He abandoned the society of the deceased, and took a private lodging. [87] died at the age of eighty-eight [1225] An aisle leading to the court-room in Helium. [203] Not the telephone. [253] I was a little late, but I gave service, don't you think? [514] After a time a voice called from the house: [183] A few seconds passed without interruption of the silence. [191] That it has been disgraced, I agree. [1483] They had talked about this dead woman throughout the evening [140] She couldn't love a real father better. [1090] to decide whether it were best. [409]

The instructor sat between the mother and daughter. [21] The girl looked interested. [1515] It was radio [1155] switched off. [1059]

a brick or some plaster fallen down [1386] The second incident wasn't his fault, at all. [1366] Pay us more and we will timber better [1541] They charged down on him [748] indeed the only kind of material [425]

The wheel turned [1064] defective equipment [1421] Got a faulty gasket on the replacement. [505] Probably that scrap of rubber was imbedded in a hunk of wax right now. [931] It may be not unimportant to understand how names are altered. [568] In most cases things remain while names change [212] The axle did not revolve, but simply vibrated backwards and forwards. [1018] as the particles were crushed together or swept apart by the motion. [863] the metallic surfaces were slided back [906] The lawsuit, the terrible lawsuit, was lost. [155]

Original

At a small facility on the edge of an industrial estate, rubber granulate was screened for metal. A magnet lifted fragments that contained enough ferrous material to respond. A particle with a brass-coloured remnant passed beneath the magnet. At a later stage, a worker watched the stream for anything visibly unsuitable. The particle was black, rounded and ordinary-looking. It passed. The line did not require the worker to imagine how each particle had been used before it arrived, or how it would behave after purchase. Such a system would have reduced production to a halt in the first hour.

A school bought material from the recycler for a soft surface beneath play equipment. The specification included resistance to weathering and a limit on certain hazardous substances. The figures came from tests performed on representative samples, not from the individual particle that had been part of the trolley wheel. Sunlight, rain and abrasion changed the surface after installation. Children landed on it, twisted their shoes and dragged metal toys across it. The material softened their falls and released fine particles into the air and surrounding drains. Two properties of the surface were true at once. Only one was listed beneath the playground's new sign, which thanked the council for investing in safer play.

Beneath the boundary fence a drainage channel carried escaped granules towards a patch of weeds and a narrow stream. Some particles lodged in the roots. Others travelled with high water. A caddisfly larva used grains and fragments from the streambed to assemble a portable case. The case included one small piece of dark polymer. It did not become poisonous or significant simply because its material had travelled farther than the larva could know. But the larva's structure now contained substances introduced through manufacturing and disposal processes far beyond the stream. During a flood the case was broken against a stone. The larva was taken by a fish. The polymer fragment remained among the sediment. By the following spring the school had ordered a new safety inspection and installed brighter signs asking children to play carefully.

Quotation version

What did it signify, the coming to life of metal and plastic? [370] He said that it was a magnet. [205] C, Brass support for magnet. [96] What was the navigator doing up here at this time of watch? [929] In the developing fluids it turned entirely black. [503] They passed. [874] further thought was not required. [594] Even under the present silly system of restricted production [1386]

for it was wondrous material to play on! [697] We find that resistance is to substances not so mixed in or incorporated. [483] Parts of the robot were going together and being tested [1084] the tests have been successfully performed [1041] The sunlight was shifting. [1283] so much was the surface changed [551] And the children have some toys. [594] His fall was softened a little by the carpet [730] surface being an accidental property of bodies [1171] There was no noise on the playgrounds. [727] In thanking the Council for acceding to his request [1334]

One of the boundary fences lay only two blocks away. [724] towards a little stream which murmured evermore among its weeds. [620] The root hairs cannot “eat” particles of soil [1336] They floated high in the water [875] It consists of a single silken wrapper, so thin and fine that the larva shows through it. [446] the pieces of silk which he took from an open case. [1540] Yet the poison could not be established. [841] modifications in the adult will probably often affect the structure of the larva [334] But in the morning the stone was broken. [620] afterwards taken from the dead fish. [971] Just a fragment remained of the haystack, a monument squared and brown, like a pillar of stone. [790] They'll need to know it in order to follow your directions. [1293] Adults get nervous about kids going outside. [210]

Original

Pavel, who had pushed the trolley at the wedding, watched a training video explaining that minor accidents should be reported without fear. The manager asked him to initial a form confirming he had watched it. Pavel said the wheel had been reported before the accident. The manager replied that the video was about building a culture of openness, not revisiting individual cases. A printed diagram showed a green arrow moving from INCIDENT to LEARNING to IMPROVEMENT. Pavel signed. The new wheel was already wearing unevenly. The arrow remained green throughout the presentation.

In a low-lying field beyond the town, a drainage pump switched on for the first time after several weeks of inactivity. The pump's task was to remove water from the land as quickly as the channel permitted. It was powered by a motor whose bearings had been replaced during the summer. A heron stood nearby, watching the shallow ditch. Water began moving towards the outlet; loose stems, silt and a dense cloud of small organisms shifted with it. Several snails lost their holds on vegetation and rolled along the bottom. A freshwater amphipod reached the intake screen and was trapped by the flow. The screen had been installed to protect the pump. It did this effectively. An accumulation of living and dead matter developed against it, altering the pressure across the mesh until the pump's controller issued an alarm. The contractor came out next morning, cleared the screen with a rake and recorded a successful return to service. The heron caught a fish while he worked.

The field had once flooded regularly. Its owners had spent years improving the drainage so that machinery could enter for longer periods. The resulting harvests were more predictable, and the surrounding ditches carried more water during storms. Downstream, a stand of trees declined where winter flows began scouring the bank around their roots. One fell into the channel and was cut into manageable lengths by the council's emergency contractor. A section of the trunk carried a bracket fungus whose fruiting bodies had been visible for years. The saw passed through its internal growth, which extended much farther through the wood than the visible shelves suggested. The section was removed to a yard and chipped. Several fungal fragments survived long enough to be transported with the chips. Most did not establish new growth. The invoices for drainage, tree removal and chip transport appeared in three separate budgets. Each budget demonstrated successful management.

Quotation version

Perhaps you had better tell the captain about your accident. [1145] the written record and programme [540] The accident is over. [1085] Ambiguous or vague questions often lead to no response at all, leaving the poster discouraged. [740] When the Plumies understood what we were doing, and why, they drew diagrams. [832] I will sign the contract [1246] The new Wheel-Foot Articles were loudspeakered and posted. [827] the arrow will not move. [1537]

How long can you guarantee to keep your pumps working? [171] it is a low-lying field [46] It was directed towards the pumps, while fresh water replaced it in proportion. [1402] Solar generators and tide motors? [1285] motor began to spin [385] Here is a great tree, standing close to the ditch. [79] Toward midnight, small clouds began to drift oceanward. [304] The water began to move. [1163] tumbling snails' shells [634] A long minute flowed by and still the alien hung there. [385] A pump, and a filter-system were installed. [1093] The beggar did the trick very effectively. [1291] The inflated membrane shot up with frightful velocity into the air. [405] all matter, living or dead [792] The pressure was suffocating [1483] had returned and was again standing at service. [123] He returned the next morning at an early hour. [852] First, the fish must be caught. [230]

Instead of flooding the surface of the fields [202] For years the old drain-pipes had been defective and leaky. [1386] much improved by the drainage of some little pools [333] the ditches and dry water-ways. [560] Water is coming down the ditches to our fields. [1498] The Trees forgot their roots. [1186] would have cut a channel for itself [333] The fruiting body of the fungus bears the seed or spores. [851] Some way up the trunk of the tree an immense flat fungus projected [707] Then as the saw is gradually lowered, the kerf will extend quite across the wood. [1038] rudely chipped [1466] All day long our chips are flying. [1123] chips of wood, shreds of bark [442] The growth presently stopped. [318] The burden includes all expenses and salaries necessary for the maintenance of the business. [604] He was successful. [1266]

Original

On a road beside the pumping station, salt was spread before a forecast frost. It dissolved as cars passed, carried into gutters and then through the drainage network. At the edge of a pond a concentration of dissolved ions changed after the first thaw. The change was within a range the local amphibians sometimes survived. Several frog eggs developed normally. Others were lost during a period of low oxygen followed by a sudden drop in temperature. A thin film gathered on the pond where an outfall disturbed the surface. Two mallards searched the shallows. One ate a larva and left a thread of weed behind its bill. The pond remained a pond. Its remaining organisms were not compensated for the eggs that did not hatch, nor did their continuation repair a loss belonging to a different life.

At the council office a report was prepared under the title RESILIENCE. Its author had six years' experience of environmental policy and a mortgage large enough to make resignation unthinkable. She was required to present evidence that flood risk had declined, biodiversity had been supported and maintenance costs had remained under control. Each statement could be supported by a measure. She rearranged the paragraphs until the measures no longer appeared to contradict one another. The final report was sixty-two pages, including an appendix of photographs taken on a sunny afternoon. Her manager praised the clarity of the executive summary. She went to collect her son from school and sat in the car for ten minutes before going in. She couldn't remember whether she had eaten lunch.

There was also a ditch behind the school, into which rain carried dark granules from the new playground surface. Children threw sticks into it. One stick lodged against the culvert. Another passed through and emerged in the weed bed downstream. During a storm, trapped leaves increased the depth upstream until water reached the school path. The headteacher sent parents a message saying that drainage works were being prioritised. A contractor cleared the culvert and disposed of the debris as mixed municipal waste, with the polymer granules distributed through the wet plant matter. He paid the fee at the weighbridge. The council's grant for the playground had closed. Nobody was obliged to distinguish the rubber from the willow twigs in the bag.

Quotation version

The crisp frost lay like salt upon the grass. [1491] Then I got into the sink ... out through the gutter, the gutter-pipe, the ditch and so on. [439] The waters lay smooth as a pond [656] concentration of dissolved substances in the surface layer [1364] so closely limited is the local range of this species. [272] The frog brought her eggs [439] The temperature was very low [1402] Now there is a sudden drop in the temperature. [567] A thin film of ice bordered the flat, reed-grown lake. [1491] I had known the shallows. [477] the larva was placidly eating its Flies as though nothing had happened. [446] There was a pond there [1541] I had seen that the eggs were in the process of hatching [202] the eggs will remain in the cells many months without hatching. [108]

their offices had dwindled down to mere titles [702] The Council was very gratified with your report [437] Six years. [728] There is a large mortgage against it, however. [1243] Instead, she sank under the flood of them--sick and certain. [1078] but little evidence is required. [319] “The references in support of these statements are the following:--” [232] There were a hundred ways in which she might contradict this, but she used none of them. [159] She took the pages, folded them and replaced them carefully in her pocket. [348] It was a bright, sunny afternoon [982] He praised her sensibility. [1521] as an executive in charge of some department, as a manager [604] In ten minutes she was gone. [1131] But she could eat but a few mouthfuls. [362]

The night was dark; some drops of rain were falling. [466] threw in a piece of stick [891] Not a stick cracked, not a twig bent. [11] See the weed floating in the water there? [946] But when the storm rises it is all changed ... and the two leaves touch. [1390] It is well the reader should understand the conditions under which it would seem these messages were sent. [1461] recognizes the need of disposing of organic wastes [1046] They cleared away the debris. [961] mingled with numerous bulky granules [288] Sometimes the normal fee is paid, sometimes a double fee of £13 6s. [238] The place was silent, the gates closed. [691] The willows were motionless. [128] twigs on the willow bush. [619] by this point they seemed to be as much a part of the riverbank as everything else. [1058]

Original

The tree cut beside the pumping station had been home to a colony of ants within a hollow created by fungal decay. Many were carried in pieces to the yard, where the cut timber was exposed to sunlight and dry air. The brood was moved repeatedly, from one crevice to another, according to the available darkness and humidity. Workers carrying pale larvae crossed the saw marks and the edge of the bark. Birds took some of them. A sudden tipping of the timber broke the remaining chambers. The ants' movement continued for several hours, then diminished. When the chips arrived at the green-waste site the colony no longer existed as a functioning arrangement. The yard staff had asked the council to leave the timber as habitat. The contractor replied that removal was necessary to reduce risk, and provided a certificate indicating that a risk had indeed been reduced.

Downstream from the school playground, the stream passed beneath a low bridge and entered a reach where the banks had been reinforced with stones. The stones were laid after a flood damaged three gardens. Their joints created sheltered spaces for some animals and prevented roots from entering others. In the deeper water a fish held position behind a fallen branch. Its gills transferred dissolved oxygen from water into blood; muscles made small corrections against the current. The branch had fallen from a tree weakened by an earlier change in drainage. It formed a useful obstruction until the council removed it during winter maintenance.

Above the bridge, a layer of fine sediment had gathered in a pool. The surface was dark with decaying leaves, algae and bacteria. Tiny animals moved along the boundary between oxygenated water and sediment where oxygen was scarce. Worms extended portions of their bodies into the moving water, taking up oxygen while remaining partly buried. Some sediment was stirred by feeding fish. Other patches were sealed by a mat of fine particles from the road. The stream's appearance during routine sampling was good. Water taken in a bottle was clear after the heavier particles settled. The bottle was transparent. The pool was not.

Quotation version

Leaf-cutting ants: their method of defoliating trees: their nests. [91] The ants arrived at this spot by passing through the interior of the tree, which was hollow [658] Gladiators were getting cut to pieces right and left. [386] thoroughly air-dry timber [1139] Something moved in the darkness on the other side of the room. [56] darkness here, dryness there, humidity here. [1048] though from the marks upon the bark of the trees [407] others carried the undeveloped white pupae and larvae. [91] the man took the birds in his hand [660] The branches broke or wouldn't bend far enough. [754] But the ants didn’t notice. [5] Fresh relays of ants were continually arriving [91] The green blinds were drawn in the bungalows of the summer colony. [922] Their world exists no longer. [1281] opened out between two timber-yards enclosed in walls. [664] “It’s a risk—of course it’s a risk,” he replied. [1517]

There was a low stone bridge just over this pool [1198] Why, with any stone picked up in the garden. [400] More important, how do you explain what became of these animals? [1536] beneath the apparent position of the fish [707] there are fish with gills or branchiæ that breathe the air dissolved in the water [334] a branch falls [487] so that till those obstructions are removed no more of its garrulity can be expected. [1481]

it stood up above the surface of a rapid connecting two pools. [708] The dark surface of the star was lost to view. [387] The oxygen thus passes in an endless round from animal to plant and from plant to animal. [279] The worms at last bury themselves and harden into pupae. [442] the oxygen dissolved in the water which constantly surrounds them. [1170] the bits of fish and half-cooked meat [995] he saw great patches in the road [704] The stream is as good as at first [44] Indeed he took a long draught, instead of a taste, from the bottle. [643] The heavy particles settle to the bottom as sludge [1178] It was transparent. [977] There was a perfect pool there. [399]

Original

An extended dry period lowered the stream. The volume of an upstream discharge remained much the same while the amount of clean water available for dilution fell. Filamentous growth increased near a warm outfall. In an enclosed backwater it formed mats thick enough to trap bubbles and dead insects. By day oxygen production at the illuminated surface was sometimes high. At night microorganisms and plant tissues consumed oxygen without replacing it through photosynthesis. A small fish entered the backwater as the level rose, then could not return when the passage narrowed. It continued moving its gills until the dissolved oxygen fell below the level it could use. At dawn its mouth still opened intermittently. A larger fish struck it once, found it difficult to swallow, and left it against the bank. Beetles reached it before noon.

The council had employed a consultancy to establish the stream's ecological potential. The report listed a target date, cost bands, opportunities for volunteer participation and the possible introduction of a floating island planted with native species. The island was bought. Its plastic buoyancy elements were secured below a planting mat with proprietary clips. The plants arrived in pots containing a compost whose composition differed from the stream's sediment; some established, others died after a change in water level. A moorhen nested among the survivors. During a storm one of the island's anchor lines failed and the floating structure moved against the reinforced bank. The movement tore a section of the nest apart. Three eggs rolled into the water. A child saw one floating and asked whether someone would rescue it. His father, who worked in risk management, told him not to enter the stream. It was the right instruction.

After the storm, volunteers hauled the island onto the path. A clipboard recorded three missing planting modules. The nest did not appear on the inventory. A volunteer took a photograph showing what appeared to be fresh greenery above clear water. The photograph was selected for the project's final report and captioned RECONNECTING PEOPLE WITH NATURE. The council's communications team preferred it to another photograph containing the broken anchor line and a plastic cup wedged among the roots.

Quotation version

Why did the stream dry up? [1354] Then the discharge appeared to diminish both in volume and in intensity. [1384] by the amount of fresh water used for dilution in the irrigation ditch. [1489] It grew warm in the room, but nothing happened. [1298] The roofs as well as the sides are formed of mats. [1120] The earth was now illuminated, by day, with a most doleful light, beyond my power to describe. [638] growing plants for photosynthesis when it needs oxygen [941] the quantity of oxygen consumed [858] “Fish,” he said disgustedly after a moment, as he kept swimming further out. [438] where some small fish were swimming. [240] the passage became narrower and narrower [226] will separate below and leave the gills exposed. [288] gills used in breathing air dissolved in water [1027] the tip of its mouth tube open [1216] Instantly, the fish of the lagoon seemed to go crazy. [837] difficult to swallow [158] he drew up against the bank [889] It was nearly noon. [562]

the brooding mists under the banks at some distance down the stream [109] Some little floating islands were in the shallows. [863] She was on the island all the time. [256] Thus the plant is secured to its support in a perfect manner. [336] It looks like an enormous shell, fucus growing all over it. [58] There had been a few potted plants [394] Moorhens swam in and out among the rushes [706] Loss of anchor [744] they tore the nest to pieces [1481] They rolled into his hand. [457] You see, there is the child. [1010] they saw something floating upon the water [1142] He had to risk it. [354] never again to enter its muddy stream. [333] Then came a very special instruction. [809]

Perhaps strangers had landed on another part of the island? [1403] I take it those are the generating plants? [424] Nest answered without looking up. [627] There was the inventory to be checked [1380] A photograph of a forest clearing [854] The water was fresh and clear [1402] between man and nature [1067] selected another. [911] You want the busted spot on the tree to show? [497]

Original

Months later the restored floating island was moved into a sheltered side channel. It looked less impressive there. The consultancy's final bill was paid. Monitoring would continue for one more season, if funding permitted. On its last scheduled visit, the survey team found no fish in the restored pool and recorded the result as insufficient data. At the next meeting, a councillor suggested changing the wording. The scientists objected. The wording stayed. The funding ended on schedule.

Charles received a postcard from Carrie. It showed a mountain in an aggressive colour and contained six cheerful sentences, followed by one he read four times: *I suppose we're all trying to arrive somewhere.* He took this for a message addressed to him, although it could have been addressed equally well to a delayed train. He propped it on the mantelpiece. A week later it fell behind a photograph. When he rediscovered it, months afterwards, he experienced a second disappointment and interpreted this too as evidence that something between them had happened.

Quotation version

surrounding the islands at the mouth of the channel [706] Somehow this big body seemed smaller, less impressive. [1032] My brother paid the bill at last. [1491] You'd have about four hours of night at this season. [1448] but I saw no fish [1006] he had calculated from insufficient data. [583] He was so changed that he said not a word [1172] “Why?” demanded the scientist. [495] It now occurred to me abruptly that “stay” was the word made use of [125] More funds and facilities were available. [723]

sent back a postcard [918] He read what was written on it, and then he read it to the others: [577] but every sentence aimed at cheerfulness [45] three or four times [945] The message was on its way, and it would be hours before he could have a reply. [1111] Owing to a delayed train [1476] His hand leaned on the mantelpiece [807] It was a week later in the kitchen [1162] If he hadn't, Heaven only knows how long it would have been before someone rediscovered it. [517]

VI. The Third Wedding: Interruption

Original

The marquee required thirty-eight poles, fourteen lengths of canvas and more rope than the supplier had included in the quotation. The two men installing it disagreed over the ground. A stake struck a buried stone, sending force back into a worker's wrist. He swore and started again. Another stake entered smoothly and was pronounced secure, though no one tested its hold once the soil became wetter. The event planner had assured Carrie that the structure was wind-resistant. She meant that the company had insurance and had never personally seen it come down.

Wind crossed the lawn and rose against the marquee canvas. Tension shifted through the ropes. Wet cloth tapped against a pole. A worker adjusted the line. The sound stopped, then returned later at a lower pitch.

The caterers arrived at nine. Celia had worked weddings for fifteen years, enough to lose the belief that their elaborate expense guaranteed anything beyond an elaborate invoice. She admired planning because it reduced the number of people who shouted at her. Her daughter was at home revising for exams, and Celia had promised to help with chemistry that evening. The promise had been made before an additional dessert station was ordered. The order had come with no additional staff.

The tablecloths mixed linen with synthetic fibres. Laid flat, they appeared identical; at their edges lay mended corners, different hems and pale marks from previous uses. One stain had been washed until it resembled a manufacturing defect, and the cloth was placed at the top table. Cut flowers drew water from concealed containers. The stems were losing the capacity to support themselves. One florist had guaranteed freshness until midnight. The guarantee covered replacement flowers, provided the complainant returned the originals within seven days.

Quotation version

a few more poles were required [1415] Canvas and poles were loaded on to the wagons. [589] Because the ground was wet. [664] hard enough to hurt [161] Then he swore. [640] I suppose you think it a poor stake! [1013] The shapeless structure which she has just built fulfils the desired conditions [440] She meant the doctor and the Company. [1541]

The wind rose with the rain [1473] against the wind, it has its cordage and its canvas [664] He caught the rope and held it tight. [857] The cloth had been wet [587] At the lines, [1227] A high pitched sound broke the stillness. [292] lowering suddenly in pitch [122]

it was early in the morning when they came. [709] In brief, it amounted to this—he had been ruined by his wife. [913] “Don't shout!” shouted the girl. [498] help her with some problems that she was preparing for the next day [861] is your daughter at home? [1194] She had promised him help once before. [1420] This promise was made on the 2nd of November. [1402] called for a second dessert [1540] None of the Chemical Staff was present. [611]

Black and white tablecloth [983] Linen consists of certain woody fibres of the stem of the flax. [279] all warped and frayed at the bottom [409] I hemmed the edges over again. [414] Its stains must be washed away. [1355] repeating if the stain still shows. [962] He laid the table-cloth down [237] with flowers from the florist’s and all the cut-glass out [853] So big, no stem could support them. [1420] guaranteed fresh [1357] remained there until near midnight [949] I wonder how long the flower lives. [158] within seven days [741]

Original

The flowers for Carrie's wedding began in separate places. Some grew in soil under glass; others in inert substrate held in plastic trays and supplied with measured water and nutrients. Greenhouse vents opened when the temperature crossed a set point. Pumps delivered solution along channels, returned excess to a tank and corrected its composition. When a pump failed, plants at the far end received less water. Their leaves lost turgor before the flowers visibly drooped. The grower marked the affected trays and adjusted delivery dates. Three hundred stems were rejected from the premium order and sold in a market where their shorter life would not be apparent at the point of sale.

Several of the crops were bred to open at predictable times and survive transport. Their value depended partly on resisting the very kinds of decay that would eventually dismantle them. A species of small fly established itself beneath a bench. The adults laid eggs in moist growing medium. Larvae fed on fungi and roots, and sometimes on one another's remains. Their population increased while the temperature held steady. A worker applied a treatment whose instructions required protective clothing, a measured dose and a period before the plants could be handled. The treatment suppressed the flies. It also altered the community of organisms living in the trays. A few larvae survived in damp corners the spray had not reached. Some emerged later. The treatment was recorded as successful because the number of damaged plants fell below the buyer's permitted threshold.

Elsewhere, on an outdoor farm, rain reached a strip of soil where fertiliser had been applied before an unusually heavy shower. Soluble nutrients entered a channel already enriched by runoff from nearby fields. A dense algal growth developed in slower water. When portions of it died, microorganisms broke down the material and used oxygen in the process. At night oxygen levels fell more steeply. Small fish crowded near the inflow, where moving water carried more air. Some survived until morning, when photosynthesis increased oxygen again. Others remained on their sides, barely moving. The farmer received a letter advising improved nutrient management. He objected to the phrase because he had followed the approved application rate. The weather had been different from the forecast. The plants he was growing would be sold under a label explaining that they brought joy.

Quotation version

We wed and christen with flowers. [1047] These organisms grow in the soil and feed upon the soil ingredients. [279] This was the soil it grew in [1371] The trays of plants, in their beds of sponge plastic and hydroponic materials [1163] the door and the windows were open to the fragrant sun-cured air [997] The pumps began to drive the water from the tanks [1402] From this tank the solution passes through a small ball-valve cistern [425] though of course the water was not enough to wet its roots. [709] the drooping leaves and flowers [378] Dates were not fixed. [1400] and gave directions as to its marking and delivery. [862] it is then sold to the gardeners [707]

the breeding of plants. [1219] an intense vitality in all aspects of their form and function [860] an ineluctable element of decay in these same areas. [860] the tiny flies [997] laid their eggs in sand or earth [634] others feed on the larvae [441] the temperature will remain constant. [739] applied after the plants were up [1413] Kill flies. [482] This may be inferred with certainty from the geographical distribution of organisms. [573] Rains and spray had damped it [971] They emerged thence a moment later. [664] before the treatment which the plant underwent. [442]

It had rained on the preceding night; the soil was soaked. [664] a heavy shower of rain [97] gradually widening and deepening the channels in which they flowed [10] Water is often a limiting factor in plant growth. [1364] It failed living; it might be of use dead. [590] deprived of its oxygen in the process [986] Night was falling more surely. [622] Observe what shoals of fish are crowded together at the margin. [906] The last of his oxygen was gone. [423] The police officers did not move. [628] You have received a regular letter of advice? [414] the higher may be the rate of application [1046] Weather forecast [145] There was joy in it. [176] There were scores of rare plants, all labelled [345]

Original

At the distribution centre flowers were cooled, counted, wrapped and allocated to events. A large rose with a bruised outer petal was stripped of the damaged tissue and passed inspection. A white stem snapped while being handled and entered a bin containing leaves, plastic collars and foam blocks saturated with preservative solution. The bins were weighed at night. The weight was entered into a waste-management platform, where it appeared alongside a percentage of materials sent for recovery. The contractor recovered some of the plastic. The flowers decomposed in a heap whose interior warmed under microbial activity, then became oxygen-poor where compacted layers restricted air. The material didn't disappear as the dashboard's downward arrow might have suggested. It changed its chemistry and location, releasing heat and compounds whose movements the weighing station did not record.

A florist at the wedding venue placed stems into holders which kept them upright without requiring the flowers to have enough living tissue left to maintain the shape. She had slept four hours. The first arrangement had been rejected because it looked too natural, the second because it looked stiff, and the third accepted after the planner asked her to make it look expensive but unconsidered. The florist used the phrase *just picked* for blooms that had crossed several countries by road and air. The phrase appeared on the delivery note. It was a conventional description of appearance, not a claim that the flowers had never been elsewhere.

A moth emerged from a split chrysalis in a hedge behind the venue. Its wings expanded as fluid moved through their veins and the cuticle dried. One wing failed to unfold fully. It could still move but couldn't fly normally. That afternoon the gardener cut back the hedge for the photographs. The moth fell into a tray of discarded stems and was taken away with the packaging. It was alive when the tray entered the refuse compactor. The compactor was labelled QUIET OPERATION. The label was accurate compared with the previous model.

Quotation version

Then he waited in the cool shaded sitting-room, among the flowers. [1008] Her roses were faded now, and from some of them the petals had fallen. [250] The crumpled rose had its petals rehabilitated [97] their white stems shining like silver through the delicate green of the leaves. [1332] tumbled into the bin, covered with leaves [487] We weighed anchor at night [77] The Mystery of a Minus Weight [404] Pieces of plastic with values printed on them are distributed. [1421] It is the interior of a flower that is not yet unfolded [664] a heap of flowers [1538] poor in oxygen [1170] The steep road led downwards, and everything disappeared. [1541] The increase in weight was apparent, but not particularly unpleasant. [1502]

The flowers belonged by right to the florists. [664] four hours' sleep [729] But you asked him to make arrangements. [854] were arranged with the greatest possible stiffness. [955] In other words that it is nearly always in bloom. [1276] She had picked up the phrase from hearing it used at table. [1483] An ancient phrase that--damned well. [879] But they are not flowers, Daddy. [813] very conventional and artificial looking flowers. [536]

in all Butterflies and Moths emerging from the chrysalis [444] Every Moth, on emerging from her chrysalis [444] As she spoke her form dilated, the vast wings expanded. [906] Its wings unfolded and grew stiff [426] He was so exhausted he couldn't move. [173] When he came back to the window looking into the yard: [805] A moth fell [126] was taken away. [1166] The servant entered with a tray. [1391] Without another word he made the operation. [1332] Is it accurate? [319]

Original

Inside the marquee Carrie leaned towards a rose to smell it. It had almost no scent; the variety had been selected for colour, shape and durability. She bent closer, then gave up and smiled at the florist because she didn't want her to feel the problem was hers. A perfume applied to the tablecloth made the air smell vaguely of flowers. The tablecloth and rose would be separated after the reception. The tablecloth would be washed. Some of its fibres would enter water. The stem would enter a bin whose classification depended on the vendor's contract. Carrie had other things to attend to, and the rose had no need of her disappointment.

In one greenhouse a grower had stopped using a broad-spectrum insecticide after the retailer changed its purchasing policy. She began introducing predatory mites and tiny parasitic wasps into the crop. Both methods could suppress pests under suitable conditions. They did not make the greenhouse a peaceful place. A predatory mite pierced a smaller animal and consumed its contents; another prey animal escaped through a gap between leaves. The mites reproduced when food was sufficient and declined after the prey population fell. Some starved while sitting on a flower that met every quality requirement of the florist who later purchased it.

A colony of aphids had established itself on the softer shoots. Many were female and reproduced without mating under those conditions. The next generation was already developing before the present one was fully grown. Their mouthparts entered plant tissue and drew fluid from the vascular system; excess sugars emerged as honeydew. On it grew sooty mould which reduced the amount of light reaching the leaf. Ants discovered the honeydew and began visiting the shoots. They drove off some predators and ignored others. An aphid parasitised by a wasp remained attached to the plant while the developing parasitoid consumed its internal tissues. Its body gradually changed shape and hardened into a swollen case. The next wasp emerged through an opening. A second kind of parasitoid had developed inside several of the first. Those would emerge instead. The greenhouse supplied no safe level of being someone else's future.

Quotation version

I, too, will smell the rose. [1391] Perhaps the wood when taken out of the sunlight lost its scent. [1020] of great varieties of form and colour [747] She looked down, but still smiled. [633] The air was fresh and sweet with perfume from the orange flowers. [239] The reception was enthusiastic. [38] covered with a clean white tablecloth [1386] nothing would induce it to enter the water [333] we gather the remnants up to burn, or bury, or toss into the river. [1045] other things to do. [201]

Its policy has been to restrict production and maintain high prices. [102] “Maybe last year's crop have grown up,” she began. [1092] I have touched above on the insect pests. [1185] The place was peaceful enough on that pleasant May afternoon. [1382] are preyed upon by other animals [333] through a gap in the leaves. [1063] Nevertheless, instead of devouring food, he becomes the prey of insects. [614] when it hath blasted and starved all the sweet garden flowers [426]

an ant runs up and down a rose stem tending its aphides. [1468] are the ones selected by the females for mating. [1260] The present generation has a task of its own to perform. [1203] variations in sugar content of the tissues of the plants [1364] simple vascular tissue [337] Meanwhile it had grown quite dark. [1405] At last, a nest of Black Ants is discovered. [441] The smaller satellites had been largely ignored. [339] the wasp is said to fly about with the fungus partially developed. [288] Gradually it changed size and shape. [610] emerged into the open air. [863] Satirists frequently exposed this form of parasitism. [1373] We might emerge—and live! [1461] There are no common rights over the whole year land. [1278]

Original

A technician called Rina counted aphids on selected leaves and entered the totals into a tablet. Her weekly target was a reduction below the threshold specified by the retailer. This could be achieved with fewer aphids, or with the aphids spread so unevenly that the selected leaves were no longer representative. Rina knew the distinction. She adjusted the sampling plan when plants had been moved, making a note in the comments field. Her supervisor asked why her numbers were difficult to compare with last week. She explained that last week's plants were no longer there. He said consistency was important. She asked whether he wanted her to count the old plants. He said he did not appreciate sarcasm.

A treatment was applied at the far end of the structure after a pest population crossed its agreed limit. The grower excluded staff for the prescribed period. Several insects in protected buds survived. Others were killed, including some of the beneficial predators introduced at considerable expense. That evening a worker opened a vent and a moth entered through the gap. It circled an overhead lamp, struck a hot fitting and fell on the floor. Its reproductive organs had matured before the flight; it had not yet laid eggs. A spider reached it before the floor was swept. The spider fed, retreated and later deposited its own eggs beneath the frame. The cleaning contractor removed the web as part of a programme intended to give visitors confidence in the site's hygiene. Visitors were not normally permitted in the greenhouse.

Outside, beneath the loading bay, pallets had crushed a line of weeds against a wall. Their seeds had arrived in mud adhering to a vehicle's tyres, in potting medium and in soil moved during building work. A plant grew through a hairline crack at the corner of the concrete. Its roots widened the crack, enabling a little more water to enter. At the next maintenance visit the plant was sprayed with herbicide. It yellowed and collapsed, leaving the crack open. Water entered in winter and expanded when frozen. The loading surface broke along the weak line; a driver reported it. Repair was approved six months later, after somebody tripped and the site manager discovered the possibility of litigation. The weed had already produced seed before being sprayed. Several germinated beyond the loading bay, where the maintenance contract ended.

Quotation version

Looking up I count a thousand leaves [659] carefully selected leaves were tried [337] Now it was at the very threshold and within it [976] below the threshold [1464] It is clear that very sensitive leaves had been accidentally selected. [337] It knew [474] “I am thinking of the irony of our situation,” said the plant. [1153] make a note of it [400] Why she's got ever so much thinner in the last week. [1008] many plants were no longer in flower. [446] His consistency was, indeed, too cruel. [594] Water she wanted, and fruit. [1315] he couldn't conceal the edge of sarcasm in his voice. [1030]

The treatment had, so far forth, been followed by complete success. [808] should they become a pest. [1170] He had lost his staff. [863] These insects adhere to one another sometimes for several leagues. [1402] But they wished to harm our people, so we killed them all. [473] Entering through this gap, winged insects from another realm of being. [375] Through the open window entered the fresh evening air [350] The pale light of the lamp falls upon the table. [719] struck his head against a hanging lamp, and fell. [701] from the eggs which are laid by the fowl [378] This is the floor on which the Spider means to operate. [440] Later, as the Spider goes on feeding [440] When the Spider has laid her eggs [447] far removed from the tell-tale web. [440] You denied yourself to visitors. [66]

were crushed like reeds beneath the pads of a mastodon. [977] weeds trodden down here and there [664] They may be dirty as mud, but I love ’em! [340] the seeds adhering [950] a few bushes had taken root up on the roadway [815] the crack has widened [591] Best time to spray plants too in the shade after the sun. [728] suddenly opened a crack and closed again instantly [664] Water will freeze when it is cold enough. [381] Trucks broke down. [833] A month later, or maybe two months, and they could not have done it. [1024] Six months later [958] Somebody had tripped [946] Weeds grew everywhere. [374] had been cleared of trees and bushes that they might not harbour vermin [706]

Original

The plants for Carrie's wedding were wrapped individually and loaded into a refrigerated vehicle. Inside one sleeve a minute insect survived the journey. Its eggs were stuck to a leaf that nobody would look at directly. At the florist's workshop the leaf was stripped away and entered a bin of stems. A larva emerged and fed briefly among the cuttings. When the bin was emptied, the larva entered a larger mass whose temperature rose as microorganisms consumed the decaying tissue. Heat, moisture and a shortage of usable food ended its development. The pest had been transported successfully for hundreds of miles and had arrived somewhere incapable of supporting it. The grower's certificate stated that the consignment was free from visible pests. The statement was accurate at the moment of inspection. Carrie's florist clipped the last damaged petal from an immaculate rose and was charged for the whole stem.

Rina later left the greenhouse to work for a council biodiversity team. On her first week she attended a workshop about habitat connectivity. A consultant explained that nature was resilient and would rebound when given the chance. Rina asked what happened to species introduced into a site to control others once the food supply collapsed. The consultant agreed that long-term planning was essential and moved on to the next slide. It showed a butterfly above a flower, both photographed in a location which had since been paved over. The paving had been necessary for access to the conservation centre.

Hamish rehearsed a speech in an upstairs room. He disliked public statements of affection. His family had taught him that important things should go without saying, a principle that had allowed several important things to go permanently unsaid. Carrie had once insisted that he tell her what he missed when she was away. 'Lunch,' he had answered. She asked what he meant. He had meant the stories he could tell her afterwards, and the discovery had genuinely surprised him. He practised a sentence about that now. It sounded as if he were discussing an intestinal complaint. He kept it.

Quotation version

fitted with a powerful refrigerating-plant [446] carefully wrapped in tissue paper. [1227] Did they have some kind of an insect under his jar? [1495] The eggs are worth looking at. [439] it lays its eggs upon a leaf [891] who showed me how to strip the stems from the leaves [713] As the larva passes from the stage of Fig. [1170] They ate decayed food and they never went to mass. [1384] when we had made an end of our food [641] had been transported [204] incapable of supporting a host of invaders [208] Assume, at starting, a territory perfectly free from that pest. [802] each of which he held up a moment for inspection. [110] She opened the book and, plucking a petal from the rose, dropped it between the leaves. [239]

She left [382] a training and networking event for new hires [1057] But nature seems to know what is needed--and provides it. [361] the natural resilience of a healthy nature. [1333] Have the subsequently introduced species consumed the food of the great antecedent races? [333] the food supply, predators, competitors [1257] Perhaps at this very moment plans were maturing. [220] The butterflies a while since were gone to rest. [419] like butterflies above the flower-faces beneath. [37] on the paving. [593]

We went upstairs to the small drawing-room. [795] He disliked strangers who tried to strike up acquaintances in public places. [1494] This was the first and perhaps most important incident in his history. [575] to tell her [44] “You were at lunch, I think,” he said. [561] Somehow he knew what she meant. [1244] How could anyone have known about his discovery? [1247] The story had meant more to her than to the others. [1166] rather surprised at his discovery [912] No, 'twas only about the sentence. [587] “And what do you think his complaint is?” [807] And he kept it. [400]

Original

During the interval before the speeches, Celia discovered that a freezer had been switched off to make room for the band equipment. Its temperature had risen slowly, remaining cold enough for much of the food inside to look unchanged. A thermometer showed the current temperature, not the duration of the earlier rise. Celia found the kitchen supervisor and asked when the plug had been removed. He said he didn't know. She asked who had switched the band on. He said he thought it had always been on. Celia called the person responsible for food safety, who advised disposing of several trays. The supervisor argued that the food had cost too much. Celia told him the guests would cost more if they became ill. He agreed in principle, then photographed the discarded food for an insurance claim.

A tray of chilled poultry had warmed enough for microbial populations on its surfaces to multiply more rapidly, though not all organisms did so in the same conditions. Some bacteria were inhibited by the salt and acidity of the marinade; others were not. The final temperature reading would not reveal what had happened during the intervening hours. Most of the food in the tray was still chemically and structurally what had been purchased, but the risk had changed. Celia sent it to the waste area. The manager later asked whether she had considered offering it to staff rather than throwing it away. He said this after the trays had been crushed and mixed with broken crockery. His concern for waste was genuine and conveniently belated.

In the waste enclosure a rat worked through a gap behind the bin. Its whiskers moved across the surface of a torn sack. It took a fragment of bread and retreated. Small flies had laid eggs in the damp material. Their larvae would reach different stages according to temperature and access to food. When the waste contractor arrived, the bin was tipped and compressed. Several larvae survived the first pressure and were killed later in a hotter, drier place. The rat escaped beneath a fence, carrying the bread. It had a scar across its ear from a fight the previous spring, and a population of parasites on its skin. Their activity affected its movement. It returned on a night when the waste enclosure was empty and spent two hours searching without finding anything edible. It did not become a representative of resourcefulness. It lost weight.

Quotation version

had been switched off [107] The temperature became as cold as ice. [863] Any marked rise in temperature might [896] The matter of duration of a low temperature is perhaps quite as important as the degree which is actually reached by the thermometer. [1489] In the kitchen I found the cook on the point of departure. [874] He didn't know. [450] The band had stopped. [975] He always had. [1436] She put the tray aside, and brushed some crumbs from her skirt. [345] Cost of Food. [1046] she told him [592] The photograph I was speaking of at the dinner last night. [1508]

For a time the multiplying bacteria have an unimpeded course and grow rapidly [279] the organism as a whole is adapted to the conditions of its life [1369] The moisture and the heat cause a growth of bacteria which proceeds with more or less rapidity according to the temperature and other conditions. [279] Is there any acidity? [244] The hours passed and nothing happened. [151] a tray of untouched food standing in the aperture [412] It was taking a big risk [1484] she sent it away [1476] garbage and waste sent down [409] Maybe it was thrown away. [373] I believe there'll be some crockery broken. [1475] The crash of broken crockery [314] Yet he had no sense of waste, no sense of the present hope that waste implied. [461]

The rat will have found some hole, no doubt. [468] Its long ragged whiskers twitched, and its scabrous, naked tail was moving slowly from side to side. [768] Yes, sir, bread. [1150] This is the time when the eggs are being laid. [445] who wish to keep the food fresh for their larvae [440] was tipped [1333] was compressed [105] The Larvae had distinct attributes, and were thought to cause epilepsy or madness. [275] An open window showed how he escaped. [1231] Has a razor scar above the left ear. [1070] a white scar that he had got in a fight [1459] colonies of parasites [1356] affecting only the powers of voluntary movement. [1458] I have spent hours in trying to analyze it, to find what it smelled like. [543] could not find anything to eat [38] The oil resources were not that important. [306] he lost several pounds in weight [1386]

Original

The catering manager arranged pest control. The contractor inspected droppings, gnaw marks and gaps in the building, then placed several bait stations inside locked boxes. A rat died behind an appliance. A staff member smelled it and thought the drains had backed up. The drain company attended first. Its invoice was paid before the rat was found. The appliance was moved, the body removed and a gap sealed. When a family booking a christening asked whether the kitchen was hygienic, the manager pointed to the contractor's signed report.

At the bar, a man asked Charles whether marriage was only an expensive method of discovering someone else's habits. Charles gave the answer expected of him and everybody laughed. The man said he'd been married three times, two of which had ended. Charles asked whether that made the third a success. The man said it was ongoing, which was the most he could promise. He turned out to be Carrie's uncle. Charles wasn't sure whether to count this as information.

Carrie had a headache and was worried about her father, who drank more than he admitted and less than she feared. She was happy too, but exhausted by the repeated public examination of that happiness. Each supplier required her to confirm something. Each friend asked whether she was absolutely certain. The certainty had come to resemble a document she was expected to produce on demand. She had signed a contract with the marquee company. Nobody had asked whether she felt absolutely certain about the wind.

Carrie's dress had been altered twice. When she sat, it pulled across one hip and made it difficult to breathe deeply. A friend loosened the concealed fastening. For the rest of the day, a small gap remained beneath the buttons.

Charles arrived on time and delayed everyone by joking about it to the man directing traffic. Scarlett had begun seeing someone in Brighton and resented the way Charles approved of an arrangement he knew little about. He apologised. She called this a useful rehearsal.

Quotation version

Now, if you have a proposal for a pest control group-- [784] Several safe ways of approach to the building were discovered, and the combustibles placed and fired. [249] The building had been inspected [1478] There was a box for bait [837] A rat ran right over my face! [347] There was not a drain of water left, but everything smelled green, succulent. [791] He was first! [578] the bill had been paid [1396] It had not moved, nor had its mouth-like opening closed. [1073] “Yes, he signed the visitors' book,” said the girl in reply to his question. [130]

marriage is a graft; it takes well or ill [664] Everybody read the paragraph, and everybody laughed at it. [89] That's the man his wife could have married and didn't. [1167] have been married three times [1177] considered it a success. [50] And the third?" she asked. [326] Two hours was the least to be expected from a man of his promise. [135] Uncle [702] I was not sure. [1465]

Her father suffered from atrocious headaches, and this was the one thing that relieved him. [561] drank more or less [1538] She came to be a completely happy one. [1321] she found everybody requiring something they had not [42] “You're sure?” she asked. [452] I only wanted to ask her whether she is certain [482] The result of her renewed entreaties perhaps the reader has anticipated. [803] She produced a document in the form of a note. [807] And to-night the marriage-contract is to be signed! [1187] What she felt, what she imagined, what she believed, I have never asked her. [546]

her dress [409] had been altered [285] Sometimes she sat on the floor because she was so tired of the foamease chair. [184] He loosened one of his automatics with a suggestive movement. [976] One day, the buttons were removed from the foils. [664] gaps between the buttons [854]

The man was not joking. [78] I am not more alarmed [44] and she knew and resented it [561] I apologised. [1462] He and I just caught your rehearsal. [1189]

Original

Gareth arrived carrying two drinks he didn't intend to finish. He had learned that appearing to have somewhere to go increased the number of conversations available. He wore velvet over a shirt Matthew had ironed. Matthew had also brought medication Gareth had forgotten. It was for an ordinary condition and offered no explanation of what followed.

They quarrelled about a holiday: Matthew wanted quiet; Gareth wanted a city where no one would let them sleep. Gareth made a joke that injured Matthew.

'I wasn't trying to take charge,' Matthew said.

'You do it beautifully without trying.'

'Fine. We'll go wherever you want.'

'Oh, don't be noble. It's very exhausting for the rest of us.'

Matthew walked away. Gareth watched him leave, then turned to someone else and began a different conversation at once. It was one of the habits that made him charming at parties and difficult at home.

Fiona found Charles at the bar and told him he looked as he always did when he wanted something already ruled out. He was silent. She apologised for the sharpness, not the accuracy.

'I'm sorry,' she said.

'You needn't be. It's accurate.'

They watched Carrie crossing the room with Hamish, kissing one guest, avoiding a cable, greeting another, retrieving a glass from a waiter. She looked harassed and beautiful. Fiona asked Charles whether he could bear to hear what she'd been doing. He admitted he hadn't asked.

'You know,' Fiona said, 'we might all be rather tired of discussing your feelings.'

Charles looked at her. She smiled, though not to soften what she'd said.

'You could ask me what I've been doing.'

'What have you been doing?'

Quotation version

You didn't finish your drink! [520] Now that he could hear them so clearly, he would go and find the other people. [180] dressed now in somewhat worn brown silk and velvet. [1323] They have not forgotten what his last visit brought upon them. [1327] He offered no further explanation, and I followed him in silence. [1477]

The sleep-wrapped city was dark and silent. [1264] They quarrelled about something [245] but a man wants to sleep nights, and they wouldn't let him sleep nights. [1209] You think He made it for a joke? [1008]

I did not mean to! [594]

How beautifully you do it! [12]

Really, really fine. [393] “We’ll go wherever you like,” he said. [254]

not be so noble [1266] You are exhausted already; I am exhausted too. [1332]

He turned his back and walked away. [361] He turned away, knowing she was watching him. [105] and hastily turned the conversation to something else. [601] He acquired a habit of going to their parties. [856] And he’s difficult at home, too. [1517]

He was always doing something, or looking for something to do. [988] Suddenly he became silent. [65] So she speaks up sort of sharp. [488]

“I'm sorry,” she said. [1008]

“You needn't be,” said she. [1008] It was very accurate indeed. [378]

when Carrie came up with another of the guests. [409] He watched her cross the room [1524] That woman is beautiful [460] Do you think you could bear to hear it? [260] “No,” she admitted. [1294]

I don't know if I can get my feelings across to you. [553]

he turned his head to look directly at her. [325] She smiled gently. [1217]

“I've got to ask you some questions,” he said. [1012]

What have you been doing? [592]

Original

'Trying to decide whether to leave my job. Learning Italian. Going out with a man who thinks I ought to stop drinking coffee.'

'Good lord. Which one is he?'

'None of them. I stopped going out with him.'

Charles laughed. Fiona liked the sound and found that this no longer made her happy.

The defective stake on the marquee's west side loosened. Another rope took the strain. Workers added a fixing. The guests discussed the cost with the astonishment reserved for expenses they hadn't personally incurred.

Celia's daughter sent a message asking whether she should eat the curry in the fridge. Celia typed YES, then wondered how long it had been there. She deleted YES and wrote WHEN WAS IT MADE? She received no reply. For a moment the question of whether her daughter should eat yesterday's dinner seemed a more manageable problem than the tension building in the marquee, though at that point nothing terrible had happened there. The thermometer over the kitchen door showed a number within range. Celia washed her hands, returned to the room and asked the band to reduce the volume.

Gareth found Matthew at the edge of the dance floor. They spoke quietly. His apology arrived without a joke, which made Matthew suspicious before it made him glad. Gareth held out his hand. They danced, at first with the stiffness of people who have been observed arguing. Their movements gradually recovered the small learned adjustments that years together had produced: weight transferred before a turn, pressure from a hand at the back, a familiar change of pace as one tired. The band played a tune Gareth disliked. He had been planning to complain about it and forgot to.

Halfway through the next song Gareth said he felt odd. Matthew asked whether he wanted to sit down. Gareth said yes, then no, then stopped answering. He was still holding Matthew's hand when his knees gave way.

Quotation version

What's my job [1062] trying to decide what to do [221] I am learning Italian [918] “I don't think I want my coffee,” he said. [785]

“Good Lord!” someone blurted. [782] His words are: [1124]

No, none of them were there. [700] So I stopped where I was. [703]

He laughed [486] I liked the sound [1361]

the sides and stakes being arranged as before. [1386] by the straining of the rope which hung from above [806] Each day they added new workers [1274] Under the circumstances, however, expense wasn't important. [1215] to the astonishment of the guests [1136]

They all ate curry. [727] That’s the message she sent. [1473] After a pause she asked: [726] That was the question she asked and asked, and listened in vain for the answer. [922] received no reply. [683] The dinner was rather a silent affair. [682] still that too had happened before and nothing very terrible had come of it. [1425] thermometer within doors [1481] She was quiet once more. [378] washed her face and hands [74]

They rose and started for the dance floor. [453] He spoke very quietly, but very decidedly. [130] Then he had to apologise. [466] He was suspicious of them. [872] held out his hand [1173] They danced. [1519] For these two made a little life together, they had a joint activity. [792] A pressure of the hand [391] It even amounted to a valid change of pace. [829] He particularly disliked one “new” song to a jaunty dance-tune. [400] She quite forgot all about it, thinking of the man. [947]

Only unwell. [593] “Shall we sit there?” she said. [1478] began to answer, then stopped. [161] His knees gave way and he dropped on a bench. [1433]

Original

He fell against a chair and a table. The chair struck the floor. A glass rolled across a cloth and broke against a plate; liquid entered the weave and moved onto the surface beneath. A guest shouted for a doctor. People ran towards Gareth and obstructed one another. Celia cleared a passage through the tables. A man who had spent the afternoon referring to his experience in medicine explained that he meant his father had been a doctor. Someone called an ambulance and couldn't remember the postcode. Carrie's father supplied it correctly, surprising everybody, including himself. He later repeated this detail so often that his wife had to ask him to stop.

Matthew knelt beside Gareth. He called his name in a voice he didn't recognise. A guest began chest compressions while Celia guided the paramedics in from the gate.

A wet rectangle formed beneath the overturned glass. The repaired rope held. A fox crossed the far lawn and slipped through a hedge. No one from the wedding saw it.

The paramedics worked for a long time. When they stopped, the crowd had become so quiet that the fabric tapping against the pole could be heard again. Matthew stayed beside the place where Gareth lay. Carrie moved towards him, then stopped; she didn't know whether touch would help. He reached for her hand, and she sat on the floor beside him in her wedding dress.

Gareth had had blood tests six months before the wedding after recurring fatigue. The results had been unremarkable. He had stopped drinking for three weeks, chiefly because Matthew had been pleased and Gareth wanted to annoy him with the evidence of improvement. The ordinary biological processes sustaining his body were not a contract for future performance. Signals passed through nerves and tissue. Blood delivered oxygen. Electrical activity coordinated the heart until, abruptly, it no longer did so in the way required. The heart was muscle, conduction tissue, vessels, circulating ions and a history of events unavailable to the people watching him dance. As the electrical pattern ceased to coordinate useful contraction, blood no longer circulated adequately. The paramedic's hands kept moving after she understood how little they could change.

Quotation version

who fell backward from his chair and slipped to the floor. [693] knocking the chair clattering to the floor. [654] My glass, fallen from his hands, had rolled at his feet. [1402] shouted to me to go for the English doctor. [283] They ran towards each other [14] But other people got between them in the street, obstructing him [1522] The table was cleared. [726] clear herself a passage through the débris. [446] my own father was a doctor. [255] An emergency call. [33] He himself just couldn't remember it. [732] surprised. [409] her father supplied the rest. [376] He turned to his wife again, repeating, with some emphasis: [281] but his wife stopped him: [1126]

I knelt down beside him and raised his head. [1463] a strange voice called him by his name [382] pressing on the chest systematically [962]

There was a bottle and an overturned glass on his desk. [1099] He held the rope. [790] slipping through a hole in the hedge [466] The answer was all there, printed out plain to see only nobody saw it. [826]

They worked thus in silence for a long time. [791] A silence had settled down over the crowd. [1154] who remained motionless in his place [414] He reached to touch her shoulder. [968] She held her hand out and motioned him down beside her. [559] He reached for her hand. [354] and sat on the floor beside him. [1316]

That discovery was followed by months of tests and examinations. [360] There were blood tests to take. [738] But in us there was nothing requiring treatment. [1377] For a day or two he stopped drinking. [855] There was no scope for any further performance. [1466] His body submitted to all the ordinary processes of age [696] whence radiate the nerves scattered over the several organs of movement. [446] The oxygen of the atmosphere received into the blood in the lungs [858] Abruptly the signals were blanked out completely. [222] the muscle of his own heart [727] the pivotal question of the heart and blood vessels. [1056] the last movement of the heart ceased [414] The blood gradually ceased to circulate properly [1121] her hand almost automatically continued its movements [1517]

Original

For a time the music and conversation occupied the same room as those processes. Nobody listened for them. No one could have done so in a way that altered what happened. Gareth was not living unknowingly through a final wedding in order to provide it with an ending. He was irritated about the hotel booked for their holiday, happy with the sensation of Matthew's hand at his back, and distracted by a song he hoped to complain about. Later, when people looked back over the evening, they found apparent signs. A glass he hadn't finished became evidence. A joke about getting old became uncanny. A photograph of him sitting down was offered as proof he had been unwell. None of these things had been adequate evidence when they occurred. Their new meanings came afterwards, produced by people trying to occupy a time in which they might still have acted.

Hamish went outside to speak to the staff. His wedding speech was folded in his pocket. He asked Celia what should happen to the food and hated himself for having asked it. Celia said some could be collected by a charity if it remained properly chilled. She had already checked. He agreed, then asked whether he should tell the guests. She advised him against making an announcement about the buffet. He stood in the rain, relieved to have been prevented from doing something useful and monstrous.

Celia called the charity. Some food was collected. The dishes that had been warm too long went into commercial waste. The venue charged a disposal fee for the meals the guests had not eaten. Later, the management company included both figures in its sustainability report and expressed satisfaction that a difficult event had yielded an unexpectedly good food-donation result. An external auditor queried whether the donation could be counted under community benefit when the wedding had not been completed. The answer was yes.

Before Celia left the venue, her daughter sent a message asking about chemistry. Celia typed, *I'm so sorry, there's been a death.* She erased it because she did not want to make a death sound like a scheduling excuse. She wrote, *I'll explain when I get home.* At two in the morning she found her daughter asleep on the revision notes, with a circle drawn round a question about rates of reaction.

Quotation version

They sit down, talk together--it sounds like music itself. [642] They occupied the same room together, these two. [1372] And nobody seemed to care. [943] Nothing could be done. [406] it's happened; it can't be altered now; something's got to be done. [1444] its purpose is neither resolution nor stasis but continuing process. [817] He had been happy [788] the words impressed themselves on my mind and I remembered them afterwards in solitude. [1255] He rushed up to the glass. [845] Where did you get such a perfectly uncanny understanding? [1159] He was sitting near by. [984] He was evidently unwell [400] none of these disturbing things [451] Thought of the old days came back kaleidoscopically. [332]

He presently went on to speak. [379] folded up his wedding suit with tears in his eyes [414] Why, he asked himself, did everything have to happen to him? [1254] He hated to ask what had happened. [1529] It should not be kept on sufficiently long to produce a chill. [1438] He said, “Check.” [538] The Guest nodded and smiled again. [313] He advised her against it [44] He stood at the doorway watching the rain. [692]

a telephone call [731] no food collected for it [443] while the dishes disappeared as fast as many hands could carry them. [1157] To this meal guests were frequently invited from the town [1492] food was more difficult to obtain [1256] expressed satisfaction with the results. [1014] Oh, benefit, benefit—I would have done it whether or no. [674] The answer was in the affirmative. [330]

the lady had asked whether any message had been left for her [43] some one was dead. [1520] I’m so sorry [1338] A sentence of death had been passed in silence. [293] but he quickly erased it. [437] I'll have to explain to her… [1273] I found her asleep. [1332] she found her daughter apparently asleep [1088] just changes the rate of a reaction. [1349]

Original

The body was carried away under conditions intended to prevent damage, contamination and unwanted attention. Before that could happen, a person had to tell the staff where to bring the vehicle and whether the narrow entrance was passable. The answer was disputed by two men who had been working at the venue all day. A wheel on the stretcher struck the edge of a paving stone. The staff corrected its course without interrupting their conversation. Matthew watched from inside the doorway. He wanted to keep them there because the last movement of Gareth through a familiar place should not happen in the same manner as a delivery. He also wanted them to leave, because their care and competence made it impossible to pretend that anything could be reversed.

Matthew returned to the flat he shared with Gareth. A jacket hung over a chair. The newspaper was folded beneath the television. A mug stood on the draining board; Gareth had left it there after breakfast. Matthew thought he could never wash it, then hated himself for making a monument out of dirty crockery. He put it in the sink. A message arrived from the wedding photographer asking the couple to confirm whether they wanted the evening photographs included in their package. He read it twice, unable to decide which couple the photographer meant. He did not reply. He stood beside the sink until the light above it went out on a faulty timer.

The chair retained its depression; tea dried at the bottom of the mug; the heating system continued to warm an empty side of the room. These were not substitutes for Gareth and made no attempt to be. Matthew knew where to reach for almost everything in the flat in darkness, and for most of the night his hand kept beginning movements that required someone else to be there. In the morning he found that the bathroom mirror had steamed up when he showered and cleared again. He was furious that he could not stop it, and then furious with himself for wanting to.

Quotation version

The rest of his body was lost to him. [987] But she remained and saw the body being carried away. [846] the way being too narrow to admit of the entrance of vehicles. [664] make these thoroughfares passable for themselves [1278] “They certainly did,” answered the stage-driver. [299] the men had done a day's work [1541] Striking the edge of the paving stones at high speed [411] It was interrupted. [1409] He stepped into a doorway, then peered out cautiously. [911] He knew where he was and what had happened, but he did not want to move. [790] to keep in the same place. [230] Of course, the process isn’t reversible [214]

returning to the flat. [409] The jacket [916] hung over the back of a chair. [1540] a folded newspaper [1014] a mug [844] on the drain board. [1014] keep intact a state of happiness which was gone for ever [213] It became a shrine of sorts [1115] and stood it in the sink [790] You were surprised this evening that we have so many of your photographs. [245] He read it once, twice,--and I fancy yet again. [951] Still he did not reply [110] He was standing where I had seen him before the light went out [640] stood beside the sink [1277]

The tables and chairs and cabinets stood in the same relation to each other as before [1442] a depression in the seat [579] Yet the place was warm, central-heated. [795] It will all be the same, only I will be stiller. [57] But it was not the same thing [1444] deep though invisible tracks they must leave, everywhere, behind them! [686] his arms, though stretched out, remained empty. [1518] Only this hand seemed to have a vital and immediate memory [737] went to the bathroom and took a hot shower. [486] The mirror had been clouded over with steam [737] Then the mist cleared. [37] He felt his face flushing and he was furious with himself. [1277] he was furious and ashamed. [1183]

Original

In the cooling body, circulation had stopped renewing the distribution of oxygen and removing the products of metabolism. Cells did not all cease functioning at the same instant. Some exhausted their remaining supplies and changed chemically; some membranes lost their capacity to maintain differences between inside and outside. The balance between an organism's tissues and the microorganisms occupying its surfaces and cavities altered. Bacteria that had lived in the gut under conditions maintained by a living body encountered a different set of resources and restrictions. Some multiplied where the local conditions permitted it; others died. Different species competed, consumed by-products or modified their surroundings. In tissues, enzymes that had participated in ordinary maintenance continued to act for a time without the larger coordination that had previously made their action useful to Gareth.

Some organisms persisted where the available resources suited them; others disappeared as their conditions changed. Resident microorganisms, opportunists and the body's own tissues did not respond in the same way. The mortuary recorded the temperature at regular intervals. There was no instrument that provided a total account of everything changing inside the room.

The mortuary worker who received Gareth had had a daughter two months earlier. He worked alternating shifts and was usually awake when she was asleep. He recorded the time, checked the identification and stored the body under controlled temperatures. Refrigeration slowed many processes; it did not halt every chemical change or bring the body back under its former regulation. Condensation formed on the outside of a metal surface when warm air met it. A small drop descended until the machine's fan altered the air enough to make it fall sideways. The worker made an entry on a form and checked his telephone for a photograph from home. His daughter was asleep with one fist beside her face. He enlarged the image and looked at it for several seconds before returning the device to his pocket.

Quotation version

The circulation stops. [728] The cooling of the body [858] Sometimes it ceases for an instant [653] He wondered how they could have remained undisturbed so long. [897] for our supply was now exhausted [1371] the inside of these primary cell-membranes [1196] Surface wounds allowed to decay will deepen in course of time and produce cavities. [851] with the bacteria which lived in his body as they lived in all other bodies. [934] The living body has some very efficacious resistant forces which prevent most bacteria from growing within its tissues [279] They had been allowed to die for a specific purpose. [516] to be the product of two different species. [441] Enzymes are specific in their action. [1364]

The principle of life, which makes organism, always remained, while the outward form changed. [913] her body did not respond to the treatment as well as on the other occasions. [1332] while various other instruments kept the temperature [1230] Nor was the ticking of the clock the only sound in the room. [118]

He has a daughter---- [1126] And when at last he slept again, she did not move; yet she was not asleep. [1119] He made observations, checked for time and position. [1450] The identification tab was similarly recorded. [1421] It has been commonly regarded as simply a slow chemical change [279] The air outside was warm, and even hot. [402] condensing suddenly by contact [1403] dropping fast [936] the current of air caught it. [100] I took him through the homes of a few of our factory workers. [873] She checked it, made an entry and nodded to the man. [1034] A woman still held a small child, both seemingly asleep. [581] He glanced at it and thrust it into a pocket. [73] enlarged its image to show details [835]

Original

A moth struck a light above the delivery door. It moved repeatedly towards the illuminated surface, unable to maintain the orientation that ordinarily allowed it to navigate. It exhausted itself and fell behind a bin. A cleaning worker swept the area next morning. The insect's body had already been entered by small scavengers. The sweeping brought them into an unfamiliar patch of light and cold air. Several scattered; others were carried out with the rubbish. There was no boundary between the building's hygienic work and its generation of new places for living organisms, only successive attempts to control which kinds were permitted to remain visible.

Beyond the mortuary's loading bay stood a patch of waste ground enclosed by metal fencing. A contractor had planted shrubs there to meet a planning condition after an extension was built. The plants arrived in plastic pots, were transferred into soil compacted by machines, and watered for three weeks. After that the contractor's maintenance period ended. Two shrubs died during the following summer. Another was damaged when delivery vehicles began using the area as a turning space. A surviving bush produced berries. Birds fed on them and deposited seeds in places where the plants were unlikely to establish. Some did, briefly.

A fox had made a resting place beneath the service building. During one dry spell it brought a pigeon into the shade and consumed much of the body, leaving feathers and sections of bone. The remainder drew flies. Eggs were laid near exposed tissue; larvae fed and grew while temperature and food permitted. Several larvae left the body to pupate in drier soil. Ants discovered one of the pupae while its casing was still soft, bit through it and removed portions of the contents. Others emerged as adult flies. They fed at bins and flowers, encountered glass and motor vehicles, and died in places separated by dozens of metres. The pigeon had originally lived at the railway station, where its droppings had begun a long dispute between the railway operator and the council over responsibility for cleaning a roof.

Quotation version

Two light knocks struck the door. [846] Once a moth swooped into the light [184] In a while, only a third of the illuminated part was turned toward the earth. [638] Then, the fit over, it fell back, exhausted as usual. [661] swept up the cigarette butts and broken glass [60] A small, orange insect appeared. [778] It was swept raggedly away on the breath of a chill wind. [763] Many are dead; the rest scattered and lost. [276] Everything without the building was still, and no person appeared. [1134] permitted them to exercise a corresponding control over things. [487]

A place, a patch of ground? [587] a small patch of integrated activity [555] Here were the plans, the specifications, the construction plans. [1036] planted with all manner of shrubs [707] These plants had been arriving in small lots for about a week. [1386] That was the end of it. [750] surrounded by shrubs in the rich foliage of summer [42] it filled the space between a great host of vehicles [1259] We must search for months, sometimes, to find a single bush with berries. [1252] The birds are dead, but the plant flourishes. [406] and have probably been produced from seeds deposited there by birds. [744] Yes, several did. [512]

I said I thought the fox had got right away [1074] Then the wood-pigeons were devoured to the bones, and declared excellent. [1402] There were just feathers--and bones. [1471] And the flies? [1332] for the larvae of insects are full of eggs [1481] There the first eggs are laid. [535] supplying the larvae with food [747] It was plain that they had left her poor little body in the forest. [1464] some bringing in the pupae of ants [91] adult flies. [442] Who told you that dead people like flowers? [982] motor vehicles. [619] But the travellers came to a railway station at last, and left the coach. [561] a violent dispute had begun [1093]

Original

The argument had produced a letter stating that both organisations were committed to humane, non-lethal management. A new ledge strip was fitted to prevent perching. Several birds moved to a narrower surface above the ticket machine. Another pigeon became entangled in netting left loose at the roof edge. Its wing joints were held apart by the mesh. The bird made repeated efforts to move, exhausting itself while remaining visible from a platform where passengers were advised not to enter the track area. A cleaner reported it. The report went first to facilities, then security, then a contracted pest-management firm whose office closed at five. The trapped bird died while the matter was being allocated. The incident was recorded as resolved when the body was removed. A screenshot showing the closed ticket had been attached to the work-order system.

Beneath the mortuary wall, water from a damaged downpipe collected among grit and dead leaves. A slug crossed it at night, feeding on microbial film and softer plant tissue. Minute nematodes occupied the wet soil and the tissues of various small animals. Some lived freely, consuming bacteria. Others were associated with hosts. A parasite entered a young slug and reproduced under favourable conditions, affecting the animal's tissues and movement. The slug became less active, lost moisture and was consumed by beetles before the infection had completed its course. Several parasites died with it; others travelled in the beetles' gut or in the soil disturbed by their feeding. The patch of ground remained dark and wet despite the site's new drainage plan. The plan dealt with the main car park.

Inside the mortuary, temperature and cleaning routines restricted many organisms that could grow on available materials. The same activities left residues, filtered water, used gloves and disposable cloths that had to pass through other systems. A stack of absorbent pads waited for collection in a sealed container. Their fibres had been manufactured in another factory, packed in film, delivered and handled. The container went to a treatment facility where the contents would be rendered incapable of serving as a place of growth for many organisms. That was its purpose. The energy required and the residues produced by the treatment belonged to other permits, other measurements and other people. The person whose name was entered on the collection form was Gareth, though much of what the container held had never touched him.

Quotation version

Be humane. [664] He produced the inevitable letter. [912] perched on ledges on each side of the walls. [1282] I don't think those birds would figure that out anyway. [1122] the pigeons settling by twos and threes along the straight line of the roof [560] One of my wings has got some of the rivets out of it just above the joint. [1009] made efforts to escape. [664] quite out of the track of passengers. [377] It is reported so. [1] That was what the firm had contracted to do. [1386] the office closed. [233] The same kind of failure took place on each bird. [107] they say her body was removed [802] a rather curious incident which is well worth being recorded [23] I've got a yellow ticket, from Security. [353]

These leaves were then placed in water, and next morning were evidently dead. [337] A grotesque pulsating slug floating in a bath of some slimy fluid, perhaps? [1262] There was no underbrush; the soil was carpeted only by the dead, wet leaves. [863] But I lived, and the bacteria never touched me again. [1253] And the hosts of En did receive their portion before all others. [190] But after a little, conditions arise which are hostile to the further growth of the parasite. [279] Beetles became much more numerous [1414] The life of the grey field slug is very dependent on moisture. [1170] All the tribes of beetles which feed on vegetable substances, fresh or decayed, were very numerous. [77] It was quite dark now. [1110] in wet ground [1185] The idea had become a definite plan. [531]

Only certain acid-producing organisms grow, and these very slowly. [279] most such examples of adaptation have been studied in connection with possible temperature reactions upon the growing organism. [1364] It was a slow, clumsy, and costly way of weaving cloth, this cottage system of manufacture. [873] a sealed packet [1472] From the factory. [225] manufactured, shipped and delivered at one time to one party [102] Just fill the container again. [241] rendered incapable of growth [1170] What was its purpose? [1022] It can always be produced if required. [281] This process requires a certain expenditure of energy [1399] Never heard the man’s name in my life, or seed his form afore. [592] He was entered in my name. [36]

Original

A cleaner named Dee finished the floor and turned out the light. She was paid for thirty minutes but knew the work required forty if she did it properly. Her supervisor had offered a technique for saving time: start earlier. Dee asked whether that meant she would be paid earlier. He said he was talking about initiative. At the bus stop she searched for another job on her telephone. A listing described an exciting opportunity in environmental hygiene and specified that the candidate must be passionate about cleanliness. She didn't apply. She had already spent the evening preventing a succession of other organisms from occupying a building and did not feel passionate about the arrangement. The pay was worse.

The last bones from the fox's meal lay among stones in the waste ground. A worm drew organic particles into its gut. A fungal strand crossed the underside of a feather. At dawn a vehicle reversed over the shrubs, compressing a portion of the soil and cutting a small plant at its base. The driver got out to inspect the bumper. It was unmarked. He entered the building and reported that the turning space was satisfactory.

On his second evening alone, Matthew noticed the sound of the refrigerator vibrating against the wall. Gareth had wedged cardboard beneath it to stop the noise, then removed the cardboard because it made the machine run too hot. For years the vibration had been a point of disagreement that neither could make interesting enough to solve. Now it crossed the room with an unbearable precision. Matthew unplugged the refrigerator and went to bed. In the morning he found the milk warm and a container of food beginning to smell. He stood in front of it, furious at himself for having forgotten a thing as small as electricity. He threw the food away, washed the container and, halfway through washing it, realised Gareth would not be the person who noticed he'd done it.

Grace called to ask about a certificate. Matthew said he didn't have one. She apologised, explained that the person at the funeral office had been helpful, apologised for saying helpful, and asked whether he would come with her. They made arrangements for the following morning. Matthew wrote them down on the back of Gareth's shopping list because it was the only paper he had to hand. The list still contained batteries. He looked at the word until it no longer seemed to describe anything.

Quotation version

The vacuum cleaner's standby light calmed down. [834] He seemed to be working at the floor; and suddenly he turned off his light. [845] And she was young—only forty; and she worked only thirty years. [873] thirty minutes debit against his work time [242] She had started out long before he spoke. [106] I intended to start earlier [482] the money was to be paid [1386] He's been talking about nothing else. [1444] “Telephone call for you,” she said. [54] She signalled a bus to stop. [1306] their souls excited by their bodies’ cleanliness. [792] It is hygiene, for it enforces cleanliness [1047] But she didn't! [685] She could not feel at peace. [352] That was worse yet. [181]

bones from the evening meal [730] There lay by it a couple of gnawed bones, and, its meal finished [99] a few yards of silk-worm gut [1259] A faint breeze ruffled the gray feathers. [17] lie close to the base of the shrub. [770] shrubs trimmed [966] Why, he has got the driver to stop-- [141] the day passed unmarked by any incident [414] He entered the building. [371]

He was alone in the room, and it was night. [1050] a slight vibrating or creaking sound in it [1517] The hum of the refrigerator [1530] The machine stopped purring, and instead, its rear section began to vibrate. [430] but ultimately on this point there arose a disagreement between them [1324] We crossed the room hastily. [847] the strange prolonged silence in the house [103] There was no longer the faint vibration [840] warm milk [1258] The crude smell was that of wasted raw materials. [869] furious with himself [1054] He tore open the shutters, and threw up the sash. [811] He threw the food out [354]

request certificates or copies of documents [1204] I haven’t got one [230] And then suddenly she pulled herself up and apologised, saying she had forgotten. [97] He was very helpful over the details of the funeral. [1468] She could never leave a phrase unmodified. [162] These arrangements are made in the morning [444] He took a fresh piece of paper and wrote this item down. [1386] There was only a shopping list. [354] Most contain a tiny dry battery [1259] as often as I try to fit the reality with nearer words, I find myself in danger of losing the things themselves [908]

VII. The Funeral: A Thing with Handles

Original

Gareth's sister Grace arrived at the funeral director's with a folder of documents and the expression of a woman determined not to weep in front of someone who charged by the hour. Matthew arrived twelve minutes later. They kissed on the cheek. The gesture was neither warm nor cold; it failed to indicate which of them was authorised to make decisions. For seven years Matthew had bought Gareth's groceries, paid half the rent and argued with him about the thermostat. Grace's name appeared on the relevant form.

The funeral director, Miriam, had a square wooden desk, a face practised in remaining sympathetic through changes of subject and a diary divided into forty-minute appointments. She offered tea. Grace declined; Matthew accepted. Neither wanted it. The trip to the kettle gave the room an interval in which they were temporarily people awaiting a hot drink rather than people required to choose how another person would be disposed of.

'I don't know what he'd have wanted,' Grace said.

'Everyone in red,' Matthew told her.

'He said that to you?'

'At a funeral in 1988. He said the black ties made everyone look like bad news wearing bad news.'

'He never told me.'

'He kept it in circulation for years.'

Grace looked down. The remark could be an accusation, but Matthew hadn't meant it as one. The usefulness of having information about Gareth had begun to resemble a competition neither wanted to enter.

Quotation version

the adult pain that rested somewhere under the eyelids, [998] took charge of the funeral arrangements. [1492] Some twenty minutes later the ship arrived. [1037] His wife leaned over and kissed his cheek clumsily. [196] Even the propitiatory gestures of the creature failed to disarm me. [1463] neither hot nor cold [718] He had bought it, he said, with danger, and paid for it with toil. [1256] half of his rent would be paid [1409] the grace of her form [916]

a businesslike professional attitude was called for. [363] a square table [812] Without a clock the place simply couldn’t work. [1527] Will you have some [303] compliment [601] He didn’t want it. [1544] set water to boil in a kettle. [1091] had reseated herself to await the replenishment of the kettle [1478]

I don't know what he meant [807] He wanted—I don’t know what he wanted [792]

all in red [79]

What did he say? [472]

I was at a funeral. [728] These people had already braced themselves against bad news. [1498] he wears a black tie [1358]

“You never told me that.” [916]

It was, however, kept at bay during thirteen years. [212]

looked down [1396] He meant the remark in a general sense. [706] An accusation is an accusation. [161] but he hadn't meant it. [516] What I want is information: not useful information, of course; useless information. [1491] to enter upon our usual friendly competition [380]

Original

Grace had been dealing with bank accounts and cousins who wanted news but preferred not to be asked what they intended to do with it. Matthew had spent the same days answering whether he was looking after himself. He was beginning to suspect that looking after himself meant appearing less difficult for the people asking. He had eaten a tin of peaches standing at the refrigerator, unable to decide whether a meal required a plate. Grace had forgotten to feed her dog until the animal became assertive. They were both failing at ordinary things in ways that would have made Gareth unhelpfully hilarious.

Miriam returned with tea and a brochure. Two arrangements were labelled traditional and contemporary, although neither specified a century. There was a page of flowers priced by size, a page of handles described as dignified, and a lining upgrade described as soft. Grace asked what the standard lining was. Miriam said it was also soft. The difference, after a careful explanation, was decorative. A footnote stated that the advertised prices excluded transport beyond an agreed radius. The distance to the burial ground was within the radius, but the return journey was not mentioned.

'I suppose the lining isn't for his comfort,' Grace said.

'No,' Miriam said. 'It's mostly for yours.'

Matthew liked her for answering. Her honesty was not a discount.

Grace chose the plain pale-wood finish. Matthew noticed that the word *plain* cost less than *traditional* and more than *essential*. There was an uncomfortable pause before she asked whether he agreed. They both knew that her signature was required. Gareth had been introduced as Matthew's friend by people now telephoning him to ask what kind of flowers Gareth had liked. For the first time in his adult life Matthew would have liked to be asked a question on a form that had no legally useful answer. He said Gareth would have preferred something disgracefully expensive, and that they needn't buy it. Grace ticked the box. Both suspected, wrongly, that the other would resent the choice.

Quotation version

it is seeing to everything concerning him. [1379] show her bank-account and her visiting-list. [1473] Are you sure these kinds of comments are necessary? [1223] But you can’t cry for the rest of your life. [999] It was a simple meal, and he ate it in silence. [545] a tin box which had once contained Californian peaches. [226] had forgotten to feed the dog its dinner. [1115] One thing could not fail to strike even him. [808]

She must return in time for that English consoler of trouble--tea! [297] I have our brochure here setting out our service. [1445] the materials were handsomely printed up, elegantly bound [839] It may be a century, or three quarters of a century, or perhaps half a century. [1197] the size and colour of their flowers [890] The lining had been sewed up again. [664] Just as soft [36] The only difference will be in the decorations. [46] But by the excluded I mean that which will some day be the excluding. [483] while the distance to the ground must be [638]

What do the dead people know about it? [801]

“No,” said Miriam. [790] I trust you have had everything possible done for your comfort? [944]

He had a strong regard for honesty [479] it is included in the price [1311]

She chose a very plain [617] The variations in price depend on the physical qualities [739] She waited a moment, giving him time to reply. [98] Then if you will just sign the order… [1445] Do you know how your friend came by these? [1015] whom she introduced as her friend [947] This was impossible to answer. [228] No questions to be asked or answered. [554] And he didn't want or need something big and expensive. [1331] preferred because of their superior expensiveness or futility [1399] made a mark [414] But, as always, they were sorry for each other for the wrong things at the wrong times…. [462]

Original

Miriam had been a funeral director for nineteen years. In that time she had learned that the first thing many people did when confronted with a set of prices was apologise for looking at them. The price list was required by the regulator. The firm had complied by printing it on heavy paper and placing it in a folder whose cover read PERSONAL CHOICES. Some choices were unavoidable; others were offered at attractive increments. The basic transport charge could be reduced if the body was collected within business hours. The body had, of course, ceased to observe business hours. Miriam did not find this amusing, but someone in the office had once said it and been asked not to repeat it in front of clients.

There were two available burial appointments that week. One was at ten on Friday, the other at two on Monday. Friday was cheaper because the cemetery was already opening the ground for another service nearby. Grace disliked the idea that her brother might benefit from an economy of excavation. Matthew said Gareth would have wanted everyone to take the bargain. Grace said Gareth would say that, and then spend the money on an unacceptable floral arrangement. They both laughed and found themselves looking down at the table. Miriam gave them a minute. At another desk an assistant was filling in the heading NEXT OF KIN with a name copied from an email and briefly paused because the name was difficult to spell. The correct spelling would determine which person received a letter. The letter would determine who was expected to pay. It would make no difference to the body.

In the warehouse behind the showroom, a cardboard box of handle sets had become damp from a leak near a roof seam. The handles were inside their protective foam, but the outer carton distorted enough for the label to peel. A clerk printed another, checked the finish code and wrote the quantity in marker on the box. One of the metal fasteners had been dropped on the floor during inspection. It rolled beneath a shelf and became part of a collection of dust and things removed from sale by chance rather than by specification: a button, a staple, two insect bodies, a fragment of packaging, a small piece of red thread. The shelf had been moved once in ten years. The next time it moved, all these things would be swept together and classified as general waste. The insect bodies would be older than the red thread; the fastener would remain fit for purpose.

Quotation version

though a hundred and fifty years had passed since her funeral [802] The price was high, much too high for her to pay. [1174] She had learned to bargain, pare down prices [1476] pored upon all kinds of price lists [727] It's more like some firm's paper. [1459] opened a printed paper, and read: [414] as looking the part is well known to be more than half the battle in any form of business enterprise [864] There were roughly three things we could do now, and none of the choices was especially attractive. [501] No. The working hours may be reduced..... [1006] During what would have been my business hours [1133] repeated [790] He did not find things amusing. [508]

Week after week, however, passed away. [1284] Once also on a Monday at ten twenty-nine. [226] Today is Friday, and you will not have to wait many hours. [742] She disliked the idea of long journeys to begin with. [126] He was looking for a bargain. [1011] and it was really a bargain to anyone that wanted it. [948] what are you saying? [956] spend his money foolishly. [1491] laughed in spite of themselves. [157] a laugh went round the table. [792] had left them alone [1007] “The name is, of course, not the right one,” said the head assistant. [843] At the desk he paused. [771] Extracts from Letters received [467] He found his letter in the letter file and read it. [1301] It wouldn't make any difference. [942]

The box must have leaked before it was lost. [1464] From a debris of cardboard boxes [1279] They were labelled, but the labels were yellow with age and the writing was nearly undecipherable. [863] There had been a quantity of printing [378] clerks checked the innumerable invoices. [1540] He felt himself dropped on a hard metal floor. [721] dropped some metallic object on the floor [700] the small surface transient objects, [690] and the button rolled across the floor. [239] the red thread [1007] We rarely moved things; [690] rubbish suitable for the dustbin. [1127] This rapid sketch of the insect should be enough for our purpose. [443] and thoroughly fit for its purpose. [997]

Original

Before they settled on the pale finish, Grace had asked whether there was a cheaper option than the coffin shown in the brochure. Miriam showed them another model. Its finish was darker, its handles less ornate, its construction essentially the same. The advertised difference in price reflected supplier contracts, a small design change and the fact that the cheaper model had recently been discontinued. Grace looked relieved and ashamed. Matthew wanted to help and could think of nothing that wouldn't sound like criticism. In the end he said Gareth had once bought a counterfeit designer belt and worn it with the label on the outside. Grace remembered the belt. The imitation leather had cracked before the first winter. He'd kept wearing it until the buckle snapped. They had agreed to the pale model. Miriam explained that the supplier had three in stock. This sounded like good news, and for a moment it was.

After the appointment Matthew and Grace went to a café. They had never spent an hour alone together before. Grace stirred her tea until the metal spoon began tapping the cup. Matthew asked about the dog. Grace said it had eaten part of a plastic bag and was probably fine. She admitted she had forgotten to feed it for a day. Matthew told her he had switched off the refrigerator and ruined the food. They considered the possibility that grief might be making them both incompetent, then admitted they had each done comparable things when happy. Grace said Gareth used to imply that she was the practical sibling. Matthew said the implication was generous. They laughed for longer than the observation justified. In the middle of it Grace reached across and took Matthew's hand. His relief frightened him more than his sadness had.

Miriam ate a sandwich at her desk. An email from head office reminded staff to offer clients the full range of memorial products, as failure to inform customers was a missed opportunity to support them. She was expected to log every offer in a system which kept a record even when the answer was no. She opened Gareth's file and entered the coffin code. The software suggested an upgrade before she could proceed. She clicked NOT APPROPRIATE. It asked her to select a reason. There were six reasons, none of them grief. She chose OTHER. The system required additional details. She entered CLIENT DECLINED. In a month, the data would be used to design a new staff training course called Confidence in Difficult Conversations.

Quotation version

a lighter colour, [971] Is it possible to get a plain coffin?" madame asked. [200] Here's another model. Let's try it. [1543] Later fiction is less barometric as less architectural than the Gothic. [1210] Yet the prices got higher and higher, and the quality worse and worse. [1275] the above prices and those stipulated in the official contract [102] He looked haggard. [1320] He's got to think there is no help. [1302] He picks out a label. [945] I picked up the worn belt [783] she remembered [44] his belt [594] The outmoded cabs were worn and dirty--the cracked patent leather wrinkled like an old man's face [462] A belt would have kept your stomach in long ago. [410] The man on the platform turned pale, but said, “Agreed.” [27] She was stock-still but for the current. [1329] That was good news, I thought. [522] for a moment, but only for a moment. [253]

They went to a café to drink coffee [792] I had made an appointment [913] For days I never left them alone together. [646] He stirred his tea and stared into the cup. [912] tapping her spoon two or three times against the side of her cup. [1517] The dog now was quiet. [904] She answered that, according to his command, she had eaten it. [208] You'd think she'd have forgotten. [1490] she told further how that food was not plentiful with them [641] almost admitting that it was her fault that they didn't get along [493] Perhaps he was influenced by his sister, or by what he read. [1378] Matthew just said— [592] And they laughed like fiends. [655] laughed louder and longer [166] Her hand reached down to touch them. [1161] He reached across the table with his left hand [1216] He was frightened and bewildered, now. [48] It was chiefly relief, although a sad relief, I felt.... [124]

while munching at a sandwich. [266] going to show some products. [1375] was duly recorded. [1162] when a file has to be consulted [1204] Isn't that an improvement? [1159] It clicked. [788] not appropriate [1324] And for what reason? [1400] None of them had heard any answers. [1512] So she chose another. [1521] 55–72 Details of system. [1046] she declined [44] in a course similar to the one they used on their first try. [1297] All of this was data, important new data. [264] the acquisition of new knowledge and skills [1138]

Original

The coffin had been assembled six months earlier in a factory east of the city. A press had brought wood fibres from several sources together under heat so resin could bind them into panels. The panels were faced with veneer from a batch processed at Leena's yard. Behind that surface some regions contained more voids than others. The standard permitted them because the panels could bear the required load. Under damp conditions those spaces could become routes for water and sites of altered stress. The factory's job was to make a box that could carry a body as far as the grave.

The thin veneer was made to present the surface of timber, and it did so. It was not fake in the sense of consisting of nothing. Its grain was real, the pores and rays that formed its pattern having developed in the tissues of a living tree. The surface was merely much less of the structure than an observer would suppose. A visitor looking at the coffin could imagine a solid trunk reduced to four solemn sides. The panels under the veneer had never been a trunk. They were composites of things cut, mixed and made to occupy regular space. A colleague at the factory called the veneer a skin. He had worked there twenty-six years and had seen enough skins to prefer the machine's term, *facing*.

The lining was cut by an operator who adjusted the machine to reduce waste. White fibres accumulated along the cutter's guard, made visible when a strip of sunlight reached the table. Natural and synthetic filaments could be separated in principle, though not conveniently after they had been blended, dyed and made into fabric. Several fibres were pulled loose when the lining was stapled into the corners. They drifted beneath a workbench and entered a crack in the floor. An insect traversed the crack after the shift ended, moved across the fibres and continued beyond them. It did not take the white material for a path, a symbol of mourning or an available building resource. It crossed because the surface permitted crossing.

Quotation version

it is of a piece with constructing his own coffin, [1370] A purely mechanical process now easily separates the valuable fibres from the wood fibres. [279] The powdered resin is melted by heat [67] What might not be behind those green panels! [623] It's the surface of the planet, no more, no less. [137] The panels were open. [1402] The requirement of conformity to this higher conventional standard becomes mandatory. [1399] with the water they absorbed from the damp ground [1386] One carries them on to the grave. [286] They carry a kind of box [1465]

Makes it look quite woodlike. [1207] thin pieces, especially veneers, less than thicker boards. [1139] They were confident that nothing genuine could occur [513] Where it had writhed was now no waving grain, no trees, no green thing. [977] These trees have true woody tissues presenting that beautiful arrangement of pores [344] was merely on the surface. [1520] You look as solemn as a coffin. [1338] four bare walls seemed to close in upon you like the sides of a coffin. [623] Ahead the straight trunk went on and on, narrowing but never branching. [26] They came to a larger space where the coppice had been cut. [466] the body’s decent skin [207] He had worked on the place for six years now [587] after six and twenty years [301]

The big machine cut on [1101] where it is desired to cut away the waste exactly to a given line. [566] It's the sunlight, I think. [300] barely visible in the weak sunlight [222] It is not made at all, it is natural! [14] They are blended [41] At the end of this time the meat fibres were strained. [673] His body began to drift down toward the floor. [866] a loud crack as the fibres part [707] The path from the gate to the building was completely overgrown. [897] What, are you crossing of yourself? [932]

Original

The workers had become fast at producing a shape that changed very little between models. A small person called Bridget worked at the final inspection station, testing whether fittings would bear weight. A batch failed because a metal bracket had been attached at the wrong angle. The shift manager wanted to know whether the fault was visible under normal use. Bridget said it wasn't. He asked whether it was likely to matter. She said that was why the specification existed. He explained the importance of commercial judgement. She refused to sign. The batch was taken apart, the brackets moved and the holes filled before reassembly. The repaired boxes were sold at the normal price. Bridget's refusal entered her appraisal as a need to develop flexibility. The handles on the finished boxes bore the required load.

One coffin from that batch was damaged during transport and written off. It was taken back to the factory, stripped of its reusable fittings and broken up. The board was too contaminated with finish and adhesive to return to the normal board-production stream. It went to a contractor that accepted mixed wood waste. There the material was reduced again, mixed with other discarded furnishings and placed in a pile under temporary cover. Rain moved through the pile. Its surface dried on warm days and grew damp at night. In a sheltered seam, fungi expanded into parts of the lignocellulosic material they could use. Where additives and coatings resisted their enzymes, growth followed other routes. The pile neither returned to a previous state nor became something pure. It was an interval before further movement.

Miriam later described the intact model to Grace as an excellent choice. It was excellent at the things for which it had been selected. It had the dimensions required for a body, the surfaces required for a ceremonial object, and handles that enabled a group of people to lift it without putting their hands beneath. Those functions would be carried out only briefly. The metal could remain recognisable for much longer. The lining might lose the texture intended for mourners while retaining fragments of its manufactured fibres. Other parts would be attacked, altered and moved by different processes. There was no comparable functional test for their lives after the service. There was a warranty against manufacturing defects. It expired after twelve months, during which the purchaser was unlikely to be in a position to inspect the product.

Quotation version

they changed their shapes a thousand times a minute [638] Each step had to be thoroughly tested before weight was put upon it [863] A military deadlock ensued, and the problem became one of attrition. [476] Then every shift has seen it? [549] Perhaps--and this was the most likely hypothesis--he just didn't care. [554] Why he hadn't simply told me that it was no use [1237] A judgement! [478] its commercial importance [1004] She refused. [855] They had filled up the hole with an old golf stocking. [1384] Two large boxes to be sold separately. [1001] She made a gesture of refusal. [1472] They had almost finished with the loading. [364]

She might have kept the coffin and lived to be a hundred. [541] The original Di-tube model was still in its corner, undamaged. [53] Then one exploded on the pad and only a few on board were saved. [355] there was a great heap of waste wood [1386] If you can dispose of this material for profit, I certainly will appreciate it. [75] Outside it was raining hard. [619] Gradually the days and nights grew colder [779] and a few warm days had dried its surface somewhat [1370] One important use to which several species of fungi can be applied [288] fungi, dead parts of plants [1170] it had seemed to us like following the growth of some living creature. [128] It was a one-way passage. [13] No further approach was made by either, although intervals in the evening permitted it. [905]

an excellent choice [1003] every thing that was virtuous and excellent in her mind. [992] from which it differs both in dimensions and object. [1400] of sufficient dimensions to contain the body [950] It is your function to do so. [1391] Then comes a long story about metals. [160] This one has a lining, I see. [412] usually of fine texture, and manufactured for the purpose [950] a chain reaction would occur. [1346] There were no walking wounded in this war. [1500] it is guaranteed [69] twelve months [1386]

Original

Staples held the lining beneath trim. Cloth had arrived in rolls, woven to a specification that changed twice in five years. Handles were screwed into place; their alignment was checked. The assembly passed inspection for size and joint strength, was wrapped in plastic and stored. The supplier had rebranded the range as a collection.

The handles came from metal that had previously been rock. At the mine, the distinction had become economic rather than geological. Ore was separated from material with too little recoverable value to justify treating it the same way. The rejected material was placed into a widening formation of crushed rock, held by an embankment and monitored through instruments. The arrangement was called a managed facility. Under rain, water passed through exposed surfaces and acquired dissolved substances that altered the conditions downstream. A small pool at the edge of the facility sometimes appeared bright orange. The colour photographed well. A local newspaper used the image in a report on jobs and investment, having been unable to arrange access to the watercourse beyond the perimeter.

At the processing plant metal-bearing material was concentrated, heated and separated. Energy crossed the site in pipes and cables. Gases were captured where possible. Residues entered different control systems according to their chemistry and the terms of the operating permit. An automated warning sounded whenever one measure approached its limit. The operators had learned the sequence by ear. The warning's tone resembled the noise made by an old arcade machine when a player won a small prize. One worker had once laughed at the resemblance. His supervisor asked him to put the observation in the suggestion box rather than distract the team.

The fine sludge in a settling pond held particles small enough to move between grains of coarser waste. Several species of aquatic organism had colonised the shallow margins. A cluster of larvae depended on the thin oxygenated region near the surface. After a dry period, sudden rain altered the inflow and suspended settled particles. Light reached less deeply; oxygen use continued. Some larvae moved towards the edge, where they were more easily taken by birds. Others remained in place. Their gills moved for a time and then stopped. The pond did not cease to be alive. Its inhabitants changed, and the chemistry favoured another set of processes, including some which generated a sulphurous smell that the perimeter sensor was not installed to measure.

Quotation version

it was fastened with staples [1013] a roll of cloth [380] screwed to the board [902] fixed exactly square [902] passed a last inspection [1023] What collection? [1171]

What metal I wondered, did these people use? [1404] They didn’t pay. [226] Then why were we forbidden to mine of the ore? [1533] The material thus excavated will usually be sufficient to form the embankments. [1046] “How is that managed?” said I. [997] The surface water from rain [1307] the rain passes straight through to the ground. [709] bright, sparkling orange. [558] photographed well. [545] “That pile there,” the postmaster said, pointing to quite a pile of newspapers. [215] and the newspaper report was produced. [459] unable to go out beyond the gate [629]

The enclosing metal is then removed by chemical means or volatilized by heat. [739] all the water-pipes and concealed machinery and cables of the ways beneath [1466] So were the carbon dioxide and ammonia. [19] This system has taken various directions, according to circumstances. [1307] An alarm bell sounded. [1285] a curious, familiar sequence of sounds [1465] Everybody has won, and all must have prizes. [229] This machine makes quite a noise [1449] he laughed [1386] The safest thing in such situations is to remain silent. [839]

The basin occupied by the pond was probably scoured out by the glacier. [257] The water-eating organisms kept the surface dry. [169] I sprinkle on the surface of the combs some larvae that have lately left the egg. [442] By noon the rain had settled into a dull, steady downpour. [248] Light did it. [865] carrying the larvae and pupae in their jaws [91] Everything remained in its usual place. [948] Then its movement ceased suddenly. [863] The whole pond was alive. [439] They said the place had a febrile smell. [892] while the air was heavy with a sulphurous smell. [11]

Original

At a subcontractor's plant the metal was cast into shapes suitable for finishing. The finished handles were not pure examples of the material from the mine. They incorporated recycled feedstock and minor additions selected to produce the required strength and appearance. Surface treatment made the metal resemble a more expensive finish. A sales representative described it as heritage brass. The word heritage had been chosen because customers preferred it to electroplated alloy. The metal had no connection to the particular historical period implied by the catalogue; most of the period's original metal objects had themselves been made through processes considered modern or vulgar at the time.

The factory tested handles by applying loads greater than those anticipated in use. Failure points were recorded. Handles which passed were packaged in foam to prevent damage during transit. The foam came from a polymer whose feedstocks had passed through other industrial facilities, each with separate accounts of what was extracted, emitted or lost. Small sections broke away during unpacking. They passed into vacuum-cleaner bags, gutters and bins. A proportion was eventually crushed into material too small to recover by sorting. It acquired the status of contamination when it appeared in a stream of otherwise recyclable waste.

One handle had a flaw beneath its plating. The flaw was too small to be visible from the showroom side. Under a different environment it would encourage corrosion; under the present one it was harmless. The quality-control camera recorded a reflection on the surface, and software accepted the part. The camera was correct about the surface it had been asked to examine. In a meeting about defects the company adopted the phrase *zero escapes*, meaning that nothing defective should leave the line. A shipping clerk noted that nearly all their products escaped at the end of every shift and was told the programme was not intended to invite humour.

The handles entered a carton of forty, passed through a warehouse, and arrived at the coffin factory without any indication of the water behind the mine or the foam fragments dispersed by unpacking. There was no deception. A purchaser ordering handles had not asked for a history of the element's movements through earth, bodies, machines and wastewater. The relevant technical information concerned dimensions, appearance and load. A test result accompanied the carton. It was perfectly satisfactory.

Quotation version

except as metal to be cast in another shape. [789] They buy their handles by the gross, handles ready-made. [1540] chipping them into shape for the alterations and additions to be made to the house [561] the change was only skin-deep [537] with the usual imitation brass furniture. [1386] The words were carefully chosen. [1421] belonged to no particular period [434]

Loads are so applied in the ordinary testing machine. [1139] In many cases a test should be continued until complete failure results. [1139] because of the fragile nature of the load [1205] a complex of saturated long-chain polymers [61] He managed to pull a section away. [368] Disposable sacks for vacuum cleaner. [1441] It crushed to powder. [1519] the old definition of dirt as matter out of place. [403]

the hidden flaw [834] It was not visible. [242] They are always present, but commonly harmless. [279] The camera reflects everything that happens. [1319] he had accepted it [664] Quite correct [1461] as far as it went [1092] nothing defective [1219] will be allowed to pass. [1333] no joking! [957]

They entered the warehouse. [367] passed through the glaring corridor of offices and storage-warehouses [179] There was no deception about this. [614] the things that slip through the world otherwise unperceived [351] different in dimensions and appearance [10] details of tests and results [1139] Perfectly satisfactory. [1286]

Original

The coffin factory also made boxes for people who preferred not to use the word coffin. Their catalogue distinguished traditional, simple, contemporary, ecological and natural products. The photographs showed each product in the same empty room under the same soft light, which was a considerable achievement because several could not be manufactured from the materials suggested by their appearance. One model was advertised as solid-looking. Another was called earth-friendly. The phrase was printed in green and accompanied by a drawing of three leaves. The factory had been advised not to make a specific claim about what happened underground. The leaves were not a specific claim.

In the finishing area, sanding removed minute portions of surface material until the veneer appeared continuous beneath the coating. Dust entered an extraction system. Fine particles suspended in air were collected on filters, while larger fragments settled in corners and on machinery. The filters were changed according to recorded pressure difference. For several days before a change, the airflow through part of the system had been reduced by an accumulation of material. An employee repeatedly wiped a pale residue from his sleeve. He was told the readings remained compliant. The reading was taken at the extractor's outlet, where it was supposed to be. He worked beside the bench. These were different locations, neither invisible to anyone willing to stand there.

A seam of glue made two manufactured boards behave as if they had grown together, to the limited extent required of a furniture joint. The adhesive set by a chemical process controlled by temperature, pressure and mixing. In one batch the room was cooler than the production schedule allowed. The material reached usable strength later than expected. An operator set aside several pieces and checked the joint by applying force to samples. The failures occurred within the permitted tolerance. The batch proceeded. At no point did the test demonstrate that the joint would remain unchanged indefinitely. The guarantee covered manufacturing defects for one year. The product was intended to be buried. Its return conditions had been described as discreet.

Quotation version

The former seem chiefly to make coffins and highly painted and decorated clothes-boxes. [1414] a list of semantic cue words [1112] Instantly the room was flooded with soft light. [1419] difficult as had been its achievement from the materials in hand. [1159] Looks solid enough from here. [1035] respect what we discard [351] The third was green throughout, and so were the casements. [1105] prettily decorated with green leaves. [12] make no claim. [990] I made no claims. [668]

rubbing it with glasspaper [1386] invisible beneath a coating of the same [638] They sucked in dust and dirt [1305] The air was so full of the small particles [638] filtered fine particles of dust [233] by the difference in the air-pressure. [1225] the air passages became obstructed [100] filliping the dust from his threadbare sleeve [664] The actual readings can be noted [7] at the outlet [7] He was perched on the edge of an opposite work bench [261] To begin with, the location is entirely different. [1006]

In the case of several boards to be jointed into one piece [1038] When everything fits, glue and clamp together. [1038] I shall make it by a chemical process. [1400] temperature and pressure [1285] the room was colder. [922] gaining strength very, very slowly [222] Tests to determine the strength [1139] There were just going to have to be rejects, and that was that. [1411] This I proceeded to do. [112] they will not last forever [10] it is guaranteed [69] for one year [379] He may have intend to bury them deep in the ground. [1332] discreet return [287]

Original

Discarded panels occupied a covered bay. The coverings were torn and rain reached the lower stack. A blue-green growth appeared on the surface of one panel where its finish had not been applied evenly. The growth drew resources from material exposed through the damaged coating. Nearby, a colony of springtails fed on fungi and decaying organic residues in the damp space. A predatory mite took several of them. After a period of drying the fungal growth stopped advancing, and some of the springtails moved deeper into a seam. The stock was later classified as recoverable waste. Workers separated pieces that could be trimmed and resold from those suitable only for chipping. They found the growth unpleasant and wore gloves. The panels had been made partly from living wood, but this new life made them defective.

An order arrived for a coffin with a smooth lining. The customer selected a cream colour from a sample book. In the supplier's workshop, woven fabric moved through rollers and past a cutting station. A fine synthetic yarn had been blended with natural fibres to give the cloth dimensional stability. Cutting produced a fringe of short filaments at the edge. Most were removed in finishing. A worker used a vacuum cleaner to clear the rest. The cleaner's filter retained many, not all. A small amount escaped into the workshop air and settled among fibres shed from workers' clothing. At home, one of the workers shook dust from her shoes into a garden whose soil had already received fibres from washing. A blackbird fed among the disturbed particles. It selected an earthworm and left the fibres in place. Not every pollutant became part of a body; not every body avoided it.

In the upholstery section, scraps of lining fabric were gathered in a sack. The supplier's environmental policy described a preference for circular materials. An audit found that the sack was going to general waste because its mixed contents could not be separated economically. The manager introduced two colour-coded sacks, appointed a sustainability champion and took photographs. On the first morning a worker put synthetic offcuts into the natural-fibre sack, having been told by another worker that the difference was whether the fabric felt soft. The champion corrected him. Both sacks subsequently entered the same skip when the recycling contractor declined to accept the volume. The photographs remained useful because they were of the new procedure. Nobody had claimed they showed its destination.

Quotation version

inlaid in the panels of its covers. [426] Then there were stacks upon stacks of prints. [1520] Some paper-dry growths were still blue-green. [502] Subsequent growth over the damaged portion does not cohere with the wood previously formed by the old cambium. [1139] In this metamorphosis as the fungi flourish so the twigs decay [288] A still larger number of fungi are developed from decayed or decaying vegetable matter. [288] Take him, poor little mite—I'll cut the bread. [791] They preserve their form when dry for an indefinite period. [1370] it must have been here in recoverable quantities. [306] How would it do to trim its nails? [110] The pieces are then separated with a fine saw [902] He was wearing a pair of enormous, misfit white gloves. [8] They may be composed partly of wood—wood that has no longer vitality—or wholly of metal. [110]

In the coffin? [239] an order for a coffin [377] It was a rich cream colour [463] so if you hear us moving about in the workshop [204] More twists of woven fabric [1022] frequently used in blends for these cloths. [1523] We must be on the very fringe of this beam. [608] were cut away [1270] You should've told the king we were inventing a vacuum cleaner or something. [1292] many, but not all [1364] thin clouds of unsavoury dust, mingled with the light refuse [544] shook some of the dust [748] dust on her shoes [579] a blackbird flew down, and hopped in [561] only this earthworm is left to protest. [664] How every part lives and breathes! [632]

put into a sack [408] The tank is by preference circular, as shown. [425] a greater waste had been going on [592] Economically it would have been wasteful [283] we've got two sacks [1386] took photographs [1522] I touched the material carelessly; it was of softest smooth white serge. [124] synthetic or natural [1285] It seemed clean and soft [500] corrected him [1419] the same receptacle [1476] he declined to accept [562] These photographs had been but recently taken. [62] made no claim [957]

Original

In the warehouse a row of finished coffins stood on supports. Their surfaces were undamaged, their interiors unused. A beetle crawled beneath a pallet and disappeared into a crack in a wooden bearer. A cleaning machine passed two metres away. Air moved between the boxes as a loading door opened. A carton of fasteners was misplaced, found, moved and misplaced again. Gareth's future coffin had not yet acquired its final fittings. It stood among several indistinguishable products with its lid resting loosely in position. When it was finally invoiced, the line item specified a particular finish and a pair of handles. The invoice contained no error. Its purchaser would later be asked whether she had found the choice comforting. She would answer yes because there was no form for the relief of having stopped choosing.

A worker called Sylvia applied a final polish to the lid and put it back on the rack. Her father had recently died. She had bought a similar model from another company because employees were not offered a discount. When a colleague asked whether the work had become difficult, she said, 'No, the work was difficult before.' She had been advised by human resources to take the time she needed, subject to the arrangements for bereavement leave. The coating dried. The next lid arrived on her bench.

In the warehouse there had been no Gareth. A label showed a code, finish and size. On Tuesday another added a name and reference number. A clerk corrected the spelling from two r's to one and checked Miriam's email twice. This took longer than attaching the label.

In preparation for the body the lid was removed. The lining yielded beneath a gloved hand and returned imperfectly. A faint chemical smell remained. Gareth was placed inside by people whose work required precise, sometimes difficult movements. They did these with care, although they had no time for the theatrical reverence the brochure implied. A fastening caught on the cloth; one of them freed it. In the corridor a porter had a brief argument about his rota. His colleague reminded him to lower his voice. They were both right.

Its boundaries were persuasive: panels enclosed a volume, veneer disguised joints, handles showed where to hold it. When lifted, load moved unevenly through screws, board, finish and fabric. Different components had different origins and would respond differently to damp and time. For now they were called one thing, lifted as one thing and invoiced as one thing.

Quotation version

They also took a small pair of tressels for the coffin to stand on. [1386] not been used [863] the grimy beetle crawled on [282] A few feet away stood a machine. [515] Bars threw open doors and fresh air met stale air. [967] it was misplaced. [791] found it again [728] it was misplaced. [791] not yet finished [407] hard to distinguish one box from another. [2] I saw the invoice, and took note of it [1332] without error [44] Always she was making choice; always resolving. [154] Is this indeed your choice?” she asked me. [1195] but she did [265] having nothing left to choose. [787]

polishing or varnishing the coffin [1386] Her father died suddenly two days ago. [889] No discount [554] it had always been [876] difficult work [775] I'm sorry for your loss. [1207] Perhaps you need to go home [1207] Their coats dried then. [727] the work went on [788]

had no name [580] And you use a code they all know. [901] Indeed, names have been mentioned. [914] I’ve given your name as a reference. [1508] twice [790] corrections of spelling [953] took a very long time doing this [636]

the lid was removed [1332] yielded under the pressure of [21] her gloved hand [845] when the smell is faint [661] placed him in the casket. [1445] his movements were quick and precise [100] with a care [390] Her skirt caught on a barb; he carefully freed it. [854] The porter [726] was arguing [790] in respect for the sad occasion of the day, [689] and, lowering his voice, said [1401] They were both right. [155]

showing darkly a dining-room panelled with old oak [426] the load had been lifted [1491] damp [296] fundamentally different, and have had different origins [1416] a single object [1335] invoiced [408]

Original

On the morning of the funeral Matthew found no clean shirt. This was inaccurate; two remained, but one had lost a button and the other was behind a suitcase. Gareth usually located things by recognising the shapes they made in the surrounding disorder. Matthew wore the shirt with the missing button and Gareth's red scarf, drawing it across the gap. In the mirror he looked like someone protesting at a respectable gathering, which was not quite what he intended. The electricity supplier had sent a message headed *We understand this is a difficult time.* It concerned a payment that had failed after a card was cancelled.

The burial ground occupied land whose former drainage lines still influenced its wetness. A map in the cemetery office showed plots as a grid of rectangles with paths between them. The soil did not form rectangles. It contained bands of clay, disturbed layers from earlier work, roots and seams through which water travelled more easily. In one part of the site the ground remained wet long after rain had stopped. The cemetery manager had ordered drainage improvements, but the permitted budget covered work on the paths, where visitors could fall and make claims. Several graves retained standing water beneath their surface soil after the contractors left.

The grave dug for Gareth had been selected for location, availability and depth. Its boundaries were cut through a living arrangement of roots, small animals, fungi, bacterial populations, mineral particles and air-filled spaces. Some roots were cleanly severed. Others tore away with clods of earth. A worm was exposed in the wall and withdrew into a newly opened gap that led nowhere sheltered. Beetles from a deeper layer moved into a pocket of light. A pale centipede was struck by the excavator's edge and remained moving in fragments of soil after the bucket lifted. These events were not unusual enough to be described as incidents. They were conditions of excavation. The ground was made ready in forty-seven minutes. The cemetery's productivity measure had improved since the purchase of a smaller machine.

Quotation version

had nothing to wear. [1519] the missing button [623] a suitcase [1253] The shadows of things assumed strange and ghastly shapes. [1256] they can usually be recognised at a glance. [1416] with a red scarf [327] clothes of dead people. [801] For it was an unjust mirror, this mirror of his soul that he was looking at. [1491] were the messages sent to us by our successful comrades in other lands. [873] But your card wouldn't. It would have had its silent message. [903]

In dry seasons the ground-water surface sinks. [1027] the cemetery showed as a dark streak in the distance [245] the little white cemeteries with their square plots [155] Soil created by artificial filling up. [32] If the soil is heavy clay or has tight formation [1178] The rain stopped. [1306] still wet and slippery. [455] Beyond the tram were posts and heaps of gravel—the drainage works. [1462] so great a weight of water standing over the grave [1371] the soil was heavy and inclined to retain standing water too long [1489]

even now the small grave is dug for ye [1256] The nature of the cutting reveals the purpose at every step. [1192] fungi, roots, and such like bodies [1048] having taken root in a rich native soil [329] it tore the earth and the bushes [641] Either the worms were dead--or frightened away! [1385] the worm is exposed to grave dangers. [442] The hard brown beetles kept thudding against the dull light [463] threw off fragments or came into contact with water or a fresh texture of soil. [1466] I struck off a fragment. [986] The phenomenon was unusual, certainly, but hardly enough so to merit any special attention. [584] The conditions were: [867] Forty-Seven Minutes [1400] What is the measure of the best machine? [604] this is an improved machine [670]

Original

At the edge of the trench, a small root network belonging to a young tree had reached a layer richer in nutrients than the soil above it. The excavation removed part of the network and exposed another part to air. The tree's growth the following spring would be slightly different. It would not be possible to assign the change to the grave from its appearance alone. Other conditions would also have altered it: rain, temperature, insects feeding on leaves, fungal associations, injury from a strimmer, a drought at the beginning of summer. The change belonged to the tree's history without forming a legible statement about Gareth.

A grounds worker named Simon had been made responsible for lowering costs. He kept a notebook in which he recorded which graves required additional support after rain. He knew the cemetery manager preferred the term *efficiency*. Simon preferred not to have coffins lodged at an angle because a cheap strap had failed. He checked the equipment and replaced a buckle at his own initiative. The supplier refunded the cost after three emails. Simon received a message thanking him for his commitment to excellence and asking that he seek approval before future purchases. He printed it out and pinned it above the kettle. Beside it was a notice reminding staff to treat all families with dignity.

The adjacent grave had been visited regularly for twenty years, then less often. At its head a rose had been planted and left to establish itself. Aphids colonised new shoots each spring; some were eaten by ladybirds, others survived long enough to reproduce. A year of unusual weather changed the timing of the cycles. On one warm morning the aphids were abundant and their predators fewer. Leaves curled around the damaged tissue. The rose remained alive, produced fewer flowers and was later pruned by Simon, who didn't know its history. The person who had planted it was now in a care home and had forgotten which plot belonged to her husband. Her daughter knew the number but had not visited for six months. The rose's fewer flowers did not constitute an abandonment any more than its flowers had constituted remembrance.

Quotation version

this trench has been opened [1538] covered with a network of roots [602] the roots of the trees were exposed [341] spring growth [707] Can you be thinking of breaking a grave, somewhere? [455] the leaves rippled down as quick as summer rain [917] but conditions altered from day to day [1064] first we had a drought, beginning in early summer [1095] Both of these trees have an interesting history. [344] Change succeeded to change; the entire history did not reach me [1256]

reduce their expenses [1541] The rain poured in the grave. [790] He had kept notebooks [1517] What saves us is efficiency—the devotion to efficiency. [282] the leather strap had broken [482] He checked his other equipment. [17] on his own initiative [463] You have had the money and must refund it. [378] the prior approval of the Management [486] pinned it on the wall [909] And they seem to be clothed, as it were, in dignity. [774]

their graves were always visited [579] but less often [1141] rose-bush on the grave [564] the buds are covered with aphides. [708] New shoots spring [67] in the sense of living long enough to reproduce. [1369] But the time of year is come for changeable weather. [592] The morning sunlight was warm about them. [1023] the days were warm and food abundant [661] the vine leaves curled [164] it was still alive [414] the pruned rose bushes [345] fewer flowers [707] impossible to recall [1045] her husband’s grave [792] she had not visited [593] The comparison, you see, is not a true one. [999] The flowers constitute the sexual parts of the plant. [1260]

Original

Before the funeral the grave was covered with a temporary board and surrounded by chairs. The board distributed weight across the softer edges. Beneath it a small pocket of air became warmer while microorganisms continued consuming available substances in the soil. A droplet remained on the inside of a plastic fixing and accumulated dust. A slug crossed the edge of the grave, feeding on a film of algae near the damp timber. A blackbird pulled it from the surface and struck it against the corner of a stone. By the time the mourners arrived the blackbird had left, and Simon had moved the chairs until they formed two neat rows. The rows looked solemn. They were also the easiest configuration for carrying them back.

The soil at the burial ground had never been an undivided substance. Even within a shovelful there were different sizes of particles, water-filled pores, air-filled pores, dead tissues and living organisms altering those spaces. A springtail which entered a gap beneath a root could not travel freely through the clay beside it. A nematode moving in a film of water encountered bacteria and fungal strands. A predatory mite reached into the same region and captured a springtail whose legs could not find purchase. Under dry conditions all three might have occupied deeper pockets; after rain their ranges changed. When the grave was cut, a continuous arrangement of paths was divided in a single afternoon.

In a root near the excavated wall, a fungus had entered through a wound made by an insect. It spread through tissues the living tree had formerly kept intact, meeting barriers of resin and other compounds in some places and moving freely through dead cells in others. The insect that made the wound had died before the fungus reached the branch. Its body had become part of the material available to bacteria and scavengers in the wood. The fungus had no reason to preserve the original entrance. By the time Simon's machine cut across the root, the wound was impossible to recognise as a separate event. The blade fractured the wood; the fungus lost access to one region and gained it to another. A white thread of growth extended into the exposed face. The soil pressed against it when the grave was filled. Growth continued where water and air permitted.

Quotation version

Chairs were arranged in neat rows [429] with a cover on it, [675] the same principle of widest distribution of weight [872] There lurked within a little warmer air. [1461] to act upon other soil substances to render them more available for plant food. [1489] A light coating of dust was everywhere. [111] Very little dust had accumulated [797] slugs, wriggled or crawled along the path [696] It had struck against a stone, when he fell. [1493] A blackbird flew past [620] They formed two neat rows [221] look as solemn as if this were a funeral [1160] carrying them back [1353]

a heterogeneous mass [845] living or dead creatures, spores of cryptogamic plants, and micrococci [335] passing through a gap [1414] a nematode or eel worm [1489] living free in the earth [1170] those struggling legs [924] as it afforded no grip to them [1465] The others were going through their pockets. [1151] So they sat down close together in a corner of the path. [525]

wood penetrated by mycelium [288] The tree is a living organism composed of cells like any other living organism. [851] a resinous liquid that repels them [91] the insect actually dies [446] surrendered to the weather and the earth [307] No trace of its fate was ever discovered. [308] It was impossible to recognise them. [719] the wood splits [443] the delicate white threads [762] The grave was then filled in [1402] The growth became thicker [863]

Original

A beetle larva lived inside a rotting piece of timber that had been buried in an earlier landscaping job. It fed slowly and avoided desiccation by remaining in the softer interior. When the grave excavation shifted the timber, the larva was exposed in a newly opened chamber. It contracted, then moved towards a darker edge. A centipede seized it before it reached another gap. The centipede ate while Simon measured the width of the trench above it. The measurements were correct. When soil fell back, the centipede entered a cavity too small to be closed by the descending clods. The body of the larva had already begun passing into a different organism. Nothing would be restored by putting the timber back in the ground. The cavity had been opened; one animal was dead; the predator was no less vulnerable because it had fed.

That autumn the centipede was killed by a fungal infection. Spores had adhered to its outer surface and germinated when moisture and temperature suited them. Filaments penetrated tissues and consumed nutrients; the centipede's movement diminished until it stopped. A different arthropod fed on the dead body before the fungus completed its growth. The infection spread through portions of the remains and was interrupted where they dried. Several spores persisted in soil. Most never reached a susceptible host under conditions that allowed development. A surviving spore could remain viable while every animal associated with its production had gone. This was neither triumph nor continuity of identity. It was one component of a life cycle that failed far more often than it succeeded.

On the older side of the cemetery, a patch of ground had escaped mowing during a shortage of staff. The longer vegetation supported a larger population of small insects for part of the season. Insects fed, mated, laid eggs, were taken by spiders and birds, or failed before reproducing. The patch also shaded a stone whose lichen growth had begun to spread over an inscription. A family paid to have the stone cleaned. The gardener used the approved method, then trimmed the long grass to match the surrounding plots. The family wrote to thank him for making the grave look loved. Their approval made the maintenance manager certain the programme should continue. Next season the patch was mown before several insects completed development. The stone remained easier to read. The gardener received a small increase in his hourly rate after joining another contractor.

Quotation version

rotting wood [915] the soft interior [327] laid bare the chambers beneath [91] a remarkable chamber is built up by the larva [535] Then it contracted [462] moved into the shadow [797] came out and seized me. [1374] was taking measurements [218] all his measurements were correct. [790] Centipedes and millipedes in dozens came too, and were not welcome. [659] a portion of soil fell inward as he scraped, and disclosed a small cavity. [700] I am nearly devoured. [1374] what was done could not be undone [629] It was found that animals were continually dying natural deaths under more or less suspicious circumstances. [211] a cavity opened [779] It too had become vulnerable. [1434]

perish from the influence of its destructive parasite. [288] the spores germinated profusely [288] more slowly this time [924] did not stir [924] with the fungus sprouting from its body. [288] The infection had now spread [1256] spores probably contained in the soil [288] The welder never reached the infirmary. [760] they could never have developed under existing conditions. [1369] resting spore, may remain dormant in this state [288] There was no atmosphere of triumph [317] but a small number can survive [334]

a patch of garden ground unburied. [1465] An old cemetery lies to one side of it [1041] and vegetation, which alter the nature of the insect population so greatly [446] she lays her eggs [334] with a stone roof strangely coloured by the growth of moss and lichens. [916] paid for the work [1386] the most approved methods [1230] I kept the grass trimmed. [1270] to the graves of those we loved [1256] the family grave [133] The manager, who accompanied them, was obliged to continue the conversation. [1541] Does the same season witness the insect’s final transformation and its labours? [446] read the inscription [592] the substantial increase of wages it brought [592]

Original

A colony of woodlice had occupied a cavity beneath the edging of a path. They consumed decaying plant material, microorganisms and soft residues from older litter. Moisture sheltered them. A prolonged dry spell forced them into a shrinking damp region beneath a stone. Several young died; a larger individual consumed part of one body. On the third dry night a shrew entered the cavity and took two more. The shrew was infested with fleas and carried a heavy parasite burden from earlier feeding. It moved out of the cemetery and was caught in a snap trap behind a house. The householder put the body in a bin, pleased that the trap had been humane because it had killed quickly. The fleas left as the body cooled. Two entered the fur of a cat that had been investigating the bin. The cat was later treated with a preparation designed to kill fleas. The treatment worked. Its active compounds were present for a period on the cat's coat and in the material the household disposed of while cleaning. The household had behaved responsibly by the standards available to it.

Simon went through the grounds with a measuring wheel, checking that no memorial exceeded the permitted area. A small stone angel stood four centimetres outside its plot. He wrote a notice and attached it with a plastic tie, then returned to make sure the notice could be read from the path. At the angel's base, a snail withdrew from direct light into the gap opened by its weight. A mite crawled onto its shell. Ants carried away fragments of a dead moth. The notice gave the owner fourteen days to move the memorial before the cemetery acted. No owner could be traced. At the end of the period Simon moved the angel himself. Beneath it the snail was crushed against the path edging. Its shell broke into pieces. Simon saw the remains and wiped his fingers on the grass before measuring the next stone. The memorial was now within regulation.

The church was cold. June had turned the heating on early, but one radiator was airlocked and another knocked as its pipes expanded. She had been asked to provide additional chairs; the parish refused to pay for their hire because funerals were counted as church activity. Outside, the old blue ribbon remained threaded beneath the drain cover, beneath new layers of silt. June meant to remove it. The list of things she meant to do had been copied into a new notebook when the old one filled up. The transfer had given it the appearance of progress.

Quotation version

the beech alley was transformed to a path beneath ilex-trees [916] beneath which was a cavity of considerable depth [414] decaying vegetation [405] the moisture which is necessary for their existence [1170] Some of us have damp ways, and some of us have dry ways. [376] died at an early age [949] having thus consumed the body [616] The third night [174] A shrew-mouse also was caught. [758] sprung the trap and got caught. [1070] Beyond a doubt, the trap held an animal. [1004] the fleas deserted their host [707] the cat’s fur [129] began at once to investigate [309] flea-powder [588] “My treatment is working,” [1332] minute doses of poison [218] The cat, having cleaned all her fur [728] It was a household. [622]

to take measurements [218] on which a beautiful sculptured angel stood [1338] They did, and read the notices on the board outside. [1007] So he wrote out a notice [770] he returned to the path [1350] He had just inserted his head in the opening [1521] A gap, a space opened before him. [792] crawled on. [1023] The worker ants take it back to the nest [218] fourteen days [1465] notice to move out. [861] They cannot be traced. [42] Simon moved [800] sculptured angel [1338] slimy path of a snail [462] Now it cracked and broke in a thousand brittle pieces. [571] wiping his fingers on the coarse yellow grass beside him. [1148] complied with the regulations [1538]

The space was dim, damply cool [963] it turned on the heating units [1305] rattling as it expanded under the influence of the heat. [1345] Extra chairs had been brought [873] The blue ribbon was not new [587] intended to remove [1134] in my notebook. [4] She then made up a list [981] You're being transferred. [1427]

Original

Charles arrived with Scarlett. Fiona and Tom stood at the entrance, unsure where to put their hands. Carrie had travelled down from Scotland. She was wearing a coat with a narrow belt that repeatedly came loose. Hamish wasn't with her. She said that he had work he couldn't rearrange, and then seemed irritated at having offered a justification. Charles said he was sorry. She asked which part he meant. He had to think.

They entered without finishing the conversation.

The coffin entered on four sets of hands. Each step shifted its angle; force moved through handles, fasteners and board. A wet sleeve marked a corner. One bearer, worried about his grip, was a fraction ahead and slowed without being told. The lining moved less than the shell.

For a few minutes the entire visible assembly occupied one field of attention. Benches, flowers and printed names faced it. The veneer appeared continuous; beneath it, fibres, adhesives and fasteners carried loads that differed. At the appointed moment the coffin settled onto its supports. Nobody could distinguish its histories from its polished surface. The bearer opened and closed his aching fingers.

Matthew rose carrying a scrap of paper that was not his speech. On its reverse Gareth had written milk, lemons, batteries and a name Matthew couldn't decipher. He had found it in a coat pocket and taken it with him because it was unbearable to leave behind, though bringing it made no sense either.

'Gareth,' he said, 'was a generous man, although he liked you to know the price of his generosity.'

People laughed. Matthew could hear the laugh travelling from the front of the church towards the back, where several people had never met Gareth but had been told this was the sort of thing they ought to enjoy.

'He once spent three hours helping a neighbour carry a wardrobe downstairs. For the next four years he brought it up whenever the neighbour asked a favour. The wardrobe had belonged to the neighbour's dead mother. Gareth didn't find that a reason to stop.'

Matthew unfolded the paper and looked at the list.

Quotation version

Charles was there. [466] not knowing what to do with their hands [662] they stood at the door [42] came from Scotland [1177] their belts loosened. [1507] He was not with her [790] her own actions, which somehow seemed to require justification. [1053] He said he was sorry [481] She asked what, exactly, it all meant. [477] He had to think! [294]

sentences begun which he could not finish [44]

the coffin was carried [97] They move slowly through angles. [884] He shifted his position [875] placing each foot first tentatively then extra firmly [163] wet sleeve [922] he slackened his pace [1520] I discovered it was a shell, a hollow thing, and I passed inside. [1470]

These arrangements took some minutes and during that time occupied all our attention. [574] wooden benches [1003] into which the furniture had been loaded and carried away. [250] then brought in the coffin and placed it upon them. [1386] I could not even tell what they had belonged to. [603] the fingers clench and relax. [686]

He took a scrap of paper [964] The name, you know, was written on the back. [913] He handled the things with a respectful tenderness, as if he had been lifting the dead body of his lost friend. [177]

“Yes,” replied the man, “but at what a price!” [414] He is a very generous man. [520]

Whereat the people laughed. [22] the laughter was part of the pain. [998] a mutter of laughter ran down the line [514]

three hours [1465] helped to carry [1090] There are remarks which, having been once made, are repeated at intervals, on principle: [163] they had been neighbours for four years [463] belonged to her dead mother. [1141] Besides, they didn't want to stop. [343]

Then he unfolded a paper [775]

Original

'He could be cruel. I don't want to make him less difficult now just because he's dead. He knew when I'd had a dreadful day. Sometimes he would make it worse, and then apologise so absurdly that we'd both be laughing while I was still angry. At other times he put the kettle on before I said anything. Sometimes he brought the tea. He knew me better than almost anyone, and it did not always make him kinder.'

A few people shifted. Grace looked at her hands. Matthew had decided not to deliver an argument; he couldn't tell whether honesty had made the decision for him.

'We lived together seven years. There are relatives here who found that an awkward sentence. For us it meant that he knew which floorboard creaked and where I kept the spare key. It meant making room for him without noticing I was doing it. And now I keep moving to make room for him when he isn't there.'

He stopped. The last line embarrassed him; it had arrived without his permission. He had wanted to say something cleverer. He put the list in his pocket and sat down. No one attempted to help him, an achievement by the standards of the day.

The service continued. Words altered the listeners, not the moisture moving into the lining or the forces at its supports. Charles remembered Gareth embarrassing him in public and defending him afterwards. Fiona was angry to have survived him. Grace remembered persuading Gareth, as children, to climb a wall, then blaming him when he fell. She had never corrected the lie. It was unbearable, then foolish, then unbearable again.

At the burial the ground was heavy with water. Straps lowered the coffin; load shifted to the earth. Soil struck the lid in sounds varying with its moisture. A machine waited for the mourners to leave. The operator had instructions not to begin while they could see him. Several guests struggled to find their cars because they had blocked one another in, in obedience to a notice requesting responsible parking.

Quotation version

could be cruel upon occasion [86] There's no reason to imagine that a dead person was necessarily pure, faithful, and good. [1040] You scarce knew him before to-day. [677] I am sorry [383] Half angry, and half laughing [192] put the kettle on [922] brought the tea [1474] knew him better than anyone who lived. [529] not always kind, though. [398]

a little agitated rustle to break up the silence [162] She looked down at her hands. [788] whether this was the right decision [731]

We have been together so many years. [406] awkward sentences [1517] the creaky plank in the floor [281] an application of a spare key [1079] make room for him [43] those empty chairs where he had sat. [466] Memory believes before knowing remembers. [456]

Suddenly he stopped. [328] Before that silence he felt ashamed of what he had said. [281] He wanted to say something. [399] He took it, put it in his pocket. [285] No one attempted to help him. [1463]

The evening service was still going on in the church. [244] words and manner had power to set her hands to trembling [781] Afterwards there is a public scandal and it reflects upon me and all of us. [405] Her heart was sore and angry, and she was capable only of angry consolations. [42] At last we reached the wall of the churchyard, which we climbed over. [1332] Children were always climbing [667] yet I'm to be blamed as well. [247] for the lie never fits in right with the square truth. [1065] it was unbearable. [954]

the ground is already so sodden [1511] while the coffin was lowered [922] rattled on the lid of the coffin with a mournful sound [1386] the machine stood ready [141] an attention to the instructions already given [108] in search of motor cars [874] cars of invited guests [1401]

Original

At the reception people ate sandwiches in a room hired for three hours. The manager had already offered a discounted extension, in the tone used by staff who regret having to mention money and are not permitted to omit it. Six guests told Matthew that Gareth would have complained about the coffee. A seventh said Gareth had always loved the coffee here. Matthew laughed so hard that he had to go outside. When someone followed to ask whether he was all right, he said yes, and for five remarkable seconds the person believed him.

Carrie found him beneath an overhang. Rain struck the gutter above them. Matthew said he was frightened by how quickly the others had begun using their ordinary voices. Carrie said she was frightened he might never recover his. He told her about the quarrel over the holiday. She didn't say it was trivial. It wasn't. In the downpipe a dense packet of leaves held back water until pressure forced a narrow stream around its edge. The overflow fell beside the wall, where it loosened mortar already softened by earlier winters. They went inside when Matthew was ready, not when the rain stopped.

In the grave, panels still enclosed a volume. Water entered by some joints and not others. Soil organisms met new material under altered conditions. The body, board, lining, finish and fasteners would not change together. The shape was recognisable. That was a condition of the present, not a promise.

The coffin remained a convenient name. It had been especially convincing while four people carried it.

When the mourners had gone, Simon and another worker returned with the machine. They removed the temporary board, checked the position of the lowered box and began moving soil into the grave. The first loads struck the lid at angles different from those made by the handfuls dropped during the ceremony. Heavier impacts changed the distribution of stress at its joints. Soil settled against the sides. Small air pockets remained in places where irregular fragments held one another apart. The workers filled the excavation and tamped the surface. Simon knew it would sink later. The soil had been disturbed and no longer occupied the compact configuration established before digging. He would return with more material when the subsidence became visible. Until then the surface was even enough to close the record.

Quotation version

eating sandwiches [1519] They trooped into the reception room [1122] for a lower price [196] We must not omit to mention here [1196] As though he were saying, “I don't want any sugar in my coffee.” [1033] loved coffee [350] roared with laughter [1343] was obliged to go out [14] “Yes,” he said, and paused for perhaps five seconds. [1429] I asked whether everything was right; to which he replied yes [639]

He found himself standing beneath an overhanging marquee. [1239] rain beating with heavy drops [201] in a minute or two she spoke to us quite in her usual voice, [528] I'm frightened [1237] I fear he will never speak again. [283] Quarrelled and hinted about it. [378] What did they quarrel about? [862] these details, which are wrongly called trivial [664] It lay on the edge of the main stream. [128] Evidently, the mortar was falling away.… [638] It was still raining when they withdrew [1473]

A closed box [130] They don't lack for water, do they? [221] We do not know to what extent these organisms are distributed in the soil [279] at different rates [703] tangible and recognizable shape [1338] There was no promise. [44]

The empty coffin remains. [664] And forthwith the four deputies carried it out. [412]

For a while all those machines went dead. [1025] After the customary rites the grave-diggers lowered the coffin. [400] It jabbed with increasing savagery until he fainted and ended the ceremony. [648] It causes joints to harden if even so much as a drop remains on it long. [523] settled against [602] Some were in small fragments, the others merely torn in half. [1472] Excavation of valleys. [91] where the filled excavation is still visible. [870] I knew it would be so; [376] This will be the soil in which digging is impracticable. [443] compact soil, such as that of a path [446] He wouldn't return. [1360] was recorded over the entire surface of the globe. [1384]

Original

Rain entered the upper layer first. Water travelled along some paths and not others, reached the box through gaps, and remained outside where finishes delayed penetration. The veneer, composite board, adhesives, lining and metal responded differently. At one joint repeated swelling and drying widened a small separation. In a damp region, microbial growth found nutrients in accessible parts of the board. Elsewhere coatings and conditions restricted activity. The burial did not initiate decay as a single event; it brought together conditions under which numerous processes could occur, stop, begin again or take other routes. There was no advantage in describing them as the coffin's decline. Several materials had already been changing for decades. Others would be materially similar long after the shape was lost.

Inside the body, microorganisms that had existed alongside Gareth during his life encountered tissues altered by the end of circulation and the effects of cooling, preparation and burial. Different local conditions produced different forms of activity. Some organisms consumed proteins and carbohydrates; others used compounds left by those processes. Enzymes broke down cellular structures. Gases accumulated in spaces that had not previously held them in the same quantities. Liquids changed the distribution of soluble substances. There was a sequence of transformations, but not a uniform schedule. What happened in one tissue depended upon moisture, temperature, chemistry, accessibility and the organisms present. The body remained material, though it was no longer maintained in the organisation through which Gareth had lived, spoken, insulted people and held Matthew's hand.

The metal handles could not hold any of this together in the manner implied by their appearance. They were attached to panels whose mechanical properties changed when wet. Corrosion began at small defects in protective surfaces and advanced according to the surrounding chemistry. Some screws remained secure while material around their threads lost strength; others themselves changed before the panel did. A handle could remain intact after it no longer attached anything to anything. It would then be metal of a particular composition in a place with its own water and organisms, rather than part of a useful object. The company that had manufactured it would have completed its annual accounts many times over.

Quotation version

It began to rain, hard. [471] We only know that the box is somewhere on the water, moving along. [1332] The upper parts of the walls were lined with a thick padding of leather [1400] When dry, clean up the joints. [1038] afterwards separating at the joints. [288] perhaps because of the dampness and fungous growths in the cellar [892] too much surface moisture. [1489] much that is overlaid with layer after layer of fleshly covering. [1355] Then begins the burial, according to the usual method. [443] the two processes occur side by side [1465] And then, that there was another: the empty coffin. [664] He had changed as they had changed. [1019] Could they also mimic human shape temporarily? [52] all kinds of similar materials [706]

The body was quite cold. [31] entirely familiar with local conditions [249] such as the carbohydrates and proteins [1364] Some of the compounds produced by such processes are poisonous, others are harmless. [279] although the enzyme itself is not destroyed [1364] by accumulating a large quantity of vapor [1400] the accumulation of gases. [1178] Do these substances yield certain soluble elements to water? [442] Then he had lost the schedule. [853] Transformations have passed, transformations are on the way. [441] It’s not on a schedule. [1013] depending upon the temperature under which the tissue is ripening [1364] dead matter that did not move. [876]

This time they held a metal-pointed pen. [694] the handles were coupled together [1018] Why didn't these galley panels go out for drop hammer? [236] for their surfaces were pitted through unequal corrosion [335] Any longer thread would only weaken the screw where it most needs strength [1038] It shows no mark of having been attached to a handle. [483] But that does not necessarily mean that they are composed of any metal that we know. [977] although they had had company from time to time [12] represented in the annual accounts. [238]

Original

Through one winter the soil above Gareth's burial held water longer than the adjacent path. The ground had been replaced in layers unlike those formed by years of roots, rain and settlement. Some pores connected; others ended abruptly against compacted clay. Water carrying dissolved substances entered a gap between the facing and the manufactured core of a coffin panel. The facing lifted slightly, dried, and drew down again. The movement was small enough to leave the surface apparently continuous to any camera lowered into the grave. There was no camera. The upper soil was marked by grass and a stone whose lettering would be renewed before the structure below lost its general shape.

Within a sheltered region of the board, microorganisms consumed compounds accessible to them and left others untouched. A fungal filament entered a softened fibre. Several bacteria colonised the surfaces altered by its enzymes. A minute animal grazed on the bacterial film, changing its distribution. Its waste supplied material used by other organisms. The fungus was itself invaded by a microscopic parasite in a nearby region. Some cells lost their integrity while neighbouring threads continued growing. No population had arranged the sequence. The organisms made use of one another where their structures and the surrounding conditions allowed, and much of what could have developed never did. Too little water, too much water, unsuitable temperature, an unexpected competitor: any could end a lineage whose ancestors had survived far worse conditions elsewhere.

A strand of synthetic lining had become caught between the board and a fastening. It retained its colour after much of the adjacent material had darkened. Its polymers resisted biological processes that rapidly changed neighbouring fibres. Pressure and local chemistry altered its surface, and movement sometimes pulled it across an abrasive particle. A few short fragments separated. One became trapped in a film of moisture near an earthworm tunnel. An earthworm ingested soil containing other fragments of plastic, mineral grains and decaying organic matter. Some passed through its gut. Others remained in the tunnel wall when it moved. The fragments' material identities had become far less useful to a sorting machine than they had been when purchased as a roll of fabric. They were too dispersed to be collected even by a society willing to pay for collecting them.

Quotation version

in winter upon the soil [1307] Sometimes they covered the ground in layers, several leaves one on the other. [711] a layer of turf, formed by the matted roots of the grasses [335] After the sand appeared some compact white clay [1400] protruded through the gap. Some sharp substance [1386] She drew herself up scornfully. [1308] was lowered into the damp grave. [1402] And the camera? [240] Ground appeared, dark soil and grass. [374] The soil, although covered with grass [744]

are draining from the soil the nitrogen compounds and throwing them away. [279] with all its intricacies of fibres [1255] Here the bacteria of the soil come into play in several directions. [279] In five minutes the animal had expired without uttering a sound. [487] Is it not rather one of those waste substances which the organism engenders while at work [444] It was that fungus. [1461] and thus we see parasites on parasites, and on these parasites again. [747] My cells may be the same, but they're conditioned differently. [1506] There was no logic of sequence. [875] for fear lest the freshly developed organism may [1] There must therefore be an intrinsic connection between the conditions and the structural adaptations of the organism [1369] and apparently had never developed. [1242] Too many complications. [937]

More accurate, perhaps, to say that he had a copper lining. [1061] through a crack between two boards [205] retained much freshness of colour. [906] resisting the slow processes of decay [1061] The moment they stepped across the bubbling spring, the atmosphere altered. [863] the movement was small. [337] Only a few short fragments exist [572] She usually takes for her dwelling the tunnel of some Earthworm opening off a claybank. [447] dig the earth, eat the nutritious soil, and then excrete it. [224] Through them we must have passed [977] Around the circular walls were innumerable tunnel entrances. [432] It was one of those complicated fabrics that have since been called handling-machines [1465] Nobody knows exactly where they were collected. [10] they are too tiny and too bothersome to collect. [442]

Original

The earthworm was exposed when a mole enlarged a passage nearby. The mole seized it, turned and disappeared into a different part of the soil. Its activity mixed particles from layers that had previously been separated. In one season its tunnels altered drainage through a patch of grass above an older grave. A visitor complained that the soil was uneven and that the animals were disrespectful. The cemetery manager explained that moles were protected by the site's wildlife policy and that licensed control might be possible if damage became substantial. The visitor was offended by the implication that damage to her mother's grave was not already substantial. The manager agreed to monitor the situation. Two weeks later a mole was found dead on the path, probably taken from below and abandoned by a predator. The manager told the visitor that the matter appeared to have resolved itself. Another mole entered the vacant tunnel system before the next summer.

At a different depth, a root tip entered a region enriched by some of the products of decomposition. Cells divided near the growing tip; older tissues differentiated and altered how water and solutes moved between soil and plant. A fungal association at one section of the root affected nutrient exchange. Some compounds entered plant tissues; others were immobilised or transformed in soil. Nearby, another root died when prolonged saturation excluded enough oxygen from its surroundings. The plant developed less growth on that side the following year. It was a young tree planted by a volunteer group, and the volunteer responsible was pleased by its overall survival. She had carried water for it during the summer. She did not see the dead root, and no one needed her to see it in order for her work to matter.

In the deeper, wetter soil, gas moved through connected spaces where it could, accumulated where it could not, and dissolved in water when local conditions permitted. Some microbial communities favoured conditions with little oxygen and drew energy from reactions unavailable to organisms higher in the ground. Their by-products entered further chemical processes. A portion moved into the atmosphere through pathways altered by the grave's fill. The quantities varied with weather, substrate and temperature. They could not be assigned to the coffin alone. A rainfall event compressed several small gas spaces and displaced water into a neighbouring seam. A colony of tiny soil animals lost a dry pocket and became inactive in the saturated one. Their numbers recovered in a different section the next spring, not from the same individuals.

Quotation version

he scraped and scratched and scrabbled and scrooged [560] the mole had dug a long passage under the earth [1049] The mole was draining the soil and purging it of its vermin. [442] separated into thin papery layers. [77] The patch of broken, rich, brown soil observable not far away [863] The visitor felt only a compulsion which said, “You must!” [1499] The soil is uneven and rugged [445] they were protected [638] protected, as far as possible [1438] Poor mother! you very soon tormented her into her grave. [676] The manager went on: [1541] With one blow the mole was dead. [791] Absent-mindedly the visitor passed through the silent dereliction. [491] that the matter be resolved. [687] The mouth of a tunnel opened in the mass. [539]

larger at the tip than at the root [202] products of the decomposition of preceding plant growths. [1364] the water itself goes into the plant tissues [1336] The cells keep on dividing rapidly [1393] Water is taken into the plant chiefly from the soil [1364] the soil bacteria assist it to seize the nitrogen from the air. [279] within the tissues of living plants [288] Roots of the eucalyptus will prolong themselves incredibly in search of moisture. [110] Year after year the leaves would wither and fall and decay. [1288] Everybody on this project is a volunteer. [1226] all young trees which are being planted [1489] pleased and astonished to learn that they survived. [691] may be carried into well water. [1307] she carried all the water [567] He saw, when he reached the first one, that it was dead. [550] he chanced to see a bit of root [1236]

It is a world of water and more or less dense gas. [465] being easily dissolved in water [80] It requires special conditions and possibly special kinds of fermenting organisms. [279] an abundance of microbial life [485] V. By-products of Industry [489] In one place part of the stonework of the graves stretches out over the sandy pathway far below. [1332] What variety we have had, at least in temperature. [1400] We were not alone in the deathroom. [651] As the water enters, the contained air above its surface is compressed into smaller and smaller space. [739] Even the source of colonies was dried up [1256] Next morning the same party reassembled in Number 12. [700]

Original

Matthew visited on a bright afternoon and found the grass had been cut too closely around Gareth's name. He knelt and brushed loose clippings from the stone. It was not a moral victory. It was something he could do with his hands while speaking aloud about the afternoon he had spent in a supermarket, unable to remember what he intended to buy. He told Gareth he was an idiot and then said he missed him. He sat for fifteen minutes. Below him a pore opened when a grain of clay moved into a slightly different position. It did not matter to the conversation. Both events occurred. Matthew stood and went to meet Grace for lunch, which would be uncomfortable at first and unexpectedly pleasant by the time they ordered pudding.

In another part of the ground, older remains occupied spaces for which no records survived. A corroded piece of metal pressed against a root. A length of fabric was still discernible between soils of different colour. A fragment of bone with mineral structure remaining had become one hard surface among other hard surfaces. An insect entered a cavity and remained there until colder temperatures slowed its movements. The living organisms in the surrounding ground had no common history of bereavement. Some of the human names once attached to the buried materials had been forgotten by every person still alive. A contractor would later open the site with a machine to improve drainage. The contractor's plans showed no names in that particular strip. The machine's teeth passed through it nonetheless.

Quotation version

But he had strolled about the town for too long. [773] and the grass had been cut for some distance around. [693] She knelt down by the stone, and tried to read the inscription. [274] No; it is only the moral victory I care for. [675] He remembered that something had gone wrong. [269] He missed it only by a few minutes. [705] You idiot [1100] he sat silent. [993] according to the clay of his nature and the pressure of his surroundings [872] That is not a conversation. [286] And then the event happened. [844] They dined together, and the dinner was unexpectedly pleasant to both of them. [1008] stood up from the lunch table. [1480] At first, it must be admitted, he felt uncomfortable--distinctly uncomfortable. [133]

The papers pertaining to those no longer alive [1204] of which no record remains [758] steeled himself against the pain and pressed a communication filament against the metal. [152] Growth of the soil was something different [587] of a different colour from the surrounding soil [77] His face was hard as bone, but his voice trembled. [449] the hard structure of bone and shell [288] the insect’s movements are free [446] It grew colder and colder and colder [1009] They were feeding, and had no thought of doing anything else. [1383] no one can even recall [1045] We saw in many places attempts made to improve the soil. [678] No joints showed in the smooth surface. [555] Into the mouthpiece of the machine I spoke, asking, [1344]

VIII. The Fourth Wedding: Continuation

Original

By the following summer Charles had proposed to Henrietta. He had done so after a weekend in which they agreed about dinner, enjoyed the weather and spoke to nobody who knew Carrie. Henrietta had known him long enough to recognise that he was affectionate, evasive, capable in a crisis affecting somebody else and extraordinarily skilled at making the failure to decide look like sensitivity. She accepted because the question had been asked without a joke. Afterwards she worried that this was an insufficient reason; it was also the only reason she had ever trusted entirely.

Henrietta wanted a settled part of her life. She had kept a business solvent, helped her brother through a divorce, and spent years following up on things her father had promised to arrange. Charles had the relaxed aspect of a man whose indecision was generally financed by other people doing the deciding. She saw this clearly. She also knew his gentleness when nobody was performing for an audience. He once drove three hours to sit with her after her dog died and hadn't told a single joke. She could not make these facts cancel one another. She had said yes.

They planned the wedding quickly. Her friends doubted Charles's commitment. Henrietta defended him until she could no longer distinguish loyalty from presenting evidence in a case she expected to lose. His friends congratulated him with the careful delight of people invited to a financial product they didn't understand. Matthew said little. He had moved to a smaller flat and was unable to decide whether to keep a lamp he and Gareth had both disliked. June, meanwhile, had been informed that the church roof repairs would take place after the wedding season. Rain was not expected to respect the programme.

The wedding was booked at Angus and Laura's church. The door was sticking again. The carpenter explained that the building was moving as well as the wood. June asked whether buildings were permitted to do that. The carpenter said most did, and some charged for it. The committee agreed to commission a report. The report would cost more than another repair and lead to a decision at the next quarterly meeting.

Quotation version

proposed marriage to her [110] They did not want to speak, feeling closer together in silence. [791] all was agreed, and when the dinner had been removed [23] For a while, nobody spoke. [1096] It is impossible to persuade a man who does not disagree, but smiles. [1312] somebody capable of fast, decisive action [1214] she believed she should accept him [42] It didn’t make any sense. [735] He had a reason for going away, though it was an insufficient one. [378]

She wanted to preserve herself. [792] A few years later, her father died. [1220] On other people’s money. [799] The man made a little gesture expressive of indecision. [114] She saw the whole affair clearly. [93] Nobody knew how she longed to see the girl. [488] Clearly, because he had just seen her driving away from her home. [1501] She says they are facts which would interest the whole world. [326] Everything in the world began with a yes. [868]

The wedding was hurried on. [398] as if doubting his sincerity. [788] But he need not have defended her to me. [1345] influential friends [356] he received the congratulations of his friends [1142] “He hath spoken,” they replied, “though but little.” [85] a smaller flat [409] He was still unable to decide. [852] to have the roof repaired “as per agreement” [1460] They watched, and as they expected, nothing happened. [1300]

What—the wedding? [593] And I say—remember you're booked for the wedding. [812] This door sticks so! [380] The carpenter fully explained his case. [25] public buildings and others where means will permit [739] There is another which is the work of the carpenter? [1103] The Committee on Resolutions was reporting. [853] thus bearing half the cost of repairing it. [1386] and to report the result at the next meeting. [357]

Original

On the wedding morning June forced open the church door. Only a narrow length of blue ribbon remained visible under the drain cover. The drain had stopped flooding because water had found another route through the debris. June took this as a success by the church's standards.

Several years of roof repairs had left the church with a system of temporary gutters, each intended to divert water until the next piece of work could be funded. At the north wall, rainwater ran through plastic tubing fixed to a bracket that had been screwed into deteriorating mortar. The tube had been shortened to clear a new noticeboard. When the wind drove rain along the wall, water reached the opening above the bracket and entered the masonry. The wall's outer surface dried on sunny days, leaving the interior damp. A caretaker's report described the wall as free from visible defects. The report had been signed in June, when there had been no rain for eighteen days.

Within the masonry, alternating wetting and drying dissolved and deposited salts in narrow spaces. Crystals grew where water evaporated, exerting pressure against already weakened material. A flake of plaster detached behind a storage cupboard. The cupboard was filled with hymnbooks, cleaning equipment, two Christmas decorations with missing electrical adapters and a cardboard box of printed brochures for last year's heritage open day. The flake fell among the brochures. A silverfish fed on adhesive in the paper bindings, moving through material held together for a purpose nobody was presently fulfilling. The silverfish was eaten by a spider in the cupboard's dark upper corner. A maintenance contractor would soon treat the whole cupboard with insecticide after a volunteer described the insects as vermin. He would not be employed to fix the gutter.

June was offered a small sum to manage the fourth wedding's floral arrangements. She declined. She had been doing the same job without pay for years, and felt that accepting the money would require her to do it properly. Instead she volunteered to supervise the opening of the church and found herself moving chairs for two hours. When the caterer asked where the waste containers were, June led him around the building and pointed to three bins, none of which had been emptied since the previous event. He asked whether the recycling was separated. June said the bins were separated by colour. He looked inside and discovered this was not the same thing.

Quotation version

Then the great doors of the church opened. [64] A narrow ribbon of sky was visible overhead. [965] a long narrow blue ribbon [601] Few stopped and came aside from that flood. [1465] They took it for a success. [664] The church was their society and their standard [854]

Years of rain water dripping through holes in the roof did much more damage. [1485] There was a plumber working outside repairing the guttering that ran round the bottom edge of the roof. [1386] to diverting the course of the water [98] fragments of old mortar and plaster. [1386] So the days passed, and no tubes were available. [1299] rain dripping from slopes and serifs of an unreadable legend on the lintel [1128] The wind drove down the rain [619] It’s the dampness drying [12] I have wondered for a long time what was behind that wall. [475] “It was the 24th of June, just eighteen months ago,” he said. [100] There was no rain to-day. [1327]

Such dry substances are long in dissolving and decomposing [716] the deposition of mineral salts [1393] The life of the earth consists in the formation of crystals. [1048] Some kind of plaster. [372] softly detached a bit of plaster from the wall [664] Her drawing cardboard and her embroidery she left in the cupboard. [466] cupboards and book-shelves [229] a very few flakes were falling at present [41] devouring the paste and glaze from wallpapers and the binding and leaves of books. [985] All my food was in a cupboard in the corner of the room. [1462] when treating of the Insect Notables of these parts [661] plagues of insects and vermin. [1041] But--perhaps that was it, there seemed to be no gutter about her. [1234]

Oh, I'll get my hand down for the wedding all right. [185] This, however, she declined [1177] “And did you expect to get any pay, with or without interest?” she added. [1067] doing her job as always. [519] I said and pulled out a chair for her. [958] She moved the chairs about [664] The booths stood neglected, the stalls unvisited, the little cafés desolate. [129] clear glass versus colored glass. [351] tin versus aluminum. [351] there are colors that we can not see. [113] He saw that he was discovered and lost at one and the same time. [670]

Original

At the back of the churchyard a plant had grown through a split in a paving slab. Its roots entered a gap containing fine soil, fallen hair, bird droppings and mineral particles washed from the stone. Under the leaves an aphid population enlarged and then contracted as predators and weather altered its conditions. A parasitic wasp placed eggs inside several aphids. The developing wasps consumed the hosts' tissues, leaving hardened bodies from which the adult insects later emerged through round holes. These tiny perforations were neither malicious nor beautiful. They were effective routes out of material that had once belonged to something else. The plant continued to draw water and carbon into new tissue while insects fed upon it.

The wedding planner had ordered the slab cleaned before the photographs. The contractor sprayed the paving with a solution that killed visible growth on its surface. Water carried part of the solution into the gap. The aphids and wasps had different sensitivities to the changed conditions. Most were lost. The plant's leaves remained green for several days and then began to yellow. The slab looked new. A relative remarked that the church had obviously been well cared for. June, who had not ordered the spray, gave the relative the telephone number of the maintenance firm. The relative said he wasn't complaining. June said that was a shame because she had several complaints ready to pass on.

At Charles's house Scarlett tried to tie his neckwear and caught her own hand in it. The wardrobe doors opened unevenly. A screw fell from the lower hinge. Charles picked it up and placed it in his pocket, where it made a slight bulge beside the ring.

'You're not putting that back?' Scarlett asked.

'After the wedding.'

'You'll be dead.'

'After that, then.'

She laughed despite herself. Charles looked ill. Whether this represented a moral improvement was impossible to say.

Quotation version

Looking away from the weed-grown churchyard [661] Perhaps some mineral element from the stone had entered the soil, but it would soon be washed away. [895] Under the altered conditions of population [1399] Many bees are parasitic, and always lay their eggs in the nests of bees of other kinds. [334] Epidemic among insects. wasps in Great Britain. [91] enables the adult insect to emerge through the outlet [444] wasn't beautiful exactly. [880] But when the country was established they usually packed up and went somewhere else. [722] Plants, was it? [1117]

were cleaned and put in order [1172] All surfaces were then washed with a dilute solution of salt [1286] A solution was then made of one part to 5250 of water [337] Nor were the dogs long in adapting themselves to the changed conditions. [874] The latter lost. [28] turning yellow [167] this plant remained green and fresh. [710] taking in the strange slab flush with the ground [1082] It was a beautiful church, and there was a large and friendly congregation. [996] It was they who recommended your firm as a likely distributor. [926] On some of them was a telephone number. [1087] Shall I not then complain? [1256] She is not well, she has had a nervous complaint on her for several weeks. [45]

his necktie [1491] The door opened. [237] had fallen from its hinges [248] put it in his pocket. [1330]

Put it back? [704] “What was that?” she asked [396]

“Why, I danced at his wedding.” [743]

You're going to die. [384]

“Oh, that,” I said. [927]

she laughed in spite of herself. [994] He looked ill. [285] it was impossible to say. [592] morally speaking. [1118]

Original

Carrie arrived at the church alone. She and Hamish had separated during the winter, with so few spectacular arguments that their friends had been unable to take sides efficiently. There had been jobs in different cities, his parents, her work, shared bills and the fatigue of being asked whether they were happy. Both had said yes until the word lost its informational value. The separation brought relief and grief, alternating without a schedule. Hamish was more generous than she had wanted to remember and less attentive than she'd needed. She was not proud of everything she had done either.

She hadn't told Charles. She disliked the idea of becoming news that would require him to perform a decision. In the small room behind the church she found him looking for a cufflink. He could not locate one of the pair. A spare was offered by a cousin, but its metal was a different colour. Charles was holding it against his sleeve as if a sufficiently good explanation would make the discrepancy disappear.

'I thought you were supposed to have someone to do that,' she said.

'There were several volunteers. I offended them.'

She told him about Hamish. Charles sat down. It would have been easy to make his expression into a promise, but Carrie knew him better than that.

'I haven't come to ask anything of you,' she said.

'You haven't had to.'

'That's not a compliment.'

'No. I know.'

They stood in silence. An organist tested the music; sound travelled through valves, pipes, plaster and the small vestry wall.

'Why did you ask Henrietta?' Carrie said.

'Because I love her.'

'And?'

Quotation version

Carrie came in alone. [409] His acquaintances and sycophants were many, but his friends very few. [1053] The city was happy. [967] You once asked me whether I was happy here. [926] Now words were lost in the midst of confusion. [1341] finding relief. [132] sadness because so much is after all so little. [848] after the customary careless, generous fashion. [1483] She was ashamed of herself [1408]

she had not told him. [507] He did not like the idea of his daughter getting married. [394] a pair of cuff links [622] in the small prayer-meeting room behind the chapel auditorium [856] in search of something that he could not find. [12] One was a spare. [838] owing to the generous offer of his elderly cousin [700] it had a very different colour. [594] he strove to explain his every action with painstaking conscientiousness [1351]

I guess she thought so herself, for she braced herself. [346]

You were all volunteers! [1025] I have offended them [42]

And then she told him all about herself. [1009] He sat down. [1389] could see right through it. [1351]

I ask nothing of you [382]

you had no need to [1422]

It isn't exactly a compliment. [258]

No, of course not. [547] I know that. [1525]

They stood together in a silence almost curiously protracted. [1052] The organist was coming from behind his pipes [239] coming through the pipes. [1039]

Why do you ask? [1059] said Carrie. [409]

I love her. [94]

And so forth. [92]

Original

'Because I thought if I did something definite, I might become the kind of person who could do it.'

'Perhaps you are.'

'I don't think this is the proof.'

Carrie looked away. 'Then you need to tell her. Whatever happens between us is not the thing you need to decide today.'

Charles agreed. He had never found it so hard to agree with someone who was right.

Henrietta heard the difficulty before Charles described it. He had come into the room carefully, as though whatever was wrong might be frightened by a sudden movement. She asked whether Carrie was involved. He said yes, and began an explanation full of reasonable things said too late. She stopped him. The dress was tight across her waist when she sat, so she stood. On the floor a pin released during the final fitting lay near the hem. The white fabric hid it from view. She moved her foot and heard the metal touch the sole of her shoe.

'You should have told me before today,' she said.

'Yes.'

'Before the invitations. Before my mother flew here. Before I sold the car because we thought we could share one.'

He hadn't known about the car. The fact visibly distressed him, and she disliked him for grasping a loss he could put a price on.

'I wanted it to work,' he said.

'So did I. I worked quite hard at wanting it. It's embarrassing, the amount of work I put into your feelings.'

She took off an earring and placed it on the windowsill, then removed the other. They struck the stone with a small, precise sound. She looked at Charles with an expression he'd remember longer than any photograph.

Quotation version

"I just wondered why you'd speak to me," she said. [417] it had been shaping itself to something more definite than thought. [1008]

perhaps I am--perhaps not [807]

that proves nothing. [639]

looking away from him. [1229] You had better tell her. [793] Let us go our own pace. Give us time. [1191]

Charles agreed. [626] Of course, he was absolutely right [1100]

She knew what was coming. [1356] I can move very quietly when I want to [1191] is it another woman? [486] But he spoke too late. [146] It was too late for explanations. [1175] she stopped him. [845] She stood up. [824] her tight-waisted dress [1473] Pin sticks, but it won't without a load on it. [679] in the folds of her dress. [1472] She was pushing her feet--very small feet they were--into heelless shoes. [1452]

For him not to have told me was absurd. [848]

"Yes," he answered. [342]

When shall you send your invitations? [414] Then mother came east to live here with me. [72] sold the car [732]

he had not known [594] visibly distressed [1464]

I wanted to be happy [1475]

I wanted the same thing. [1253] I can work hard. [593] supporting such an edifice [848] It always represents such an amount of work [1183]

took off the ear-rings. [791] a metallic click [1042] he would never forget [1475] her face [1472]

Original

'I don't want you to rescue me from this,' she said. 'You've been very brave about everyone's unhappiness except the unhappiness you're causing.'

He tried to apologise. She told him not to waste another sentence improving the account of himself. Her sister appeared and asked whether anything was wrong. Henrietta said there would be no wedding. The sister asked whether she was sure. Henrietta laughed once, savagely: her first feeling of certainty in months was about the one thing that could no longer be cancelled without a charge.

The announcement was made. Guests remained seated, as if another announcement might overturn it. A child asked whether there would still be cake. A relative demanded to know who was paying for the flowers. Henrietta's father said Charles had behaved disgracefully, though three guests knew enough about him not to grant him the satisfaction of moral authority. The photographer asked whether the cancelled ceremony counted as an additional hour's coverage. He was not making a joke. Nobody answered. He took photographs of the empty aisle until someone told him to stop.

Matthew sat beside Fiona and watched Henrietta leave through a side door. He did not regard this as an encouraging outcome for the institution. Fiona asked whether he wanted to go. He said he'd stay a little. Tom was speaking to the caterer about the uneaten food. The caterer explained that disposal was included in the package but redistribution was not. Tom asked what that meant. It meant that giving the food away would cost extra. He paid, because he wanted it to stop being a conversation.

Some chilled trays went back to the supplier with their seals intact. The manager offered leftovers to staff, who had been told not to eat in uniform and no longer had a break room. What went unclaimed ended up in industrial bins.

At the venue, an exhausted cleaner rinsed the floor where champagne had spilled. The cleaning machine worked, though one wheel was worn flat enough to leave a narrow stripe of dirty water at every turn. The cleaner adjusted her route so the stripe fell against a wall. Her manager inspected the room in the morning, found no stains and sent a message praising the team for returning the premises to operational readiness. The cleaner had a photograph of her son asleep beside a dog. On the way home she enlarged it on her telephone and stopped thinking about weddings for six bus stops.

Quotation version

I don't need your help. [410] I have to live and be happy and to refrain from causing unhappiness in other people. [92]

he came over and apologised for his bad conduct [1332] Now don’t make any more excuses, but listen! [230] Is there anything wrong? [149] I will not marry him. [671] Are you sure? [624] She laughed, but she was rather angry too. [398]

the announcement was made [971] They remained seated [136] the children [301] the wedding cake had not been cut [1118] The flowers alone cost [622] Who will pay it? [206] Her father was gradually gathering in anger against him, her mother was hardening in anger against her. [792] behaved disgracefully to his fiancée. [1417] What about the price? [587] Each long hour was counted [1256] He was not joking [466] There was no answer. [70] took photographs of [1403] the empty aisle. [260]

he watched her go. [789] not very encouraging. [45] Do you want to go? [462] I will stay a little longer. [243] There’s always some one who can use it. [1118] the yards of uneaten food [479] He put the four boxes carefully in the waste-disposal unit. [835] “What?” asked Tom [1482] give my food away [316] they pay extra [478] And if it was his fault he has paid for it. [1447]

with the seals unbroken. [664] carrying the trays back [693] The hospitality stopped within the limits of good order. [1224] out of leftovers [1253] thrown out wasted. [1118]

There was smoking and champagne. [1474] he spilled on the floor [791] The cleaning machines had served their purpose. [1305] keeping close to the wall [1539] The leader inspected the room [799] the infant was asleep beside its mother [1188] The dog, who had until then seemed to be asleep [1194] looked at the photograph. [1350]

Original

The decorations came down early. Ribbons were cut from pews; champagne was returned to storage where possible. A full glass beside sugared almonds reached room temperature. The venue charged a cleaning supplement because the guests hadn't eaten enough to meet its minimum spend. Nobody drank the glass. Its contents went down a drain.

Henrietta's sister took her home by a route which avoided the hotel where the reception was supposed to happen. Henrietta noticed the deviation and asked whether she was being protected from the building. Her sister said she thought it might help. Henrietta asked her to turn back, then changed her mind before they reached the roundabout. Later she would remember this brief exchange with more embarrassment than the guests' faces. She had been incapable of deciding which road to go down, after spending two months defending a man whose principal difficulty was decision.

The dress contained several kinds of fibre and hundreds of small fixings whose combined weight Henrietta had accepted because a photograph made the structure appear effortless. Its seam had already been let out twice. In the kitchen she cut the fastenings rather than ask for help removing it. A line of buttons fell against the tiles and scattered beneath the refrigerator, into a narrow gap beside the skirting and behind a plant whose owner watered it too heavily. The dress loosened and slipped. She stood in her underwear, holding the stiff white material in front of her, and found herself smiling at the amount of engineering invested in something intended to be worn once. Then she sat on the floor and cried. The crying lasted long enough for her sister to knock twice and finally leave a glass of water outside the door.

Under the refrigerator, one button lay among skin flakes, dust and the shed exoskeletons of small insects. Moisture from a leak had gathered there over several months. A tiny population of springtails fed on fungi in the damp debris. Their bodies propelled themselves away from disturbances by releasing a forked structure beneath the abdomen. A loose button moved when the compressor started and compressed the soil-like film in which the animals lived. Some escaped. One was trapped beneath its edge. Henrietta had not dropped the button in order to kill anything. The springtail did not die because her marriage had failed. The events happened in the same room and were connected by the fall of a small round object. That was enough for the living animal.

Quotation version

marriage decorations were taken down [395] So they got the ribbons for which they had bargained, and wanted to take her home with them. [34] a full glass [726] was at room temperature [1363] almonds and sugar [22] “What,” cried all the guests, “you have not eaten for four-and-twenty hours?” [414] I hadn’t enough to eat [1067] wine was untouched. [633] poured it down the sink. [975]

taken us back by another road [376] Henrietta asked [44] One building in particular they noticed. [433] because I hoped it might help [1338] Would you be annoyed if I suggested turning back? [1015] changed her mind [759] I remember everything that happened [1191] how silly she had been. [1118] A numbness had crept over his will till it had become almost incapable of decision. [129] incapable of deciding for herself, she [1134] The principal difficulty was that [1291]

the wedding dress [231] You could gaze at this perfect picture all day [1044] letting out seams [1341] cut the buttons off [588] He said: “I live under falling tiles.” [664] I flopped into a narrow gap. [539] The dress then slipped right off. [1441] She stood up, smiling [20] in her underwear [1215] I sat on the floor and cried. [959] she went on crying [254] knock at the door twice [1539] brought a glass of water [1141]

The same thing occurs among insects. [1369] the skin dries and comes off in little flakes. [444] A leak already--just from the pressure! [76] moisture was gathering on them. [37] under which nothing but fetid fungi and rotting vegetable debris is to be seen. [77] their long necks projecting stiffly from their bodies. [1263] there let the animal loose [1355] The compressor moaned [602] Only one escaped. [319] I was in the dark—trapped. [1464] But nobody seemed disposed to rouse himself in order to kill the moth. [1520] Oh, then, all hope was not over--perhaps she might still live, and not die. [527] But several days later, more of these objects fell in the same place. [483] necessarily connected with the events [192] That is enough; the animal is caught. [440]

Original

Her sister came back with tea. Henrietta said she would have to apologise to everyone. Her sister said she would have to do nothing of the kind. They quarrelled about whether the guests had been inconvenienced, which was easier than discussing humiliation. Her mother telephoned and spoke at length about how brave Henrietta was being. Henrietta had not yet done anything that could properly be called brave. She had remained upright while a wedding was cancelled in public, and then had been taken home. Her mother suggested a trip to Italy. Henrietta asked whether the country had offered to adopt her. Her mother laughed and then began crying herself. They ended the call without agreeing who had helped whom.

Later that evening she realised she had left her earrings in the vestry. Her sister suggested telephoning the church. Henrietta said there was no need to call about two earrings. Ten minutes later she asked her sister whether she would mind doing it.

The catering company presented a final invoice two weeks later. A line item charged for a staff meal. Henrietta asked who had eaten it. The company explained that a staff meal was included whether consumed or not, because the staff had been available. She said in that case she wished to be charged for all the meals she had not eaten, and perhaps for the marriage she had not had. The accounts clerk said she understood the emotional circumstances but couldn't authorise a change. Henrietta asked for the manager's details. The clerk asked whether she wished to lodge a complaint. Henrietta said she was beginning to develop an interest in the entire concept. The manager waived the staff meal and sent flowers. They arrived on the morning Henrietta had to return to work and were left on the doorstep in the sun. When she found them they had already begun to brown at the edges. She put them in a vase and hated herself for doing so.

Quotation version

she came to her sister again [45] I must apologise [1464] apologising, if one can apologise for such a thing [844] Of course I strongly advised her to do nothing of the kind. [900] One guest, however, distinctly annoyed him. [1212] What could they have quarrelled about? [1144] “You are a brave child,” answered her mother. [814] when, at length, she spoke [490] But she hadn't done anything of the kind. [1209] Was it that she had taken off her wedding ring? [1522] she had remained upright [1538] go home. [1388] No, Mother; no. She was really keen on Italy. [481] she offered to adopt the child [481] She began to laugh then quite suddenly to cry. [1157] They didn't know what THE CALL was, nor what happened when they got it. [1428]

she felt faint as it drew towards evening. [804] which she had left in vestry in the morning. [227] Perhaps to the brother of her sister's husband. [693] But there was no need to use it. [1121] It was five minutes to ten; what on earth was she doing? [579]

I have sometimes neglected my catering-duties for weeks at a time [440] they charged the encircling lines [873] to pay his meal-check. [770] who had eaten [79] The meal was simple, automatically served, well prepared. [979] Perhaps that was why she had sent the children away. [665] had not eaten from it for many a meal now. [981] but they could not alter it. [252] Demands for details. [321] asked for the manager. [749] “That’s what I asked,” replied a clerk. [1171] you must lodge a complaint. [1355] It was the first part of her sentence that interested me. [1290] The manager fumbled with his spectacles. [749] And he sent her flowers, once. [856] Noon arrived, and, as before, the sun did not appear. [1402] The following morning he returned to his work as usual. [589] Already the edges of their petals were curling and darkening. [195] And She cooked it herself and burned her hand a-doing it. [714]

Original

Months later she bought another car. She drove it to the coast, parked near an empty promenade and sat eating a packet of crisps while people passed with dogs and prams. A gull attacked a discarded sandwich at the edge of a bin, tore away part of its wrapper and swallowed a lump of bread too quickly. Another gull took the wrapper and dropped it in a puddle. Henrietta found the scene revolting and funny. She rang her sister and told her about the gulls. They talked about the new car and a terrible programme on television. Only after they finished did Henrietta realise that her sister hadn't asked about Charles. The discovery left her pleased, then suddenly bereft of the last person obliged to ask. She bought a second packet of crisps and went home before dark.

That evening Henrietta ordered an expensive meal and ate six mouthfuls. When a friend called, she described Charles accurately without making him a monster. The restraint left her feeling worse.

Charles and Carrie walked in the rain, speaking with a tired precision that had been absent from most of their earlier encounters. Carrie told him she was not a prize for having finally made a decision. He agreed so eagerly that she asked him to stop. They went to a café. Charles wanted to describe the day as the worst mistake he'd ever made; Carrie asked whether he thought Henrietta might dispute the ranking. He didn't make the remark again. They stayed until the café closed, uncertain whether they could trust the pleasure of being together when it had been paid for by someone else's humiliation.

They agreed to meet on Tuesday and discuss work, distance, money and what each expected the other to give up. Carrie wrote the day on a receipt because her telephone was flat. Charles folded it into the pocket containing the loose wardrobe screw.

They went home separately. Workmen had already begun stacking chairs in the church.

The flowers had been collected at the supplier's warehouse before dawn. Their buds had been held in cool storage to regulate opening. The first buds opened in the van. No person touched them. A thin layer of moisture moved from cut stems into wrapping and began affecting the paper beneath. A driver adjusted the refrigeration because the dashboard displayed a warning. The delivery arrived on time. That was the last part of the plan anybody could say had gone perfectly.

Quotation version

You the fella had the car stolen? [1280] She is just going out for a drive. [849] he drove us down to the coast [1120] where we sat eating [798] He had swallowed two mouthfuls of it, but had not touched the bread. [1539] a gull, like a piece of spume flung up [789] they tore their bread apart in big mouthfuls [664] dropped it into the water, [561] It was a voluptuous scene, that masquerade. [1107] “How do the gulls know about the weather?” he asked. [587] But her talk was certainly awful discouragin'. [1439] they talked about motor cars [854] she had never asked him. [1520] she recalled, she hadn't asked him about it. [1202] At last and suddenly came the discovery. [797] he was pleased with the discovery [377] She ... it was rather dark to go home now [588]

Crew members were eating their “evening” meal. [1081] he was a human being—and not a monster [281] but only felt worse. [1000]

In the silence, the fire and the rain continued to talk. [331] He walked in the rain [619] I am myself now, and was then, although this fact was not recognized. [188] She turned round upon him eagerly. [1425] and he eagerly agreed with her. [1089] I went into a café to [623] the worst mistake [1472] That is a matter of opinion. [416] His first remark was,-- [1228] He paid the check and they walked out of the cafe, holding hands. [695] stayed there until late [1467] Or someone he could trust? [179] the hour when the cafe closed. [843]

They meet again now side by side. [1359] wrote the date, [601] Then he folded the paper and put it into his pocket. [267]

The next morning, Sunday, they went home. [662] Then he told them to sit down in the chairs again. [119]

No flowers lifted up their dew-laden cups to meet the dawn [1256] The buds open very late in the spring [669] how the buds are opening [851] You had no right to let anyone touch them [1055] All were covered up in thin wrapping paper to keep them from the dust. [1332] their succulent stems wrapped in blue tissue paper. [345] Once again I didn't notice the warning signal light. [930] Late in the afternoon arrived a special delivery [462] My plans worked out perfectly--with one exception. [650]

Original

The arrangements were not returned to the florist. The hire contract specified that once an arrangement had been delivered it was considered used. The florist had argued for this clause after a previous wedding was cancelled because the bride discovered an affair with a member of the string quartet. On that occasion the venue returned the arrangements complete and asked for a refund. The florist had never been able to sell them again, although several had remained visually perfect for days. Their failure was not in their condition but in the number of ceremonies prepared to receive yesterday's flowers.

For Charles and Henrietta, white flowers had been tied with pale ribbon around blocks of floral foam. The foam held water in a structure intended to support cut stems and resist collapse while being transported. In the waste yard the arrangements were pushed into a metal container with broken glass, used napkins and plastic packaging. A worker lifted one display out and put it beside the office because his colleague said his wife liked flowers. The display stood there for two days. Its most resilient stems remained upright while others lost water and bent. At night small moths visited the remaining blooms. Some found nectar; others found no usable food. One entered the office when a light was left on and became trapped against the window. In the morning it was caught beneath a drinking glass and released outside. It returned that evening and died behind a filing cabinet. A cleaner found the body two weeks later, beside a curl of paper bearing the words CUSTOMER CARE.

In the skip, the floral foam broke under the weight of other waste. Small fragments entered damp folds of packaging. Their open surfaces darkened where they absorbed liquid; some retained the colour of the dye used in manufacture. The stems themselves began to decay. Microorganisms consumed accessible organic matter, producing heat and changing the local chemistry. Flies reached the upper layer; larvae fed in the softening tissues. As the waste settled, oxygen became scarce in deeper pockets and different organisms grew. A collection of beetle eggs laid beneath a leaf was buried by another load. Several larvae hatched but could not reach the surface. The container was emptied before any escaped. On the waste contractor's account the transaction was listed as an event clean-up. There was no specific charge for not having held the event.

Quotation version

The florist assured him that they would. [1474] He had made other arrangements. [121] If the court accepted the testimony of the four supposed lovers, the case was lost. [30] abandoned the bride on the very day of the wedding [719] to be refunded when they were returned. [1386] had been arranged for the occasion [1334] Never--never whisper again that you will sell our Garden. [1169] They remained alive for several days [337] don't ye fail to throw a few flowers [418]

was hung with ropes of flowers Yellow and white [1487] the broad white ribbons still hung in silvery folds around them. [302] a sponge swollen with water [442] on the heaps of broken glass scattered here and there in the yard. [244] He was holding out flowers--roses, red and white roses. [1522] allow me to present to you my wife! [1133] He stood there for three more days and yet nothing happened. [1309] The extremity of the stem is more or less bent downwards [336] Moths crowd the windows at night. [613] not found in sufficient quantities in their ordinary food. [1413] They had left that window open as a trap, and I had walked into it. [511] He put down his glass and opened the window. [478] The mouse disappeared behind a bank of filing cabinets. [1296] The body has been found. [702]

A faint white ridge of foam, thin, very thin, broke alongside. [285] divided it into small fragments [288] The strip of water grew broader, darker. [922] the liquid was absorbed [1337] Some of them had pretty much fallen to decay. [526] At once a chemical reaction and a living thing? [613] Decaying organic matter plays a large part in these changes. [1027] on which the flies fed eagerly [1481] The food for millions of mouths was growing, ripening, and going to waste. [874] It was a conical pile of dead leaves, in the middle of which twenty eggs were buried. [77] the first tiny moving head [634] The box is to be emptied occasionally, before the sediment overflows. [1038] My check will be a sufficient record of the transaction, I think. [167] They did so without fee or consideration of any kind [441]

Original

Henrietta's mother telephoned the venue about the flowers. The manager offered sympathy and said that contractual disposal had already occurred. She asked why the flowers could not have gone to a hospital. He explained that hospitals were reluctant to accept used arrangements because of infection-control policies. She said they hadn't been used. He drew her attention to the wording of the hire agreement. They spoke for thirteen minutes about the word *used*. When the call ended, he wrote a note that the customer had been distressed but reasonable. Henrietta's mother spent a further hour searching for photographs of the arrangements, so that her daughter might at least know what had been ordered. She found them on the event planner's website, tagged RECENT CELEBRATIONS. She asked for the images to be removed. The planner said she would make it a priority.

The empty marquee was dismantled. Beneath one footplate, several invertebrates had occupied the moist region created by the pressure of metal against soil. A cluster of woodlice moved from the suddenly exposed patch into nearby grass. One was seized by a bird. Another reached an ant nest, where it was attacked and left damaged in the open. A small spider remained under the bolt hole in the plate until the metal was stacked vertically. It fell onto a worker's sleeve and was brushed into the mud. Later, rain saturated the same patch of lawn and flooded a shallow burrow occupied by a solitary wasp's developing offspring. Several sealed cells collapsed. The adult had died weeks before; the offspring had not yet emerged. The ground would look smooth by the time the next event took place. A new marquee was ordered on the assumption that the surface had recovered.

The venue offered Charles and Henrietta a credit against a future celebration. The credit could not be transferred to anyone else, redeemed for cash or applied to food, which had been prepared by a separate company. Henrietta forwarded the email to Charles with the message, *Apparently we're entitled to try again.* He called her, which was the wrong thing to do. She let it ring while she sat in her sister's kitchen. Later she wrote that she did not want him to use the credit. He asked whether she intended to. She replied, *I would rather set fire to it, if it existed as something that could burn.* Their exchange lasted eleven messages and ended when she blocked his number. The credit expired on a date neither noticed.

Quotation version

She then asked him to inform her about flowers. [1517] Nothing to be done. [84] they have already disposed of [1124] I wonder why he was so anxious about these flowers. [1332] We discussed the best means of preventing infection [1256] They are quite new, and have not yet been used. [414] “Best to read the terms of the contract, before we sign,” he said. [788] What was the use of arguing? [1355] She tried to put a note of reasonableness into her voice. [1476] I wrote a note for him. [674] When she had seen the photographs [561] having spent the best part of an hour in her arrangements [43] This latter, as I afterwards found, was a very usual event. [1259] “It was an image?” [916] She is going to think it over and decide very soon. [994]

It was empty. [1394] Beneath its deceitful covering the soil is always moist and soft [77] to very slight pressure whilst kept moist [338] But they escaped the electrical feelers which stirred the grass and brush around them. [1503] Bird or something…. [1063] one of the birds would dart off, seize it [77] Migration of the ants from a nest attacked. [91] This ant constructs its nest [658] what but the remains of an enormous spider [700] a plate of metal which they lifted [22] He lost his grip and fell into the mud. [1451] He felt something brush his sleeve. [964] It was still raining and the streets were all flooded. [1353] The Wasp was there by chance; the soil suited her; she dug her burrow [446] My victims used scrupulously to seal up their empty cells. [440] The child died, however, and not long afterwards the mother also. [1410] Before the first had reached the ground, the last was falling. [223] As soon as all of you were on the surface, the order was given. [367]

a credit account [1402] We had no credit; we went in, called for food and ate it. [623] with a request that I would forward it [334] asking him to forward the message. [1478] Right or wrong things were with her. [1372] my sister had been seen standing at the kitchen door [380] She deposited the money to his credit in a savings account [981] What nonsense, she asked herself, was this? [1200] “I think we may get the fire to burn up again,” he added [408] His message could not be for her. [1077] There would have been no credit in that. [674]

Original

Meanwhile, the salvaged arrangement outside the venue office finally collapsed under its own weight. The worker took it home in his car and put it on the kitchen table. His wife thanked him for thinking of her, then asked why it smelled so strongly of mildew. He had no answer that did not sound cheap. She removed the flowers and kept the glass vase, which was genuinely useful. The stems went into the garden-waste bin. The vase continued to stand on the table for years, occasionally holding flowers bought for reasons unrelated to weddings. One summer it fell while being washed and broke. Its fragments were wrapped in newspaper and placed in general waste because the local recycling instructions did not accept that kind of glass. A shard remained under the sink until the next tenant moved in and cut her finger on it. The cut healed. The landlord retained the deposit for cleaning.

Quotation version

nearly collapsed [281] the weight of a collapsing body [310] She moved slowly to put the kitchen table between the man and herself. [533] the large book stinking of mould and mildew. [71] He didn't answer, and I knew there wasn't anything he could answer. [1029] She was the exquisite vase into which he had thrust the flowers of his idealism. [1534] throw this into the dustbin! [1474] There were some flowers in my vase on the table. [1353] How was it you fell from what you were? [1017] Its fragments, placed carefully against a wall, might serve again upon occasion. [1400] The razor slipped out of her fingers. [654] cut her finger [792] His wound healed [24] from this clean and pleasant-tempered landlord. [1329]

IX. What Continued

Original

After the wedding failed, the church was locked. June returned to collect abandoned clothing and found Henrietta's earrings. She put them in an envelope beside the roof-repair invoice, which had now been revised upwards. Two weeks later Henrietta collected them herself. June asked whether she was all right, then regretted it. Henrietta said she'd be all right once she could afford to stop telling people what happened. June nodded. The envelope, briefly placed on a damp windowsill, left a faint rectangle on the paper. Neither woman saw it.

Water entered a crack in the stone step. During a freeze, a fragment detached. June swept it away. The committee approved a repair after a visitor fell and threatened a claim. The replacement stone was a different colour, and children used its sharp edge to scrape mud from their shoes. At the next meeting someone suggested that insurance claims were increasing because people no longer took care. The person making the suggestion had arrived in a car with heated seats and had not seen the step.

At the drain the blue ribbon had become pale and brittle, preserving its colour only in folds sheltered from light. An autumn storm altered the flow through leaves and silt. A visible length lifted, caught against a ridge, and slipped into the channel beneath. It travelled several metres with the water before lodging in a mesh of roots and other debris. A child in the church had once asked June whether the ribbon was still there. June said she'd removed it months ago. At the time she believed she had.

Leena's daughter passed her driving test on the fourth attempt. Leena did not mention the cost until years later, during an argument about something else. The yard installed a new kiln, and an old sheltered stack was dismantled. Plants appeared in the exposed cracks between slabs. Maintenance removed most of them before a visit from prospective buyers. Several returned. The new kiln was more efficient per unit of timber processed. The company increased production, and the absolute amount of fuel consumed went up. These were two figures in different parts of the annual report.

Quotation version

seeing that the Church had been locked since two in the afternoon [1350] abandoned at last every stitch of clothing [1463] For answer she slipped the original into the envelope again. [1418] How long can they go on collecting? [518] although she was at first disposed to send her regrets. [68] There were always people about--she'd go on as if nothing had happened. [1522] She nodded. [594] There is still a sheet of paper left right under my nose [15] Then he must have seen the woman before. [913]

Stone steps to a courtyard. [1249] Water wears out a stone. [399] And the seas are frozen. [1317] In another moment it would be swept away. [128] was repaired--if it could be repaired. [1459] He claimed damages from the local committee [856] The stones are very sharp. [128] The stone was carefully replaced. [709] His shoes were covered with mud [560] You think the claims I've been filing for my people are false? [598] A few steps more, and he saw that the car was empty. [1060]

It held out no large promises of sunlight and the blue [1125] preserves its primitive colour. [288] The leaves were blown down and swept away. [1179] autumn darkened into winter, and storm followed storm [312] Under the swift feet the miles slipped past. [1146] its length was visible. [829] In its natural habitat it sends out special roots above water. [851] For the schoolhouse was also the church. [1437] A month ago. [1380] she believed she had [42]

A fourth observation point was the test's Base Camp [1005] You never know the cost. [596] It was not until later years [545] when the old yard gate was being repaired [802] it was then entirely dismantled [155] leaned in the cracks between what buildings still stood to provide cracks [122] guarded by their owners and inspected by prospective buyers. [1098] We return, I said! [143] Some sort of kiln. [1459] The cost of the fuel consumed plus wages [7] I can put in everything but the figures of the field reports. [772]

Original

The shelf above the pharmacy carried more books than its design allowed, but its brackets held. A tenant left; another painted, leaving a strip of old wall colour behind the wood. A plant stood on it, overflowed and died while its owner was away. A ring in the finish widened when the next tenant tried to remove it with cleaner.

Matthew moved somewhere with trees visible from the kitchen. He kept Gareth's scarf and the shopping list. He washed the mug eventually, then broke it while drying it, and was wrecked for an afternoon by the loss of an object he had once wanted to wash. People told him time was helping. Time had also brought the electricity bills, a new railway timetable and the closure of a shop he liked. He began seeing a man who could not bear to hear Gareth's name. They lasted three months.

Charles and Carrie kept their appointment, then another. They disagreed about work, money, where to live and how often Charles asked if she was certain. She found a job involving frequent travel. He left one office and eventually took work in another. There were good months during which they mistook ease for progress, and bad months during which they mistook friction for evidence that everything had been a mistake. Henrietta, whom Charles sometimes thought about when he was being kind to Carrie, had her own work, friends and difficult, unphotographed happiness. She did not need him to know about it.

Underground, changing conditions altered the assembly at different rates. Moisture entered accessible paths. Some joined surfaces restricted movement; others admitted it. Microorganisms encountered material they could use in conditions that permitted their activity. Engineered board and veneer behaved differently. Metal changed according to its composition and surroundings. Some manufactured substances remained after the forms containing them ceased to hold. There was no interval in which all the materials agreed that the event was over.

Quotation version

Being a traveling educator, may I see what books these shelves are lined with? [268] leaving the painting for the others [1386] After four days the plant itself died. [337] The next remove was to the house [41]

“He's right,” a nearby oak tree said. [1250] He kept an umbrella and walking-stick shop [1540] A flood of darkness seemed to wash up and engulf him. [139] when he had finished washing up the cups and mugs [1386] The cup is broken! [331] He must be helped. [1068] In those times just previous to the construction of railways [711] railway folders, time-tables, receipted bills [233] He was not like a man bearing a message of considerable importance to himself. [358] This lasted for several months. [664]

he kept his appointment [317] they disagreed [1520] I think he found a job somewhere. [358] He returned to the office. [645] Eventually, he had to go back to work. [974] And time slipped by, the weeks into months; the sun dwindled and earth was gone. [289] They had evidently made a mistake of some kind. [490] the best judge of her own happiness [42] He had no need to know where she was lodging. [1540]

But in a minute they slid into an underground chamber. [504] the moisture of the air [202] They were under the surface [367] with their perpendicular surfaces joining [404] telling them to use it carefully for scientific purposes only [597] All the verdure was going grey, and was developing a highly singular quality of brittleness. [895] A gleam of metal where metal shouldn't have been. [1325] the form still there but the cell substance gone [855] The day passed nearly without events. [696]

Original

Above ground a hedgehog entered the cemetery through a gap beneath a fence. It moved through grass cut too short to conceal it and found several insects under a border of leaves. During the dry summer it had less food. At the edge of a paved path it encountered a slug that had eaten pellets laid beside a nearby ornamental bed. The slug moved slowly. The hedgehog consumed it. The quantity of toxin transferred was small, but it entered a body already carrying residues from earlier encounters. The animal survived the night and crossed the road at dawn, where it was killed by a delivery van belonging to a company supplying flowers for funeral services. The driver noticed the impact, thought the suspension had struck a loose stone and continued. The flowers reached the cemetery without damage. They were described on the dispatch note as fresh.

In the same summer Matthew came with Grace to place a small stone beside Gareth's plot. She had forgotten her glasses and couldn't read the inscription. Matthew read it aloud. It contained a date chosen for the record and a name that could be pronounced by strangers. Grace asked whether Gareth would have liked the stone. Matthew said he would have complained about the price and shown it to everybody. They stood there longer than either intended. A mower started at the far end of the cemetery. Grace put an arm through Matthew's. Neither wanted the other to stop. When they walked back to the car, Matthew realised he had felt comfortable for almost three minutes and was immediately ashamed. Grace was deciding whether to tell him about the argument she'd had with her husband. She decided not to ruin the occasion and told him anyway. They sat in the car talking while rain began to fall, not particularly heavily, on the newly filled ground.

The rain entered the upper soil and followed the loosened boundaries of the excavation. Some water carried fine particles downward and laterally, changing where oxygen could move. A nematode passed through a film around a grain and encountered a bacterial colony that had expanded around an available nutrient source. It fed and moved on. Other nematodes became food for larger organisms. The forms of interaction changed as the chemistry of the grave changed. No population was waiting to receive the body or to keep it intact. There were opportunities and constraints, deaths, growth, exclusions and movements. At different depths they occurred without common timing. The ground contained many histories, and the burial was one new set of conditions among them. Nothing made them agree.

Quotation version

“I'd swear I saw right through that fence!” he gasped. [1347] he entered through a gap in the fence [664] They found it caught in a bush at the edge of the forest. [717] The grass had been cut, shrubs trimmed, leaves and debris raked. [966] Owing to the fact that the summer was very hot and dry [245] The slugs are crawling in the paths, [664] How slowly it appeared to move! [109] About the hedgehog. [398] It's some alien bug, some toxin. [234] something entered into its body. [251] He killed at dawn,--a pig,--and he has drunk too. [748] he drove on [165] struck against a loose stone. [1144] No damage was discoverable in the shrubbery. [701] They were the ones who got the fresh meat. [1071]

He came to in a place of cold, dry stone. [168] I can’t read it. [592] The latter read it aloud: [1384] The last name has no significance; but the first name is not chosen at random. [341] would have liked that, don't you? [295] Everybody complained about the service. [499] What about the price?" said they. [587] until they stood on a long flat. [825] But how far they were still from the end! [245] she put an arm through his. [626] He is happy and at the same time ashamed of his happiness [247] quarrel with her husband. [21] He told her. [1524] About how their fathers and grandfathers stood in the rain to hear you talk. [757] the rain began to fall [387]

while on the upper portion it was level with the surrounding soil. [1400] Do the particles of water [708] water and oxygen [288] It swept through them like a scythe through ripe grain. [977] bacterial life is going on. [279] No one moved. [1432] Rather larger than the last species. [1324] undergo certain chemical changes [203] At last the body came free. [609] This unfortunate death was the cause of additional troubles. [217] Time under water. different depths in minutes. [7] Burial-grounds appear to have great attractions for this class of spirit. [1043] We have nothing to do with them. [938]

Original

Years passed. *Gareth's coffin* remained a name Matthew and Grace could use to locate a burial. Beneath the ground that name corresponded less and less to a single bounded shape. Some components held their form; others fractured, migrated or changed chemically. A fastening might remain recognisable after the panel it had joined no longer functioned as a panel. No single moment supplied an end to it.

Long after the fourth wedding Charles opened the old wardrobe for a coat. The hinge had been repaired twice, most recently with a larger screw in the damaged hole. He and Carrie had argued that morning about whether to visit her mother. The argument would continue after dinner. He pulled the coat free; the hook shifted under the load. The door moved a fraction and settled. He didn't notice. He was trying to remember whether he'd apologised for the correct thing.

In the flat above the pharmacy, a new tenant put a heavy book on Abdul's shelf. The brackets passed the load into the wall; the wood flexed. A crack in its finish widened near the pale grain. The tenant went to answer the telephone. It was the landlord asking whether the ceiling stain had spread. The tenant said no, although it had. She wanted to avoid another inspection. While they spoke, water was moving through the plaster behind the shelf, slowly enough to remain unnoticed and quickly enough to leave a mark by morning.

The refrigerator switched on. Dust moved through a shaft of late light and settled. A small quantity of moisture remained around a fixing. Metal, plaster and wood bore the added weight. Downstairs the pharmacy closed early because the pharmacist was ill, and the notice on the door directed customers to a number that had been disconnected. The room above it grew dark. The shelf continued to hold.

Quotation version

The years passed. [1510] was duly coffined and laid into the earth [700] there's only one name written on the coffin-cover. [592] each one less in area than that beneath [641] These concretions when broken are seen to be more or less crystalline in structure. [335] The panel may simply be fastened on the back of the frame [1038] the error of a single moment is enough to make one lose eternity. [530]

The coat had been purchased to serve as a wedding garment. [21] Hinges are always screwed on. [902] The damage could be repaired. [1086] He thought what his mother and wife would feel upon such news. [1088] Dinner was a silent affair that period. [18] Then he bent and twisted and pulled off his coat over his head. [439] They pushed open the door and entered. [564] They didn't notice it. [755] "Sorry if I've said the wrong word again," I apologised. [1190]

Instead, he laid it on the table and took a book down from a shelf. [952] Wall Brackets. [1038] such pieces as wall brackets [1038] Through the widening crack I saw a bare [766] "We shall never get another tenant for that house," I answered. [1164] I saw the spreading stain on the ceiling--the bright red stain [117] Nor has he yet had any difficulty in obtaining tenants. [892] She tried to avoid accepting it. [542] Even as they watched, it seemed to mushroom slowly outward. [607]

And they looked into the refrigerator. [923] Now the clouds of dust were slowly settling in the light gravity. [1304] a small quantity of water still remains. [1415] With weight of metal all untold, [1371] The laboratory door I had closed. [1330] the store was closed. [1166] It was just growing dark [787] the support to hold up the shelf [1038]

Original

Years after the funeral, the burial ground was surveyed for a drainage project. The first proposal involved a trench through a row of younger graves, but the records were incomplete and the route was moved. A different line crossed ground where the remains of older, unmarked burials had altered the soil's structure. The contractor had been asked to avoid disturbing known remains. He followed the plan. In the excavated material, metal fittings and mineral fragments appeared among roots, clay and small stones. The operator stopped work when he saw a recognisable piece of carved stone. He was required to call the supervisor. The supervisor called the cemetery manager. There was an enquiry about whether a permit had been breached, and work paused for eleven days. During the pause the open trench filled with rainwater. A beetle fell into it and was taken by a water insect. A frog laid eggs in a shallow section. When work resumed the eggs were pumped into a tanker with silt and deposited elsewhere. The drainage project was eventually completed to specification.

Beneath Gareth's grave, the materials belonging to the former box continued to lose their original relations at different rates. Some parts of the facing lifted from the substrate; some remained attached. The board's adhesive-rich regions resisted processes that affected its exposed fibres. Along paths opened by swelling and mechanical failure, water transported soluble compounds and the products of microbial activity. At a small distance from the burial, those substances entered interactions among soil minerals, roots and organisms already present. Some adsorbed to particles; others were transformed, consumed or carried farther. No single substance could stand for the total process, and the speed of one transformation did not dictate the speed of another. A fastener lay inside a region of material too weak to retain it. It was no longer fastening anything. Its surface continued to change.

Quotation version

was buried with funeral rites in the ground in order that [487] The geological records are incomplete. [483] The Horror in the Burying-Ground [615] The soil is different, the air is different [1289] is known only by his remains [445] His plan succeeded perfectly. [81] would tell of some fragment of fallen mortar or stone. [638] fragments of rock, but also metals [288] “It was right there—I—I saw——” He could not finish. [769] The supervisor may have agreed with him [731] In the cemetery? [1172] Where's your permit? [1267] after an interval of eleven days [335] the men who were filling the trench completed their labours and departed [1384] Perch rose for insects as they fell helpless into the water. [706] It was the frog that did the trick. [877] On schedule, the eggs stopped coming. [1011] Here the eggs are deposited [535] The drainage would especially be affected. [534]

Everything belonging to him had been destroyed. [1491] The mechanical part still remained. [1400] Moisture in wood decreases the stiffness of the fibre walls and enlarges the region of failure. [1139] when their soluble compounds are present in the soil [1364] Some of the compounds it thus forms being soluble in water [716] The minerals and the nitrogen remain in the soil. [279] such substances are mixed with the soil where these roots are [716] all the particles were carried to the centres of the leaves. [337] like a clock shop when each clock strikes the hour insanely before or after the other [172] protoplasm is not a single chemical substance of great complexity [1260] the slightest pressure destroys them [116] for the hunt was no longer anything new. [1434] from the slight change in the surface. [710]

Original

The coffin's manufactured fibres were not all consumed at the same rate as the organic matter beside them. Some synthetic filaments persisted where biological processes removed neighbouring materials. Their surfaces became rougher; some broke into smaller pieces under the combined effects of pressure, chemistry and movement. A microscopic fragment moved with water through a pore and lodged against a root. An organism traversed the space and did not ingest it. Later, when conditions changed, the fragment was released and carried a short distance. It was not a messenger travelling towards a destination. It had no direction beyond the forces acting at each moment. Its continued presence would not be captured by a photograph of an orderly grave.

At the timber yard Leena retired. A younger worker took over the kiln schedule and had less experience of how particular boards warped. A new sensor system reduced the number of damaged boards by adjusting the air supply more frequently. The company announced a twenty-seven per cent improvement and expanded its output. The damaged air filter housing was finally replaced after a fire inspection. Dan had moved to another employer, where the dust was mostly stone and the respirators were newer. He had stopped using his safety mug after the handle broke. Its ceramic fragments entered a skip with plaster, wire and paper. The skip was weighed and sent to a facility that counted recovered material by tonne. One fragment remained in a depression in the floor of the skip. A rainstorm moved it towards the edge, where it caught against a steel rib. It would remain there until the container was overturned again.

Matthew occasionally received letters addressed to Gareth. A financial company had bought an old customer database and was offering products to people who, according to its records, had recently reached an age associated with substantial retirement savings. Matthew called and explained the problem. The agent apologised and marked the account as deceased. Six months later a different company sent Gareth an invitation to review his retirement planning. Matthew laughed, then cried, then made tea. He had stopped expecting these sequences to be predictable. The letters went into a drawer. The drawer's runners stuck in damp weather and released more easily when the heating came on. In the space behind it, a piece of hardened adhesive separated from an old repair and fell onto the floor without a sound.

Quotation version

“It is only organic matter, now,” he said. [364] The synthetic processes which take place in plants are of two types [1364] The other sun-warped and rotten shaft broke. [861] it broke into many pieces. [1443] Water is taken into the plant chiefly from the soil, through its fibrous roots. [1364] In a moment, it had traversed the space between it and the sun. [638] These maimed ones were then carried to a distance and released. [441] without purpose or direction or intelligence. [1235] drift at the mercy of the currents. [1402] For a while, he remained silent, his saturnine face grave with thought. [266]

I think he was retired since then. [753] the late hot weather having warped the boards [77] a younger hand with less experience [378] if the air supply remained unreplenished [202] Twenty-five per cent. [940] had made vast improvements [410] it was then kept carefully to be replaced on the fire whenever a thunderstorm broke [487] It was as if a stone were ground to dust [1519] half-buried in stone-dust and flakes [467] At last he suddenly stopped. [910] It broke short off by the handle. [1194] with a fragment of plaster [414] with fragments of plaster adhering to it [381] He weighed it. [1473] were counted and weighed and paid for. [565] forming the floor of the depression as a whole [80] being caught in a rainstorm [79] the swish of a rainstorm. [1064] with a rib of steel along the back [1038] If I overturned the tube, not a drop of it would remain. [442]

a letter came addressed to him [427] for the man to whom it was addressed was dead. [1141] “I was called on the telephone this morning,” he explained. [741] official apology [486] the sponsors succeeding each other in a revolving list of insurance companies [1339] He laughed till he cried [1332] he made tea [328] proved to be completely unpredictable. [1034] opened a drawer full of letters [461] The drawer clicked as it opened. [259] The bottom drawer stuck fast. [1272] slid noiselessly to the floor. [490]

Original

At the former plantation, the drainage ditch was deepened once more. The new channel improved the yield from a neighbouring field in wet years. It also lowered the water table through a narrow strip of older ground where roots had been growing in a different set of conditions. A stand of small trees began to lose leaves earlier in summer. Insect populations using their foliage changed with the amount and quality of material available. A caterpillar reached its final stage of growth on a branch that dried before it could finish feeding. It descended and entered the litter, where an ant colony attacked it. The caterpillar's remaining tissues became food for larvae within the colony; some of the ants were themselves consumed by a bird which found the exposed nest after a tractor passed. The tractor's operator was trying to keep his machinery away from nesting birds. He steered around an area marked on his map, which did not include the ants.

The field received an environmental stewardship payment for maintaining a strip of wildflowers. A seed mixture was spread on ground whose nutrient levels favoured the quickest-growing plants. Several species established, flowered and produced seed. Others failed before flowering. A warm spring brought pollinators into the strip earlier than usual; a later cold period reduced available nectar and stopped the development of some larvae within neighbouring nests. The surviving insects worked the flowers repeatedly. A visiting photographer took pictures from an angle at which bare patches were not visible. Her editor used the brightest photograph. Beneath it the organisation wrote that habitats had been restored for future generations.

Quotation version

Of High woods, and their plantation. [925] and was encircled by a ditch for drainage. [1323] It should be the same channel, but a new water every instant. [1371] water tables were falling. [61] For the reason that the trees become invisible when they lose their leaves [1400] a qualitative change in the earth brought about a scarcity of food [224] which alter the nature of the insect population so greatly [446] in its own progressive stages of caterpillar [272] Ants are now and then induced to change their residence. [658] a lot of ants with a dead caterpillar [818] supplying the larvae with food as soon as they are hatched [747] the nest itself, swarming with foraging ants. [1185] If you've got your own tractor you'll know what to do if it breaks down. [881] He looked at the Map. [887] He had studied maps of the area [516]

The four fields were treated as follows: Field No. 1 received no sewage. [1046] Would they grow them again, or were they on the ground for good? [1156] plants, flowers, and weeds proliferated luxuriantly [1222] Tree hardy and often produces when others fail. [1413] The larvae of the bluebottle hatch within two days in the warm weather. [442] It was a warm spring day [796] Dependence of flowers on insects for their fertilisation. [91] visible only from the angle at which my gaze struck it. [976] He had been photographed. [374] a legacy of curious material that only future generations may hope to examine.... [1466]

Original

The mine-waste basin above the watercourse remained fenced. Its surface changed colour with weather as different minerals were exposed, dissolved or precipitated. Some plants persisted on small patches where conditions permitted growth. The most vigorous colonists sometimes accumulated elements from the soil in their tissues; insects feeding on them encountered those elements along with nutrients. Invertebrate populations were sparse in one region and dense in another only metres away. A survey company mapped the vegetation. It marked several areas for revegetation and one for exclusion because the substrate was unstable. The exclusion area was covered with temporary fabric held by metal pins. Underneath it, light diminished and temperature changed. Plants already rooted there died. Small animals moved out where they could. Rain eventually undermined two pins. The fabric lifted against the fence, making a sound like applause whenever the wind blew strongly enough. An engineer inspected the site and recommended a more permanent solution. The budget covered another set of pins.

Elsewhere, beside the stream with the floating island, the water ran low enough for a section of the culvert bed to dry. A dark strip of organic material remained where the last water had passed. Larvae stranded in shallow pockets competed for space and food; some entered brief inactive periods and recovered when rain returned, others did not. A beetle hunted among them and was itself taken by a bird. The next storm was hard enough to move stones the insects had used as shelter. Some stones rolled into deeper water, trapping a layer of organisms beneath them. Others lodged at the entrance to the culvert and changed the distribution of flow. The council received a complaint about flooding. Its contractor cleared the stones and entered the work as watercourse resilience. He did not see a dead fish wedged in a cavity below the bridge. By evening, small scavengers had reached the exposed tissue. More rain came the following week.

Quotation version

Remains of other dams still exist. [1514] the sun has turned the exposed surface to a deep buff colour [707] Under nearly all conditions of growth of land plants [1364] It contains valuable food elements that-- [147] elements which have been removed from the soil [858] the scourge of dense populations [441] the region was sparse in its vegetation and niggardly in sentient life. [612] There was always movement in the vegetation here. [469] Thus is marked out a very irregular polygonal area [443] We marked down several spots for subsequent exploration [976] Vermilion fabrics covered a long couch against the wall. [618] The light had changed back, but that didn’t stop her. [322] These plants soon died. [337] These animals were small. [1402] One storm of rain followed hard upon another. [1542] There came a rustling and swaying sound from afar, growing louder as it approached. [316] There were sounds of applause. [246] Then we inspect again. [1251] Give me the pins. [923]

Perhaps we are following the bed of a dried-up stream. [1322] and at low water its bed is nearly dry [744] Outside the compound they found, at last, the trail of his passing. [193] And so the nonparalyzed larvae are attacked during the period of the nymphosis. [442] I was hunting this evil man when my bird died. [1455] A slab of stone in the wall was moving. [765] had taken shelter from the storm [100] This is the water falling gently over the mossy hatch and splashing faintly on the stones beneath [707] The sewage flows through one, the others being charged with air. [425] The First of the Council spoke again. [780] there were stones and roots to be dug up and cleared away [587] He didn't seem to see the jelly -fish. [69] They sat together feasting till the evening. [39] There was more rain to come. [1380]

Original

The old school playground, meanwhile, was renewed. The rubber surface was lifted in sections. Fine dark particles had accumulated in the sub-base and at the drain, where earlier inspections had not required them to be sampled. The contractor removed most of the surface and a portion of the material beneath it. Fresh material was laid. A brighter sign announced an investment in children's wellbeing. During a school assembly the headteacher congratulated pupils on keeping their environment clean. The children clapped. Outside, a wind carried dust from the old surface towards a hedge. Some particles lodged on leaves, others entered the street. A small spider built a web across the hedge's outer branches. Several gnats struck the silk and were eaten. The dust neither made the spider virtuous nor disqualified it from surviving. A bird later tore the web apart while taking the spider.

On the burial ground's edge, the young tree whose roots had been severed during excavation eventually died during a dry summer. Its crown thinned, a section of bark separated and wood-boring insects entered the exposed tissue. A fungus advanced through the weakened wood. The grounds department cut the trunk down after a visitor reported that its upper branches might fall. An inspection confirmed the risk. The trunk was divided into short lengths and placed in a pile to be removed. A beetle emerged from one and flew towards the afternoon light, where it was taken by a swift. The bird fed the beetle to a nestling that had not received enough food during two days of rain. The nestling swallowed it and remained alive for another week. On its first flight it struck a window installed to give an office building more natural light. The building had won an environmental design award. A caretaker removed the body before staff arrived and put a black silhouette of a bird against the glass. He ordered three more decals online. Two adhered properly. The third fell into the planting bed, where rain pressed it against leaves until it was covered by mulch.

Quotation version

was the old school building [130] They were being lifted out and over the pits. [388] The night was dark, and a fine, steady rain was falling. [1401] Rain-water, oozing down the burrows would also carry fine dark-coloured particles into every crevice. [335] But, after all, cannot the materials removed be simply shot back as the work proceeds? [445] The materials he had on him. [286] That is the hope of my brighter moments. [1] They looked with envy at the clean and well-dressed school children [1172] The children squealed and clapped their hands and cried: [1208] The wind came from the north with sleet on its back. [16] Particles were placed on four leaves [337] Watch a spider building its wonderful geometrical web. [1393] Along the hedgerow there are several spiders' webs. [709] These little spiders probably fed on minute insects entangled in the web [91] so long as dust and damp and spiders spare him [378] torn the water-spider's nest and crushed the spider herself. [439]

Close before me was the dead tree with its pile of bones. [310] A large tree in the forest dies and falls to the ground. [279] their upper branches are dry. [116] the layers of wood, exposed by these insects [658] You know what happens to fungus that grows in the dark. [170] the upper branches dying down while the trunk rots away beneath [661] very many are cut down, and when the trunk is lying on the ground [333] Didn't it occur to you this might be dangerous? [570] the trunk of a tree barked in long strips and splintered deeply. [1463] the insect darts off faster than an arrow. [446] For two days no food was brought me [202] diminish the food supply of insectivorous and nestling birds [1416] This the young bird would take and instantly swallow [661] like a lot of survival, when you come to think of it. [1527] A small window gave light. [95] one struck against a neighbor's window [989] And there's no question that the award is deserved. [150] a ray of light from without made it stand out like a silhouette [664] He gave his orders. [1402] to which paper still adhered [728] Was this the pattering rain, the dripping of the leaves? [128] suddenly the rain fell; it pattered against the green leaves. [466]

Original

Several winters later Matthew passed the office building without knowing any of this. He was going to have lunch with a person he had begun to love, and the prospect unsettled him. He stopped at a crossing because the light was red, although there was no traffic. The person he was meeting had sent a message asking if he would be late. Matthew wrote, *Possibly. It's become a tradition.* He crossed when the signal changed. The road surface retained tyre marks from a vehicle which had braked sharply the previous night. Along its edge, water entered a gutter and moved beneath a grate. A thin piece of pale fabric caught there. It might have come from a garment, a cleaning cloth or packaging. Nothing about its present shape made the answer available. Water lifted it, pressed it down, and moved on through the space beside it.

The water behind the pharmacy wall continued entering the timber shelf's fixings. At first the change affected only the plaster surrounding the upper screw. Later a minute crack spread through the painted surface and opened a path for air and water. Fungi occupied the damp region when conditions allowed, withdrawing where it dried. The screw, originally chosen for an anchor that had held well, began transferring its load through a smaller area of sound material. The shelf still carried books. A houseplant was placed upon it. Its pot contained cultivated soil with fragments of older leaves, living roots and organisms bought with the plant from a nursery. Water drained from the pot and entered the pale band of wood Abdul had preserved beneath the finish. The mark changed shape over several weeks. The tenant noticed a darkening but assumed it was old. The landlord agreed. Both were willing to be persuaded by a surface that had been made to look natural.

One night a book fell from the shelf while nobody was in the room. Its weight had shifted after another book was removed, and the shelf had tilted enough for the hard cover to slide. The fall made a sound that startled the tenant awake. She entered the room and found the book lying open. She looked for a person who could have moved it, then for a mouse. There was nobody. She picked it up, put it on a table and returned to bed. The shelf remained attached to the wall. The crack behind it had widened slightly. By morning a small quantity of plaster dust lay on the floor. More would accumulate before the fixing finally failed. The book stayed open on the table until someone needed the space and closed it.

Quotation version

I passed his office window [382] spent several winters in that city. [862] The falling evening again confused his prospects, and unsettled his hopes. [1135] He stopped for a street light [47] He stopped at the crossing [1522] but there was no traffic [27] wondering whether it were late [915] Message after message was sent to him [23] He agreed that he might. [45] As such it would have passed into tradition. [1488] He gave the signal: now. [1261] A rough bit of road beneath the motor tyres [477] It had rained, and a cheerless stream dropped down a dirty gutter. [419] partly covered with fragments of clothing [110] a cloth-covered button was missing from that garment [799] the outward appearance gives it no information [441] It was floating on the water. [664] or the slipping of a liquid down an inclined plane. [298]

At first the water would have made the wood swell so as to close the hole [128] The upper screw is the fine adjustment. [406] The plaster surrounding the slab was easily crumbled [1394] appeared a shining crack [977] the water issues through the crack. [986] the cracks and fissures of the plaster. [915] From such moisture grow all tubera and fungi. [1196] The damp on them dried quickly. [1211] held in position by powerful screws. [1400] but the anchor held well. [744] the shelves of strange books [893] Who had placed it there? [239] he cultivated a pot of flowers [664] and the fallen leaves composed the soil which nourished the roots. [156] A piece of wood falling into water, gradually absorbs the liquid into its pores, and swells. [708] it constantly changed its shape [713] old and stained. [1332] “Immediately,” replied the landlord. [664] made everything look as natural as possible again [560]

Something else fell from the shelf. [833] The book fell open wide [1009] a book not replaced on the shelf [400] when she was startled by the sound of something heavy falling. [255] the book was open at the second part. [239] It looks like mice. [922] There was nobody about--nobody at all. [704] she returned to her bed [411] She picked it up [1475] We always put things back where they belonged. [690] There were shelves on the wall containing what appeared to be books [906] First it was only a crack; then rapidly it widened. [977] dust lay thick on the floor and reddened the once-white walls. [1094] And the notes accumulate. [1519] closing the book that lay open upon the table. [254] for there was the book open on the table beside her [1134]

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